Twice Bitten

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/18046961.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra), Spinnerella (She-Ra), Netossa (She-Ra), Castaspella (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Action/Adventure, Romance, Horror, Nightmare Fuel, Virus, Cross-Posted on FanFiction.Net, Creepy, Transformation, Adora (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, Catra (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, Angst with a Happy Ending, all be explained in later chapters, Catra (She-Ra) Redemption, Post-Season/Series 01, Canon Divergence

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by CadillacJack

Summary

Catra figured that infecting Adora with Entrapta's data crystal would guarantee the Horde victory. She never thought she'd have to save the world from her ex-best friend.

Notes

Well here we go again with another She-Ra story!

But unlike the last two, this one will be a multi-chaptered story. So hope you all enjoy!

Part 1

Change.

It was perhaps the one thing that irked Catra more than anything.

Growing up in the Horde had presented Catra with an unchanging and predictable schedule that she had come to expect.

Wake up, pass morning inspection, eat breakfast, perform several training exercises, eat lunch, more combat training, eat dinner, shower and sleep.

Rinse and repeat.

But although this particular routine was far from exciting, there was one constant thing that Catra always looked forward to.

Adora.

Whenever she woke up at the foot of the bed, Adora's face was always there to greet her. Whenever she was expected to eat her tasteless gruel, Adora would always be there to sit with her. And when combat practice came, you could be sure that Catra would pick Adora as her sparring partner. Sure they played pranks on each other and made fun of each other's personalities, but they always managed to share a good laugh about it later and carry on like nothing happened.

That was until two months ago, when Adora first found the mystical sword in the woods and became the legendary She-Ra.

From then on, everything in Catra's world changed for the worst. Her best friend betrayed their cause, abandoned her for the Princess Alliance, failed to protect her from Shadow Weaver's wrath and had defeated her in battle time and time again.

All the while, Catra found herself waking up alone, eating alone and simply being more alone. This, along with Shadow Weaver's

increasing wrath against her, made the poor girl pray that this whole thing was just one bad dream and that she would wake up by Adora's side yet again.

But as the weeks passed, Catra slowly came to a realization that hardened her heart and destroyed her soul.

Adora was never coming back.

These changes and more had greatly troubled the young feline and had caused her more than one sleepless night.

But she couldn't deny that there were some changes that had worked in her favor.

With Adora gone, Catra had been able to achieve the rank of Force Captain, rope Entrapta into the Horde's army (allowing for their tech to become far more advanced); remove Shadow Weaver from power, as well as her power from the Black Garnett, and achieved the title of second in command from Lord Hordak himself.

The role of second in command had undeniably granted her more than her fair share of perks. These included her own private quarters, more generous and better tasting foods, an endless supply of alcohol and the ability to participate in Hordak's various meetings where she could cast her opinion on how they could overthrow the Princess Alliance.

But perhaps the one thing she liked most about the new position was the respect (or was it fear?) she garnered from her once former comrades.

Growing up, Catra had always been the subject of ridicule from others. When she was a child, the other children would pull her tail, rub her fur the wrong way or even put gum in her fur when she was asleep. Thankfully these incidents stopped once she and everyone else reached adulthood. Having Adora threaten everyone with a broken jaw if they touched Catra again hadn't hurt either.

But even after reaching maturity, Catra still felt like an outcast among her peers. Whenever she passed by them in the halls, or even in the locker room, she could feel their judgmental eyes stab her in the back. Her enhanced hearing made her overhear their hushed whispers.

"God what a freak!"

"You think she'll return to her home planet soon?"

"Did you hear that she eats mice?"

But after achieving the title of Second in Command, Catra felt the air around her change. All of a sudden, everyone she passed by immediately threw up their hands in salute and pressed themselves against the wall. Their faces were always forcefully smiling and although she couldn't prove it conclusively, Catra never heard a single person talk behind her back when she was around.

"Now this is the kind of change I could get used to," Catra thought to herself as she walked down the hallway.

Although being Second in Command involved having way more responsibilities than a Force Captain, Catra found that her schedule was far more relaxed than before. No longer did she have to wake up at the crack of dawn or go through several mandatory training exercises. Her new schedule allowed her more freedom to perform tasks that she deemed necessary.

And checking to see if any of Entrapta's toys could win the war sooner rather than later seemed to be a worthy venture.

As the doors slid open, Catra caught the genius in question welding two pieces of indistinguishable tech with her human hands. Her hair hands meanwhile were typing at rapid speed on a computer nearby.

Scorpia meanwhile was standing on the other side of the room, scribbling furiously in her notepad.

"Probably another stick figure family," Catra rolled her eyes before she cleared her throat.

This simple action caused the two to immediately stop what they were doing and run towards Catra.

"Good morning Second in Command Catra!" Scorpia and Entrapta said in unison as they saluted.

Catra smiled slightly. She personally didn't give a damn if they saluted her or not but she loved having the extra power.

"So what's the 411 on this new weapon you're working on?" Catra asked Entrapta as she walked past Scorpia.

"Oh I've made great strides so far!" Entrapta cried as she raced over to her workstation. "In fact you're just in time to witness my baby's first trial run."

Entrapta pulled out a blueberry muffin (from where Catra decided she didn't need to know) and placed it through a small hole. The purple haired genius closed the lid and pushed a small button.

Catra shielded her eyes as a bright flash filled the room. When the light dimmed, Catra lowered her arms to find Entrapta taking out the muffin, which by now was 1/3 of its original size, before throwing it into her mouth. Catra stared dumbfounded as Entrapta pulled out a recorder.

"Fright Zone Log day 137, Operation Tiny Food has been a complete success! I think with time I can…"

"WHAT THE HELL IS THIS?" Catra yelled.

Entrapta reacted to Catra's outburst like a fly buzzed past her face. "The angry cat lady seems aggravated by something, although I'm not sure by what."

"You were supposed to use your knowledge of First One's Tech to build us another super weapon! One that can allow us to

overthrow the rebellion like today!"

"Well we were," Scorpia added. "But then Entrapta started going on about tiny food and how that's the only thing she eats and I thought 'Hey I'm trying to watch my weight so maybe if I just eat tiny food I could eat less calories. Then I asked her if she could make a device and…"

"I get it!" Catra shouted, desperately trying to avoid using her claws on the two Princesses.

Catra pinched the bridge of her nose and controlled her breathing as she paced back and forth.

"Of all the people I got working for me I had to get the absent minded professor and a happy go lucky scorpion."

Catra finally slowed her pace and glanced back at the two females who by now were slightly cowering back in fear.

"Look," Catra quietly spoke, her anger bubbling just below the surface. "I know you love to play with your little toys Entrapta but you work for me now. I'm the boss and what I say goes. And right now I'm telling you to stop this tiny food bullshit and BUILD SOMETHING THAT WILL ALLOW US TO CONQUER ETHERIA!"

While Scorpia cowered further in terror, Entrapta blinked her eyes rapidly before she turned to her recorder again.

"The loud furry raises some very good points. I feel that following her directions will prevent her from developing an aneurysm." Entrapta turned back to Catra. "Consider it done! I promise you something that will blow your mind by the end of the day."

"And I promise that you won't be disappointed!" Scorpia added as she pulled Catra into another bear hug.

Catra pulled herself out of Scorpia's grasp and started walking towards the door. Entrapta suddenly leapt out in front of her, holding a regular sized cupcake.

"Are you sure though you don't want a mini cupcake though? I can arrange the frosting to look like a smiley face!"

Catra ripped the cupcake out of Entrapta's hands and threw it across the room. It flew towards a table with various items scattered about. The speed of the cupcake had been so fast that it caused several trinkets to be knocked off.

Catra was about to leave when she saw something out of the corner of her eye. It appeared to be a data crystal, similar to the one she had retrieved from the temple, only this one was green in color and had several white markings adorning its surface.

"Um…what is this?" Catra asked.

Entrapta's face glowed like a child on Christmas morning. "That happens to be First Ones Artifact No.58! The residents of Dryl found it in the mines several months ago. I analyzed it shortly afterwards and the amount of First Ones code on it was unbelievable!"

"First Ones code huh?" Catra replied as her interest peaked.

"Uh-huh! At the time I was analyzing it I was on the brink of translating a whole plethora of code that could've explained so many secrets of the First Ones!"

"Ooh secrets?!" Scorpia squealed. "I love secrets! What kinds were on there?"

"It could have been anything from where they came from, how their technology works or even just how far their influence was felt across the universe! Of course I would've known for sure until…"

"Until…" Catra waved her hand impatiently.

"Until my data crystal inexplicably infected all of my robots with some kind of virus. It turned them against me and my staff. They wouldn't stop until we were all alienated. Luckily, Adora happened

to be there along with Glimmer and Bow. And even though Adora was out of commission, we managed to overpower them and Bow destroyed the crystal with his Sonic Arrow. I then agreed to be part of the Rebellion and afterwards…"

"Whoa! Whoa! Whoa! Back up! What was that about Adora?" Catra asked trying to stop the genius from going off on a tangent.

Entrapta retraced her mental steps. "Well She-Ra, I mean Adora, tried to save me from one of my robots. But when she stabbed one of the crystals; the virus spread into her sword and…infected her with whatever was within the crystal. When she reverted back to her…less tall self…it significantly reduced her mental capacity and made the simple action of standing difficult."

Catra listened to the whole explanation with a smile that grew wider and wider.

"So you're saying that Adora was…incompatible?"

Entrapta laughed. "In her state I think my robot with no arms and legs was more useful than she was."

Catra was about to inquire further about Adora's condition when Scorpia spoke up.

"Wait if the crystal was destroyed, how is it still in one piece?"

"Oh well," Entrapta rubbed the back of her neck. "The crystal's fragments were all still in one place so I just fused them together again."

Catra and Scorpia's expressions were blanker than an empty page.

"I just thought that whatever virus was in the crystal was neutralized after it was destroyed the first time," Entrapta replied before smiling ear to ear. "Plus this crystal holds so much potential data that we may never see again! The secrets that I could

decipher from this crystal could help us determine everything about the First One's!"

"Wow that sounds great!" Scorpia cheered before she grew puzzled. "But if this all happened at Dryl, what is the crystal doing here?"

Entrapta laughed. "Oh I had one of my drone bots fly over to my lab and grab some of my equipment. I intended to analyze it sooner but then Catra gave me that other data crystal and she wanted to hack the planet and…"

By now the conversation became all but white noise to Catra as she continued to entertain a particular thought.

"If what she says about this crystal junk is true, I could make it so that Adora would be useless to fight! I could just infect Adora with the crystal and she would literally walk back to the Horde base with me hand in hand. No Adora, no She Ra. No She Ra, no Rebellion. No rebellion…victory."

Catra eventually came back to her senses and found Scorpia and Entrapta staring at her in confusion.

"Catra are you alright?" Scorpia asked. "You seem so…distant."

Catra smirked and stepped over to the cluttered table. "Oh I just thought of a way that we could get Adora and that damned sword right in the palm of our hands."

Scorpia grasped her claws together. "Really?! Wow I wish I thought of it! Uh…what did you think of anyway?"

"Just something that will make sure that little Miss Perfect never bothers us again," Catra replied as she picked up the green data crystal. "And it will be all thanks to this little rock."

Entrapta slowly nodded before the realization hit her. "I never did understand how the virus made She-Ra sick when it generally

affects machinery! This will be the perfect opportunity to find out once I've dissected her!"

Catra snapped her head back in shock, walked over to Entrapta and pointed a claw directly in her face.

"Adora is a person, not a frog. You do not lay a finger on her understood?"

Entrapta nodded slowly in disappointment, remembering how Glimmer has very much against the idea as well.

"I can still take apart the Sword and look at that right?!" Entrapta asked excitedly.

Catra expression lightened. "It would be my honor."

Entrapta laughed crazily as she began typing furiously into her computer.

"Oh boy! Oh boy! Oh boy! This is the most exciting day of my life! I can crack the code and study a virus all in the same…"

Entrapta paused as she suddenly thought about something that she just couldn't shake off.

"Uhh…how exactly are you going to get Adora infected again?"

Catra smirked as she began combing Entrapta's hair with her claws.

"You just leave that to me."

Part 2

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora sighed for the 20th time today as she glanced around the Whispering Woods.

The once lush and green grass had begun turning yellow and still bore the tracks of several Horde vehicles. Many of the trees' branches, which once held several bundles of thick leaves, had broken off and lay scattered all over the ground. And while most of the trees themselves remained standing, there were still others that were either completely uprooted or mere stumps.

But what really unsettled the young warrior, was the complete and utter silence. True to its name, the Whispering Woods had often whispered multiple things, of which Adora was never able to decipher, through the air. She could also remember hearing several animals going about their daily business such as birds chirping or squirrels squeaking.

But the aftermath of the Horde's advances had left the area completely silent. The animals had long since vacated the area and the whispers had all but ceased. It all gave the forest a cold and dead vibe.

Growing up, Adora remembered the Horde's mentality of never being sorry for what you were doing and that everything you did was the right choice. But the combination of living in BrightMoon and not having the Horde's philosophy shoved down her throat, had allowed the young girl to really question her actions both in the past and in the present.

Although Swift Wind had convinced her to rejoin Glimmer and Bow, instead of beating herself up and remaining within the temple, a small part of her still wondered if becoming She-Ra had done more harm than good.

While she did save Etheria from the Black Garnett's power, reunite the Princess Alliance and brought back a sense of hope for Queen Angella and thousands of others, she also made her best friend stray further into the dark side, allowed Glimmer and Bow to be kidnapped, led Entrapta to her untimely demise, had gotten Glimmer infected with whatever Shadow Weaver had used on her and turned the Whispering Woods into a shell of its former self.

She sometimes wondered if the First Ones had made a mistake when they chose her to become the legendary She-Ra. Surely there must've been other Horde cadets that could've taken on the role and done a better job. The sword could've gone to someone who could pull off more missions without making a single mistake, with zero casualties.

Although she didn't have these kind of thoughts often, seeing the ruins of the woods made her anxiety beat her down full swing.

Realizing that she was hyperventilating, Adora placed her hand against a worn down tree and started to take a few deep breaths. Her mind anchored back to the quiet stillness of the woods and her reason for being there in the first place.

With the Whispering Woods in near complete ruin, Queen Angella knew that there was nothing stopping the Horde from trying to take over Etheria or plan another assault on her kingdom. Fortunately, Adora and the others had successfully prevented them from conquering several lands while also providing humanitarian relief when needed. At the same time however, they had all ventured into the woods to survey the damage and, possibly anyways, find a solution to restore it to its former glory.

On this particular day however, the other Princesses were forced to attend to their respective kingdoms. As a result, Adora had planned to survey the area herself. Naturally, Glimmer and Bow had vouched to accompany her; no doubt fearful of what might befall her if she was alone. But Adora had given them a reassuring smile and told them she could easily handle anything that came her way.

"What could happen?" Adora remembered saying to the duo earlier.

When she felt her breathing even out, Adora placed a hand on a tree, its wood now brittle and dry.

"I'm sorry," Adora spoke, unsure of whether she meant this to the forest or herself. "I know I caused this in one way or another, but we're all trying to fix this. I promise I'll make it right someday. I promise."

The sound of a twig snapping caused Adora's head to snap up and look around fearfully. She immediately took out her sword and held it high in the air.

"For the Honor of Greyskull!"

And in one bright flash of light, the legendary She-Ra came into existence.

Adora took a few steps forward as she monitored her settings. The forest was as quiet as the grave.

Adora slightly lowered her sword and took a few steps back only to bump into something indistinguishable. She turned and found herself starring into a pair of heterochromatic eyes.

"Hey Adora."

Adora shrieked and fell back onto the ground.

Catra, who up till now was hanging from the branch with her tail, pulled herself up into a crouching position.

"Wow first you transform at the slightest noise then you freak out just by seeing me? I think rabbits are less timid than you are." Catra laughed.

Adora narrowed her eyes as she grabbed the sword and got back on her feet.

"Catra? What are you doing here?"

Catra playfully shrugged. "What? Can't we just talk?

"Last time you 'just wanted to talk' you had five Horde tanks aimed straight at me," Adora replied, her expression unchanging.

Catra sighed in content and smirked. "Oh wasn't that just the best? Good times."

Adora's sword stayed pointed in Catra's direction.

"Something's going on," Adora thought. "I only wish I knew what it was about."

Suddenly, Catra leapt off the branch and landed only a couple feet away from Adora.

"Alas, I am actually here on business. I want you in the Horde dungeon by the end of the day," Catra stated in a familiar acidic tone.

Adora nearly laughed out loud at the bluntness of her former best friend. Usually she at least tried to egg her on into a fight before announcing her plans.

"Catra," Adora spoke before Catra interrupted her.

"Wait, wait wait, I know this one!" Catra cleared her throat before she put her hand against her face and spoke in a higher pitch. "Oh Catra I don't want you to fight me because I know you have a good heart and you don't belong in the Horde and blah, blah, blah, blah, blah."

Adora's face dropped as she tried to say something back. "That's…that's not how I sound at all!"

"Yep, just keep telling yourself that," Catra shrugged.

Adora narrowed her eyes again. "Look, I don't know what game you're playing Catra but I have more important things to do than bicker with you! In case you haven't noticed the Whispering Woods looks like hell! Thanks to someone deciding to run an entire Horde brigade through, we're at our wits end trying to make it better!"

Catra's expression darkened and her claws grew to their full length. "If you're expecting an apology Adora…you'll have to beat it out of me."

And in the blink of an eye, Catra leapt forward and took a mighty swipe with her claws. Fortunately, Adora had grown accustomed to Catra's surprise attacks and was able to block her claws with the sword.

The resulting sparks had barely touched the ground before Catra took another swipe. Once again Catra's claws struck the sword with such force that it nearly knocked it out of Adora's hands. Adora quickly dropped down to one knee and landed an all mighty punch to Catra's stomach.

Caught completely off guard, Catra cried out in agony as she flew through the air.

After landing with a hard thump, Catra got on all fours and began coughing violently, desperately trying to refill her lungs with oxygen. Once she got her breathing to a steady pace, Catra glanced up to see her ex-best friend starring down at her with a look of determination, yet with a familiar hint of sadness, in her eyes.

"I don't want to hurt you Catra. But you keep throwing yourself into situations where I could easily do so. All I want is a way to stop the Horde from destroying Etheria and I know somewhere deep down…you feel the same way."

Catra wearily got back on her feet before a familiar smirk came across her face. "Tch…same old Adora. Always wanting to play the

hero. Always thinking she can save everybody. Did it ever occur to you that maybe I don't want to be saved Adora? Once you left I achieved so much more than I would've if I was just your sidekick! I mean...I made Force Captain and Second in Command all in the same month! And now everyone actually treats me with respect instead of just throwing me off to the side. Sound familiar?"

Adora felt the familiar sting in her heart as Catra played the abandonment card yet again.

"Catra I always respected you! I was probably the only one who did care about you growing up! You think Hordak or anyone else in the upper chain genuinely cared about you? About me? We were just pawns in their twisted game! They never treated us like a family or even as friends! They just wanted to morph us into heartless killing machines. Something I know you definitely aren't!"

Adora paused as she felt a few tears run down her cheeks. She quickly wiped them away before she put her brave face back on.

"I've said it before Catra and I'll say it again, I never wanted you to think you were second best. I always saw you as an equal!"

Catra snorted but Adora continued as she held out her hand.

"And if you come back with me to BrightMoon, I'll make sure you're treated just the way you should be!"

"Right cause that'll go over so well. Hey everyone here's the person who nearly destroyed BrightMoon and killed everyone! Let's throw a parade in her honor and accept her into the rebellion because the jolly blonde giant said so!"

Catra laughed but stopped when she noticed Adora's hardened expression. Her steady hand was still stretched out before her. Catra was just about to turn around, and launch another surprise attack, when an idea suddenly presented itself. Catra softened her expression and took Adora's hand into her own. Adora's face

dropped at her former friend's sudden actions. But just before she could voice her questions, Adora heard a quiet and eerie laugh erupting from Catra's throat before it escalated into a full blown cackle.

Adora felt her heart slowly sink into her stomach. "What's so funny?"

Catra's laughter died down before an expression of dark glee crossed her face. "Oh Adora. Sweet, sweet, dumb Adora. What's rule number 10 of combat training?"

Being one of the Horde's best fighters, Adora naturally came up with the answer.

"Always keep your eyes on the opponent, especially all of their body parts because you never know when one could just…"

Adora's voice caught in her throat as she glanced down. While Catra's right hand was still gripping her own, Catra's left hand was next to the turquoise jewel within the Sword. And it was holding a familiar green data crystal. Adora's eyes became as wide as dinner plates as the unpleasant memories of Dryl came flooding back.

No sooner had the crystal been placed against jewel, its color changed into a blood red color. Several thick tentacles of the same color oozed out into the jewel and all around the sword. Adora's breathing became shallow as she glanced up at Catra who by now was leaning against a tree, smirking.

"Catra…"

Adora never had a chance to finish. A sudden, sharp wave of electricity surged through her body. A bloodcurdling scream ripped from her throat as Adora felt her muscles become fire while her blood became liquid magma.

Catra's smirk immediately disappeared. Although she had been fighting against Adora for some time, and gradually came to

accept her as an arch enemy, it still pained her to hear someone she used to care about (or maybe still cared about?) in such pain.

After what felt like hours, Adora's screams ceased and she morphed back into her normal self. Adora turned her back on Catra before she fell face first onto the cold and unforgiving ground. Faint traces of smoke poured from her body.

All was silent.

Catra waited silently, expecting Adora to get back on her feet, fight back, groan or do something that indicated that she was alright. But when the blonde's body didn't move, Catra's heart began to race.

"Adora?

Silence.

"Adora?!"

Silence still greeted her.

"ADORA?!"

Catra's eyes became misty eyed as she rushed forward and knelt by Adora's side. The slight odors of burning hair and flesh greeted her nose. Catra tried desperately to shake the Adora's body to no avail.

"Adora! Adora listen to me! You are not dying! You hear me? You can't be dead!" By now Catra was pounding Adora's back with her fists. "You can't be dead! YOU CAN'T BE DEAD! COME BACK TO ME! WAKE UP! WAKE UP! WAKE UP!"

When her body still refused to show any signs of life, Catra stepped back in fear as she felt the world spinning around her.

"Oh my God, Oh, my God, Oh my God!" Catra spoke quietly to herself. "What've I done? What am I gonna do? This wasn't

supposed to happen! Adora's not supposed to die! She can't die; she's She-Ra for fuck sakes! Entrapta didn't mention this rock would kill her! When I get my hands on that idiot's neck I'll rip it…"

Catra's rambling would've continued had she not heard something that, at least at the moment, was probably the most beautiful sound in the world.

Adora slowly groaning.

Catra's heart skipped a beat and her shoulders became infinitely lighter as she spun around to see Adora now on all fours and slowly catching her breath. Catra's first instinct was to throw her arms around her so tight that she'd never leave her again. But the intellectual side of her brain reminded her that she had a mission to complete and that nothing, not even her feelings for the girl, where going to get in the way.

Catra shook her head and walked back over to Adora who was still on all fours.

"God damn it Adora you nearly gave me a heart attack!" Catra shouted, trying desperately to not have her voice crack. "Now get your sorry ass up so we can get back to the Horde."

Catra had often fantasized about this particular moment: having the legendary She-Ra beneath her feet, the odds falling in her favor and the euphoria of having being able to crush Adora's ego and finally best her at something. She had fantasized about it so much that she often thought about what Adora would say and do immediately afterwards. She would probably look up at her with those sad, puppy dog eyes as she pleaded for mercy. She'd then try to reinstate that she wasn't truly evil and that she should join the Princess Alliance. All the while, Catra would smile, having been able to make Adora feel what she had felt like for the past two months.

But the last thing that Catra expected Adora to do was laugh.

But that's exactly what happened.

A cold, hollow laugh filled the air around Catra. It started off slow but gradually escalated in both scale and volume.

Catra's fur bristled and her heart began to race as the horrible sound filled her ears. She could remember hearing Adora's laughter before. It sounded fun, warm and full of life. But now it sounded similar to a crazed lunatic that had just cornered their latest victim.

Somehow, Catra found the courage to take a few steps forward and clear her throat.

"A-A-Adora," Catra asked in a shaky voice. "Are y-y-you okay?"

Adora's laughter abruptly stopped. She gripped the sword tightly in her hands and slowly got to her feet with her back still turned.

"Okay?"

Adora's head suddenly snapped back a full 180 degrees. Her face was twisted in a crazed expression and her eyes were blood red. Catra wanted to scream, cry out or run away but all she could do was watch in silent horror.

"I'm better than okay Catra. I've felt better than I have in a long time."

A sudden flash of light caused Catra to let out a cry of surprise and raise her hands up to her eyes. When she felt the flash die down, Catra lowered her hands and blinked rapidly. Thankfully the bright flash hadn't stolen her vision, but when she saw what was in front of her she almost wished that it had.

Adora was once again in the guise of She-Ra but with vast differences. Her skin had turned from a slightly pale complexion into a sickly bluish color. Her fingernails were now sharp, black claws that would put Catra's to shame. Her once flowing blonde hair was now as black as the darkest of nights. Her golden tiara

had turned blood red and was covered in several, sharp thorns. Her once crisp, white outfit with gold trimmings had changed into a dark purple with crimson trimmings. Adora's once bright red cape had distorted into a scary shade of cobalt blue. Both her boots and her arm gauntlets had turned jet black and while her sword looked relatively the same, the jewel was still pulsing with a red glow as several fleshly tentacles ran up and down the blade.

But the thing that scared Catra the most about her friend's new appearance was her eyes. Her once sky blue eyes were now completely black, save for the two small red pupils directly in the center.

All the while, the new She-Ra's expression was the exact same as before: complete and utter madness with a side bloodlust for anything in its path.

Catra was so frightened by this drastic turn of events, she couldn't open her mouth to scream or force her legs to run in the other direction.

Not even when the demon disguised as She-Ra stepped toward her in a slow, threatening manner.

Adora grabbed Catra by the neck so hard that the latter could barely get an air into her lungs. Adora slammed Catra violently into a tree as her claws dug into the feline's skin.

Adora's haunting eyes looked into Catra's wide, shaking heterochromatic eyes as it whispered in a cold, emotionless tone.

"Hey Catra."

Chapter End Notes

Well that escalated quickly

Part 3

Chapter Notes

> Sorry it took me a little longer to get this chapter out but I always like to give myself a bit of a break when I post new chapters. After all, don't wanna suffer burnout or anything. :)
>
> But anyway let's get to it!
>
> Enjoy!

Bow often considered himself a practical and patient kind of guy.

Whether on the battlefield, or in the various Rebellion meetings, the young archer often managed to keep his cool.

But the sight of Glimmer pacing back and forth was becoming a strong contender for driving his patience out the window.

Adora had been gone now for over an hour.

Earlier, Glimmer and Bow had been making care packages for the survivors of a recently torn down village. But as Glimmer noticed that over half-an-hour had passed, without seeing their blonde friend, hundreds of worst case scenarios began polluting the young girl's mind. Despite Bow's efforts to calm her down, Glimmer abandoned her duty all together and began pacing back and forth in worry.

Bow himself became nervous when Adora failed to show. Although she didn't give an exact time of when she'd be back, he remembered how Adora never stayed too long in the Whispering Woods, maybe 30 minutes at most. For her to be gone this long was quite unusual. Surely she would have gotten them, or even the Queen herself, if something was amiss.

Despite his rabbit hole of worries, Bow still tried to remain positive. Maybe Adora just decided to perform a larger scope of

the forest. Or maybe she was providing aid to a village that he didn't know existed. Or perhaps she had been captured in a surprise ambush by the Horde.

Bow shook himself out of his fantasies, got up and approached Glimmer. But the young girl was so caught up in her worries that she ended up walking straight into him.

"Oh sorry Bow!" Glimmer apologized, snapped out of her trance. "I guess I just have a lot on my mind right now."

"It's about Adora isn't it," Bow asked.

Glimmer sighed. "I don't know what's taking her so long! It was just a simple recon mission. Shouldn't she be back by now?"

A sense of déjà vu came over Bow as he placed his hands on Glimmer's shoulders. "Glimmer it'll be alright. Adora's probably just scouring more of the forest. It's a big area after all."

Glimmer's breath became shaky. "But wouldn't she have let us now that she was gonna be gone longer? I mean…it sounded like she was only going to be gone for about half-an-hour and it's been over an hour now!" Glimmer breathed deeply. "I'm sorry. You probably think I'm overreacting."

Bow rubbed her shoulders. "No of course not! I'm worried too but until we know for sure we have to keep believing that Adora will be alright. If we keep thinking that something positive will happen then chances are that it will!"

Glimmer slowly nodded.

"Besides Swift Wind said that he could sense when Adora was in danger. So if she really was in danger, wouldn't he be rushing through the door right about…"

The white horse burst through the large double doors in a panic. "Glimmer! Bow! We have to go right now!"

"You just had to jinx it, didn't you?" Glimmer said before groaning.

Bow turned his attention to the white stallion. A look of panic was as clear as day in the horse's eyes.

"What is it horsie?" Bow asked.

"Adora's in trouble!" Swift Wind replied, ignoring his most despised nickname. "I was just out in the meadow munching away when this horrible feeling came over me. And I knew I just had to find you guys!"

Despite herself, Glimmer paced her breathing. "Is it…bad?"

Swift Wind walked over to the window and shook his head. "I can still feel Adora. Luckily she's still within the Whispering Woods but…"

The two thirds of the Best Friend Squad held their breath.

"It's faint, very, very faint," Swift Wind finally replied in a somber tone, his horn barely glowing.

Glimmer looked up at Bow before she tried to put on her best brave face. She was just about to voice a course of action when the unmistakable sounds of Adora's screams fled out of the Whispering Woods. It sent all of their hearts into overdrive.

Glimmer's face, initially one of fear, immediately turned into one of direct authority.

"Bow get as many arrows as you can! Swift Wind, fly us to where you think Adora may be! We're gonna get her back…no matter what it takes!"

XXXXXXX

Fear.

It was something that Catra vowed to never show in front of anyone.

The combination of the Horde's philosophy (fear was for the weak) as well as Shadow Weaver's constant punishments over the years, had lead the young feline to bury the emotion once and for all.

But seeing her former friend change into something that her nightmares couldn't create on her worst day had caused it to return in full force.

Trying not to look into Adora's soulless eyes, Catra opened her mouth to speak. But she only managed to make a strangled gurgle.

"Oh…cat got your tongue?" Adora asked, her head tilting to one side.

Catra furiously scratched at Adora's arms like a scratching post. But the eight foot warrior stood motionless. Adora's grasp suddenly loosened and Catra landed harshly on the ground.

Catra greedily sucked air into her lungs before glancing up at Adora.

"A-A-Adora?" Catra shakily asked.

"Adora? Adora? Hmm…nope doesn't ring a bell." Adora's subsequent laugh made Catra's blood run cold.

"My God what've I done?" Catra thought to herself as her hand grasped the electric staff behind her back.

"Adora…I don't know what's happened but I'm sure Entrapta can figure out a way to fix this. We'll fix this…somehow."

"Oh Catra. Sweet, sweet dumb Catra," Adora replied, echoing Catra's words. "I don't want you to fix me. There's nothing to fix."

Adora took a few steps forward, her sword pointed directly at Catra's chest.

"Stay the hell away from me!" Catra shouted as she pulled out her electric staff.

Adora paused before she resumed walking. "You don't have the guts to…"

Catra jammed the staff straight into Adora's chest repeatedly, losing count after the fifth strike. But try as she might, the imposing figure simply stood her ground. But just as she was about to strike again, Adora ripped the staff out of Catra's hands and crushed the device into two pieces.

"Oh what a shame that actually felt great!" Adora laughed. "Now let's see how much you like it."

Several bolts of red lightening shot out of Adora's hands. Catra screamed as she felt the electricity surge through her body. Her blood became hotter and hotter by the minute.

But just as quickly as it happened, the electric force field vanished and once again Catra fell to the ground.

A sudden scream erupted from Adora's throat. She dropped her sword and pressed her hands to her temples. Adora stumbled around in agony before she stopped. Adora's skin turned into a strange mixture between her regular complexion and the sickly, blue color she had before. Adora rapidly opened her eyes. To Catra's relief, they were her regular sky blue eyes.

The same eyes that Catra now realized were absolutely beautiful to look into.

"C-C-Catra," Adora cried as tears fell down her face. "You have to help me. I-I-I can't stop it."

Although a million thoughts ran through Catra's mind, her mouth could only form:

"I-I-I…"

Adora outstretched her right hand as the black claws turned back into fingernails.

"Please Catra! I-I'm scared."

This simple sentence caused Catra's breath to hitch. Growing up she always remembered Adora being the brave one. The one who would check under their bunk bed to see if any Princesses were there. The one who would squish any spider that Catra was unfortunate enough to run into. The one who could look Shadow Weaver straight in the eyes and stand up for her no matter what. Even after everything that had happened between them, Catra still held a sliver of respect for Adora's bravery. No matter what enemy she was facing or whatever situation she found herself in, Adora always managed to look past the odds and put on a brave face.

To hear that same person admit that they were afraid scared Catra more than Shadow Weaver, water or Adora's new look combined.

Slowly, as if her legs were on autopilot, Catra walked forward and slowly placed her own hand into Adora's.

"Was Adora's skin always this soft?" Catra thought, her mind temporarily forgetting the circumstances.

Another soul shattering scream erupted from Adora's throat as she unleashed Catra's hand and again placed both of them against her temples.

"No! No!" Adora cried. "You can't do this to me! You can't…"

Adora's face dropped completely before she cackled wildly. Her skin changed back into its sickly bluish color, the sharp claws

returned and her eyes returned to the horrifying mix of black corneas and red pupils.

Catra felt her legs freeze to the ground as Adora turned back to face her.

"I don't think Adora's going to protect you anymore Catra."

Adora picked up her sword and once again approached Catra. Catra unsheathed her claws before she furiously started slashing at every square inch of Adora she could find. Ordinarily, these scratches would cause the young blonde to cry out in agony and stumble. But in her new form, they were the equivalent of a ladybug walking across her finger.

But Catra didn't care. She just wanted to distract Adora long enough that she could make a break for the Fright Zone.

Catra's attacks got slower and slower as she felt her exhaustion overcome her. Catra made one last swipe across Adora's face before she bent over and breathed heavily. Glancing up, Catra saw four long red claw marks on Adora's face as well as several red scratches all over the warrior's body.

"Impressive," Adora smirked. "But can you do this?"

Several red tentacles burst out of the claw marks made on Adora's face and wrapped around Catra's throat. Catra had barely enough time to scream before she felt the sickly warm and slimy appendages slowly squeeze the life out of her.

Catra felt like her entire world was spinning. Images and sounds became fuzzier and fuzzier.

But amongst the hazy sounds of her gurgling, and Adora's chilling laugh, were a few new ones.

"Guys, I think Adora's close!"

"How close?"

"Just over the next bend."

"Oh, I hope Adora's alright."

It sounded like two male voices, one of which sounded familiar, and a female voice, which also sounded familiar.

Catra silently prayed that whoever it was could look beyond the Horde uniform and save her from dying at the hands of her childhood friend.

XXXXXXX

Bow, Glimmer and Swift Wind broke through the bush at break-neck speed.

To say that the sight that greeted them was bizarre would be the understatement of the century.

A figure that looked vaguely like She-Ra was standing overtop someone. But at the angle they were at it was difficult to tell who it was.

"Is that Adora?" Bow whispered.

Glimmer shook her head. "I don't think so but Swift Wind did point us to this spot exactly."

The horse in question shook his head and slightly shivered. "I don't like this. It's like Adora's here but…not."

The three looked at each other, feeling equally uneasy.

Glimmer took a deep breath and stepped forward. "A-A-Adora?"

The figure turned its head to look at them, a full 180 degrees.

Glimmer heard a scream, which sounded like her own voice, echo throughout the woods.

"Glimmer! Bow! Swift Wind! So nice to see you again." Adora laughed before her head snapped back into place. "I'll have some more fun with you later…Catra."

"Catra? What's she doing here?" Glimmer thought to herself as she raised her glowing hands.

Adora dropped Catra and allowed the tentacles to flow back into her face. The scratches on her face and body soon disappeared. She turned and faced the group, happy to see their faces frozen in fear.

"Adora…what's happened to you?" Glimmer cried.

"I've been given an upgrade courtesy of Catra!" Adora replied. "Do you like it?"

"Uh…no," Bow slowly replied. "But it's gonna be okay we can still fix this!"

"Argh! There's that word again! Fix! Fix! Fix! If something isn't broken why try to fix it?!" Adora screamed.

Glimmer was about to respond when she felt Bow tug at her sleeve. Turning her head, she saw Bow point towards Adora's sword. Glancing that way, Glimmer saw that instead of the turquoise jewel within the sword, there was a glowing, red data crystal. Red, vein like tentacles oozed from every direction. The same one, Glimmer horrifyingly realized, that had infected Entrapta's robots.

"Bow, are you seeing what I'm seeing?" Glimmer whispered.

"Yeah but it's impossible! I destroyed that crystal with my Sonic Boom arrow! How can it be here?"

Before Glimmer could answer, Adora suddenly charged at them with a bestial war cry. Glimmer grabbed Bow and teleported out of the way while Swift Wind flew up into the air.

When Glimmer and Bow teleported behind Adora, the latter fired an arrow that shot a net out of its top. Adora cried out in surprise as the net gripped tightly around her body and caused her to fall to the ground. But before the duo could approach her, Adora's body was suddenly surrounded by electricity that caused the net to vaporize into ash.

Adora turned her head toward the duo and snarled.

"Adora stop! We're your friends!" Glimmer cried as Adora got to her feet. "I don't want to hurt you Adora."

"Well that's too bad," Adora stated coldly. "Because I'm definitely gonna enjoy killing you."

Adora raced forward with her sword raised overhead. But before she could get far, Swift Wind suddenly swooped in and kicked his hooves into the girl's chest. Adora cried out and rolled into a tree.

The legendary warrior remained motionless.

"I'm really sorry I had to do that to you Adora," Swift Wind said.

Bow released his breath before looking at Glimmer.

"Glimmer what do we do? I've never seen something like this before!"

"I have," Glimmer replied. "Well maybe not this exactly. You remember how the virus in Dryl also affected She-Ra's sword?"

Bow nodded. "Yeah but I remember that the virus just made Adora act all weird, not…this."

Glimmer nodded as the memories of that day came flooding back. "There was one thing I didn't mention though. When She-Ra first

came into contact with the virus, it made her much more aggressive. She just kept smashing Entrapta's robot over and over again. There was this crazed look in her eye, like she wanted nothing more than to destroy whatever was in her way. It was like Adora wasn't even there anymore."

"But did Adora look anything like she does now?" Swift Wind asked.

Glimmer shook her head. "No she still looked the same. The only difference was that her eyes were red and I could see part of the virus running through her veins. But I don't know how this could've happened!"

Bow placed his hands on Glimmer's shoulders. "Look the why doesn't matter right now. What matters is helping Adora! Glimmer do you remember anything else about the virus and She-Ra."

Glimmer thought for a moment. "Y-Yeah, when I got the sword away from She-Ra it snapped her out of her raged state and caused her to turn back into Adora."

"So all we need to do is grab the sword before Adora gets it!"

Glimmer nodded before glancing back towards Adora who still lay motionless against the tree. She teleported to her location and had just placed her hands on the sword when she felt a cold, clammy hand overtop her own.

"Naughty, naughty," Adora said in a sing-song tone.

Glimmer shrieked before she tried to wrestle the sword away from Adora. But the transformed warrior seemed to be even stronger than her normal counterpart. Both girls wrestled the sword back and forth with all their might. But somehow, through some miracle, Glimmer wrenched the sword out of Adora's hands and threw it behind her.

Glimmer turned back towards Bow and Swift Wind. "I got it Bow! I got…"

The sudden fist to her face made Glimmer fly back into a tree. She collapsed onto the ground as blood oozed out of her nose.

With stars in her vision, Glimmer saw Bow and Swift Wind rushing to her side.

"Glimmer are you okay?" Swift Wind asked.

Glimmer sat up and shook her head. "I've been better. Did it work?"

Bow glanced over and saw Adora pick her sword off the ground and smile at the group, her black and red eyes never blinking.

"Uhh…no," Bow answered. "Any other ideas?"

Glimmer was just about to answer when she heard Adora yawn.

"Well this has been fun but I have better things to do then screw around with you three insolent pests! But don't worry; after what I have planned …I'll be all around you."

And with a sudden puff of black smoke, Adora vanished right before their eyes.

Swift Wind rushed forward. "Adora?! Adora?!" The white stallion shook his head. "Damn it! I can't feel her now! It's like she's vanished off the face of the planet!"

Glimmer slowly got to her feet as she tried to pinch the bridge of her nose.

"Glimmer…what'd we do now?" Bow worryingly asked.

Glimmer glanced up at the archer with misty eyes. "We…we have to get back to BrightMoon, grab the Princesses and hopefully figure out how to fix this…all of this."

With the reality of the situation setting in, Glimmer's body began to shake as the tears fell down her face. Bow wrapped his arms

around her small body while Swift Wind gently rubbed his snout on her head.

"Ssh…it's gonna be okay Glimmer," Bow said, although with an ounce of fear still in his voice. "We'll figure something out. We've beaten this virus before remember? We can always do it again."

Glimmer buried her head into Bow's chest as she continued to cry out of fear.

But a sudden rustling sound above made the glittering princess's head snap up, like a deer sensing a predator nearby. Catra was crouched on a tree branch. Her tail was swaying from side to side rapidly and her face bore an unreadable expression.

"It's the catgirl from the battle!" Swift Wind cried.

"Catra!" Glimmer called out,

But Catra simply leaped from one branch to another, and another and another until she was out of sight.

Although she only got a quick glance of her face, Glimmer thought she could see something within in Catra's eyes that caught her off guard. Her eyes portrayed a feeling that Glimmer thought she'd never see from a Horde soldier.

Regret.

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Darkness swam around Adora.

Literally.

Adora felt like she was floating in a swimming pool. When she breathed out, an army of small bubbles escaped from her lips.

She couldn't remember how she got there. She could only remember talking to Catra about something and then...boom, she could breathe underwater.

But despite not knowing how she got there, Adora still felt an overwhelming sense of dread as she floated. Nothing seemed right, nothing seemed warm or familiar. There was just an indescribable coldness that flowed freely through her body.

She had to find a way out of there.

When she saw a beam of light shine above her, Adora swam towards it like there was no tomorrow.

No sooner had she touched the beam of light, Adora found herself back in the Whispering Woods, now facing Catra. The dam of her memories burst and Adora suddenly remembered everything. She even got a few quick, albeit terrifying glances, of what she had become.

But no sooner had she begged Catra to help her, Adora felt herself being thrown back into the darkness at warp speed. When she opened her eyes, and found herself back again in the endless, dark void, Adora tried again to reach the beam of light. But by now it had completely frozen over, like a pond in Frosta's kingdom.

Adora slowly felt herself moving further and further away from the beam of light until it was the size of a polka dot.

Adora looked down at her hands and saw her fingers begin to darken. Bit by bit, her fingers grew darker and darker until they were the same color as the darkness around her. As if she were becoming one with the darkness.

Adora reached her hand up to the light and whispered.

"Catra…help…me."

Part 4

Chapter Notes

Hey everyone glad to see you again!

First off I just wanted to say a big thank you to everyone who viewed, kudos and commented on my story so far! It's always great to see how much people are enjoying this story and it always fills me with motivation to keep writing!

Also sorry about the wait but I've been busy with various life stuff, including but not limited to my birthday on the 26th. But you'll be happy to know that this is, so far, my longest chapter I've written for this story. So I hope it'll be worth your while!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Queen Angella gave a heavy sigh as she gazed upon the mural that illustrated her late husband, King Micah.

She usually came to this particular spot whenever she felt overwhelmed by her daily duties and wanted a moment of peace and quiet. But other times she simply wanted to spend a moment alone with one of the few people she was close to in her long life.

In a way, looking at the mural made her feel as if Micah was right next to her. She could almost feel his strong arms wrapped around her waist, his laugh echoing throughout her ears and his bushy beard tickling the back of her neck.

Just the way it was when he was alive.

It was no secret that Micah's death deeply affected the immortal being. Having to break the news to her daughter (a mere eight years old at the time) that her daddy wouldn't be coming home anymore, and waking up in an empty bed alone for the past ten years, had caused her more than one anxiety riddled night.

Almost every day a plethora of what-ifs plagued her mind.

What if she hadn't ordered the battled that got Micah killed?

What if she hadn't stopped fighting and kept the Princess Alliance together?

What if she hadn't let her daughter attend the Princess Prom that got her kidnapped and then cursed?

And what if she had treated the horde solider, known as Adora, with more gratitude when she first came here?

Angella always held a sliver of hope that the legendary She-Ra would return to their land to help them in their time of need. She never expected that the legendary warrior would come in the body of a young Horde soldier.

Angella could remember standing in the exact same spot months ago when she ran into Adora, covered in Etherian feathers and saluting awkwardly. She had made her point clear, perhaps a bit too forcibly, that she cared about Glimmer more than anything in Etheria.

What she had said was:

"Do not disappoint her."

But her tone had an underlying message of:

"If you do anything to hurt my daughter or anyone in my kingdom, you will feel my wrath."

Looking back, the angelic being scolded herself for being so hard on Adora. The child had come from a broken, dystopian home that punished anyone for shedding a tear or even showing compassion. She also discovered her destiny as a mythical warrior, left everything she knew behind and defeated a Horde squadron using an indescribable amount of power all in one day.

Who was she to think that a girl like that would pose a threat to them? Why couldn't she have looked past the symbol on her shirt and seen the fragile, scared little girl underneath? The girl that was just looking for a home and a chance to feel real compassion.

Angella shook her head slightly and tried to anchor her mind back to the present as well as more positive attributes about the blonde warrior.

Adora had more than proven herself worthy of serving the BrightMoon kingdom. With her help they managed to reunite the Princess alliance, saved the BrightMoon kingdom from the Horde's invasion, had inadvertently caused herself and Glimmer to grow closer together and restored a feeling in her soul that she thought had died long ago: hope.

With each passing day, Angella came to love Adora more and more, until she considered her a second daughter rather than just an ally. And with each passing day, the angelic queen tried to get the ex-horde soldier to open up to her more as well, usually through talks over tea or long walks through the botanical gardens. Although it was an awkward and rocky start, Adora soon grew more and more comfortable around the queen until she also considered Angella as more of a mother than a ruler of the kingdom.

Angella soon laughed to herself as she remembered how the young girl had accidently called her 'Mom' during an outdoor picnic. Her face grew as red as a tomato has a hand clasped around her mouth. But Angella simply smiled, wrapped her arms around the girl's strong, yet fragile frame and whispered that she would always be a daughter in her eyes and that nothing was going to change that.

But while all this gave the queen a sense of euphoria within her soul, it also polluted it with a sense of worry every time both Adora and Glimmer were out on the battlefield. Though she grew more and more confident in Adora's loyalty to BrightMoon and Glimmer's ability to prove victorious in battle, it still didn't stop the

other what-ifs about her daughters being severely injured…or god forbid killed. Adora's recent trek into the Whispering Woods was no exception.

At first the queen attended to her regular duties such as organizing ancient writings, analyzing any possible Horde invasions throughout Etheria and confiding in the other Princesses as to the states of their respective kingdoms. But as the minutes totaled up to an hour, that dreaded sense of worry came knocking. Angella tried to convince herself that Adora was more than capable of handling any potential dangers, but her mind's worst case scenario stories grew darker and darker with each passing minute.

And so, she found herself starring at the mural, waiting for the sound of Adora's footsteps to echo throughout the hall and the sound of her voice to calm her heart.

She hadn't expected hearing the door open violently and the sound of footsteps hurrying down the hall.

"Mom!" Glimmer called out in desperation when she saw her mother come into view. "We need your help!"

Angella's eyes widened. "Glimmer what is it? Where's Adora?" Angella asked as she bent down to her daughter's height.

Glimmer stuttered for a moment before she wrapped her arms around her mother and allowed all the pain and fear in her heart to flow down her face.

"Shh, its okay Glimmer," Angella cooed as she rubbed her daughter's back. She glanced up at Bow who looked down at his feet.

"We found Adora in the Whispering Woods but Catra was there too," Bow said with a heavy sigh. "And somehow she managed to get her hands on a data crystal, the same one that infected She-Ra back in Dryl. But this time…it changed Adora into…into…"

"A monster," Glimmer quietly spoke up as she lifted her head and looked into her mother's eyes. "We tried to fight her off but she was too powerful. I tried to get the Sword away from her but it didn't seem to have any effect. She disappeared and…"

Once again the words caught in Glimmer's throat and she buried her head into her mother's shoulder, shaking uncontrollably.

Angella's face dropped at the news as glanced up at Bow.

"Your majesty we need to get the other Princesses here and form a plan. Whatever we're up against is going to need every bit of help that we can get!"

Angella nodded before a look of worry crossed her face. "I'm not sure how fast we can get them over here. Mermista is overseeing new developments with her war ships and Frosta…"

"Mom!" Glimmer shouted, maybe a little louder than she was expecting. "Please…Adora's in serious trouble. We're in serious trouble. With the powers of She-Ra on her side there's no telling what she could do! Please…we need them here…now."

Angella mentally scolded herself again for her oversight and nodded. "I'll send out the message right away."

Bow nodded before he kneeled next to Glimmer and wrapped her arms around her as well. "It's gonna be okay Glimmer. We can still fix this…I know we can."

Angella continued to stroke Glimmer's back, knowing that this was exactly where she needed to be right now. But while her face was one of sympathy and comfort, her internal thoughts became as raged as a cornered animal.

"I've almost lost one daughter, I'm not about to lose another!"

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Catra stormed through the halls of the Fright Zone as she made her way towards Entrapta's lab. Thankfully her path was clear of any cadets who wanted to discuss future battle plans or simply salute her. At her current mood she would have scratched the eyes out of anyone that dared to even look at her.

The young feline couldn't exactly pinpoint what had made her so angry. Entrapta lying to her about the data crystal's effects, not having her plan worked the way it did, Adora beating her again (something that had angered her as far back as she could remember) or maybe she was just annoyed at having no clear answers as to why everything happened as it did.

First One's tech wasn't supposed to turn people into freaks.

Right?

Catra shook her head and quickened her pace. The thought of running into Adora again made her heart race. The young feline looked behind her every so often, so sure that at any moment she would find the demon princess standing right on her heels. Fortunately, the hallways remained empty, although a small part of her still expected to see Adora leap out from the next hallway and finish the job. But fortunately she was spared this scenario… at least for now.

Adora's transformation, and desperate pleas for help, kept replaying in Catra's mind like a broken record. The desperate look in Adora's eyes reminded Catra of that incident in the First One's temple, when she had finally let go of having Adora in her life (Or had she? Some days she wasn't sure which one it really was). The tear-stricken eyes of her former friend had once filled her with pride, knowing that she had finally bested her ex-best friend at something and had made her feel just as fragile and scared as she had been all these years.

But now those same eyes just filled Catra with a strange mixture of guilt, sadness and (dare she say) regret over her decisions the past couple of months. The thoughts of joining Adora during their

siege on Thymor had rarely entered her mind. But every time they did, it always made Catra fantasize about what life might have been like had she followed her back to BrightMoon. Being outside the Fright Zone in wide open spaces, trying the various new foods that she had caught a glimpse of whenever her squadron invaded a village or even just being closer to Adora. Her golden blonde hair, those sky blue eyes that appeared lively and jovial, soft, kissable lips…

Catra let out a loud hiss as her fist landed against the wall, desperate to anchor her thoughts back to the task at hand. But still her mind's dominant thought was clear: Adora was gone, She-Ra was gone and only a spooky shell of its former self remained… and it was all her fault.

Blinking away her misty eyes, Catra stood up and glanced up to see that Entrapta's lab was now only a couple feet away. Catra wiped her eyes, put on her best angry mask and stormed over to the door.

"So yeah the molting on my claws is pretty annoying but hey at least they look extra shiny when…"

Whatever else Scorpia was saying was completely tuned out by Catra as she caught the genius in question, typing more code into of the various computers.

"Oh hey Catra's back! You were gone longer than I hoped! Any longer and I probably would've sent out the entire Horde squadron to look for ya. Say where's Adora?"

Catra ran past Scorpia, grabbed Entrapta's shirt with both hands and threw her against the wall.

"What the hell is wrong with you? Catra hissed her face only inches away from Entrapta's.

Entrapta's eyes glanced upwards. "Well it's kinda of a long story. Would you prefer it in chronological order or…"

Whatever Entrapta had intended to say was interrupted as Catra threw her onto the table and punched the genius across the face.

"CATRA STOP!" Scorpia yelled as her eyes widened. "What the hell's gotten in to you?!"

But Scorpia's pleas fell on deaf ears as Catra landed another punch across Entrapta's face. She then unsheathed her claws and raised them high in the air. But before they could hit their target, Catra suddenly felt something massive wrap around her waist before she felt herself being lifted off the ground. She looked down and saw Scorpia's claw wrapped around her waist, the princess in question had a concerned yet determined look in her eyes.

"Let me go!" Catra cried as she tried desperately to pull out of the scorpion princess's grasp.

"Not until you calm down and tell us what's going on," Scorpia replied.

Catra gave a low hiss but allowed a few deep breaths to enter her lungs. Scorpia then slowly lowered Catra onto the ground but still maintained her claw around her waist. Glancing at Entrapta, Catra saw a dribble of blood flowing from her mouth.

"You said that the data crystal would just make Adora incompatible not a bloodthirsty monster!" Catra yelled.

Entrapta wiped the blood away from her mouth before she tilted her head sideways. "Uhh…sorry Catra but for once I don't follow you."

"Me either," Scorpia replied. "Do you want to lie down for a while and talk to us later?"

Catra groaned as she rubbed her hands down her face. "I got the data crystal onto Adora's sword but she acted like she was getting electrocuted. She was out cold for a while, I thought she was dead and then she turned her head to face me."

By now Scorpia had released her grip on Catra's waist.

"What's so strange about that?" Scorpia asked.

Catra's head snapped back. "I don't think most people's heads turn a full 180 degrees to look at you!"

A cold chill ran through the lab as Entrapta and Scorpia visualized the scenario.

"And before I knew it, Adora changed into She-Ra…well kinda of like She-Ra. Except she looked like…" Catra shuddered at the recent memory.

"I can draw it out for you if you want," Scorpia requested.

Catra rolled her eyes but decided to humor the disregarded princess. As she went into detail about her former friend's appearance, Catra noticed that Entrapta was repeating much of the same information into her trusty tape recorder as well as typing it into an adjacent computer. Scorpia meanwhile was drawing furiously in her notepad, as if her life mission was to ensure that the drawing was as accurate as possible. But when she was finished she showed it to Catra whose eyes widened. Although it was only black and white, Scorpia managed to get a hyper realistic, and very accurate, drawing of the transformed She-Ra. The detail was so great that Catra actually had to turn away to avoid glancing back into those soulless eyes.

"Wait a minute, you can draw this good?" Catra suddenly realized as she turned her head back to face Scorpia. "I thought you could only draw stick figures."

Scorpia waved her claw, as if it were an old joker she'd heard before. "Oh no! I can draw well. Been practicing it since I was a kid, I just find stick figures more fun to do!"

Catra raised an eyebrow before she shook her head. "Look we're getting off topic. The point is, Adora's changed and I want to know how we can change her back."

"Well," Entrapta began as she thought about it. "I'd have to analyze Adora's body as a whole which would pretty much mean dissecting her."

If looks could kill, the one Catra gave Entrapta would make the latter's head explode.

"Right," Entrapta nodded in realization. "Dissecting Adora is bad. Do you have another sample? A piece of hair, blood, anything?"

Catra shook her head. "No I didn't have a chance. I scratched her face a few times but it didn't seem to make her bleed and the scratch marks just disappeared afterwards."

A light bulb suddenly went off in Entrapta's head. She ran over to her workstation and pulled open a drawer, filled to the brim with miscellaneous items. The purple haired princess scoured through the junk before she pulled out a set of goggles along with a mini scraper and a Petri dish.

Catra and Scorpia looked at each other in confusion before Entrapta ran over to Catra and placed the goggles over her eyes.

"Uhh, what are you doing?" Catra asked.

"You said that you scratched Adora right?" Entrapta asked.

"Yeah but did you miss the part where I said it didn't do much damage!" Catra snapped.

"Yes," Entrapta replied. "But any anomalies can usually be detected in a subatomic quantity when analyzed with electronic magnification."

"I think my brain just pulled a muscle trying to figure that out," Scorpia said as she placed a claw against her head.

"Can you say that again like a normal person?" Catra irritably asked.

Entrapta blinked slowly. "I. Am. Going. To. Use. These. Goggles. To. Look. Closely. At. Your. Claws. And. Use. The. Scalpel. To. Scratch. Away. Residue. You know what residue is right?"

Catra face palmed. "Just get it over with."

Catra extended one of her hands. Entrapta's hair hands held onto Catra's wrist, and simultaneously massaged her fur. Her regular hands adjusted a small dial on the side of the goggles and slowly scraped away at Catra's claws as tiny bits of black residue slowly fell onto the dish.

Entrapta finally ceased scraping and moved towards her main workstation. She placed the dish onto a small, glass platform before pressing a few buttons on her keyboard. A beam of red light came from the contraption above and moved over every square inch of the dish in an almost synchronized manner. When the light finally disappeared, a whole slew of data, diagrams and stats came onto Entrapta's computer.

Catra and Scorpia looked over Entrapta's shoulder at all the data on the screen. To Entrapta, it was an utterly fascinating piece on Adora's DNA. To Catra and Scorpia it was a complete mess of data.

"So what are we looking at?" Scorpia asked.

Entrapta was just about to open her mouth to speak when Catra suddenly spoke.

"In layman's terms please."

Entrapta looked back at the screen and focused, as if trying to put it simply was more difficult than astrophysics.

"This is Adora's DNA." A 3D diagram of a DNA strand came on display. "Her DNA is generally normal, there seems to be some slight alteration possibly due to becoming She-Ra. But if you look at the base pairs between the phosphate backbone, or the lines in between the two long lines, it looks like some other matter had

attached itself to it. Possibly the reason Adora turned into…well a monster."

Scorpia nodded slowly. "So Adora's change is caused by her DNA being screwed up?"

"Well that's one way to put it," Entrapta replied.

Catra studied the diagram closely. "But how did it get there? I mean you said it yourself this didn't happen last time Adora got infected!"

Entrapta tapped a pen against the side of her mouth. "I'd have to run more tests on this sample as dissection of Adora is out of the question. Although, if you managed to get me the sword and/or data crystal it would be a lot easier."

Catra groaned. "I would if I could but She-Ra's pretty much unstoppable right now! I didn't mention this earlier but Princess what's her face and bowie boy were there too. She did get the sword away but She-Ra just knocked her into a tree before she could reach for it. And when bow-boy shot a net over her she pretty much made it vaporize."

Catra paused for a moment, trying to keep a brave face. "I don't know what's happened to Adora and frankly I don't give a damn! What I care about is finding a way to turn her back to normal!"

"But isn't Adora our enemy?" Scorpia innocently asked. "Last time I checked we weren't supposed to help the enemy."

Catra glared at Scorpia. "I wanted Adora here, not whatever the hell she is now. And I will do everything I can to make sure that happens! Entrapta get to work on an antidote now."

Entrapta nodded. "I'll do what I can but I'm still completely new to First One's Tech or even just where this unknown DNA matter came from."

"JUST GET IT DONE!" Catra roared as she turned away from Entrapta.

"Hey, hey it's gonna be fine," Scorpia soothed as she wrapped a claw around Catra's shoulder. "We'll figure out a way around this."

Catra sighed deeply. "How do you know everything's gonna be okay?"

Scorpia shrugged. "Positive thinking. If you believe something's gonna work out it usually does."

"Never brought Adora home," Catra muttered under her breath.

"Sorry?" Scorpia asked.

Catra shook her head. "I gotta get out of here. Entrapta call me back when you've made some progress. And…I'm sorry I snapped at you."

And with that, Catra walked out of the room before Scorpia could see the tears falling down her face.

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The meeting room of BrightMoon was a place that was firmly planted in Glimmer's memory. She had so many memories of watching her mother and father discussing with the other princesses, often about things that sounded boring to her young mind. There were other times she even sat in her father's lap, playing with building blocks, while they discussed the same boring topics.

But no matter how long or boring the meetings were, there was always a sense of wonderment that overcame the young child whenever she was in the room. Seeing the powerful figures in one place made the young girl believe that they were like superheroes that were coming together to save the day. And Glimmer knew that one day; she would be sitting at that exact table, planning strategies and fighting alongside the other princesses.

Although it had been a long and strange journey, Glimmer's wish eventually came true. Week after week she had been sitting with the other Princesses and discussing strategies to either overthrow the Horde's plans or predict when they would strike next.

Normally, no matter how grave or serious the meetings were there was always a sense of light-heartedness in the air, whether it be from Mermista's stories of SeaHawk trying to woo her over or just funny events that had happened in their lives over the past week.

But the air around this particular meeting had all the same warmth and joy as a crypt.

"I'd like to thank you all for coming on such short notice," Queen Angella began.

"Yeah you are doing me like such a big favor today because SeaHawk was just about to show me this giant mural he painted of me. And scanty about it of course," Mermista rolled her eyes.

"Aw that's so sweet!" Perfuma happily replied.

"Now if only he could keep your ships in one piece," Netossa joked.

This exchange caused most of the Princesses to laugh but they all stopped when they caught the solemn looks of Glimmer, Bow and the Queen herself.

"I've called this meeting today because I've received some disturbing news. Adora…is in trouble. Big, big trouble."

The sound of a pin drop would have been deafening.

Angella breathed deeply, trying to keep her composure. "Glimmer."

Glimmer sighed deeply before glancing around the table.

"We can't say for sure how it happened, but somehow the Horde has infected Adora's sword with the same data crystal in Dryl."

"The same one we thought we'd destroyed for good," Bow added.

"But unlike last time, the effects of the virus seem to have completely altered She-Ra's makeover. She's changed into something…I don't even know how to describe it."

Angella suddenly perked up. "Glimmer do you remember the Mind Projector?"

Glimmer nodded before she placed both of her hands on the table in a particular spot, a spot that had a diagram of an eye within the shape of a brain. Glimmer remembered how other princesses would use this technique to relay certain events they had seen on the battlefield. While regular human memory could extract most information accurately, the Mind Projector could ensure 100 percent accuracy for human memories. Whatever the person was thinking about would be projected throughout the middle of the table in crystal clarity.

Glimmer closed her eyes and began thinking about everything that had happened previously. Rushing through the woods, finding Adora, her horrifying appearance, trying to reason with her and even her eventual disappearance. When she felt like she had shown enough, Glimmer removed her hands from the table and opened her eyes.

Perfuma's hands were clasped over her mouth. Mermista's eyes were as wide as the sun. Frosta held a poker face, though the constant tapping of her fingers definitely indicated that she was troubled. Netossa's head was buried in Spinerella's shoulder as her whole body shook. And Spinerella managed to speak for the rest of the group.

"My God."

Glimmer glanced at her mother, whose face was a mix between shock, terror and sadness. It was a look she hadn't seen since she

first found out about Micah's death.

Recognizing the heavy silence in the air, Glimmer cleared her throat.

"Considering that the data crystal was in one piece again it's obvious that someone welded it together again. And the only person I know who could do such a thing was Entrapta."

"You mean Entrapta's alive?" Perfuma asked excitedly.

"She didn't say that," Frost coldly replied. "For all we know the Horde could have ravaged Entrapta's lab, found the pieces of the crystal and welded it together themselves."

"Frosta's right," Angella added. "We have no way of knowing if Entrapta did weld the crystal together again or why she would do so in the first place. For all we know, Lord Hordak may have done it himself. But what we do know is that someone in the Horde has caused She-Ra to turn into this…thing. And because of this, all of She-Ra's powers are now against us."

"Well last time we destroyed the crystal it caused all of Entrapta's robots, and She-Ra, to turn back to normal," Glimmer stated. "So if Bow just uses his Sonic Arrow, we can destroy the crystal and Adora should be back to normal."

A series of nods and agreements echoed throughout the room. Glimmer finally felt the weight of the situation lift off her shoulders as she sat back down.

"But…"

Bow's voice caused the weight to return to Glimmer's shoulders.

"Last time, the crystal was by itself in the holder. My arrow destroyed the crystal and damaged anything close by. But now, since it's on Adora's sword, there's no telling what that blast could do to her. I can still try but we'd have to get the sword out of her hands."

A heavy silence filled the room as everyone struggled to figure out a course of action.

"Well it's obvious that someone in the Horde knows something about First Ones tech," Netossa commentated.

"Which means that either they or their work must still be somewhere in the Fright Zone," Spinerella replied.

"But for all we know there may only be one person whose used this tech," Glimmer added. "Trying to find them in an area like that is like finding a needle in a haystack!"

"Maybe not," Bow added as he reached into his bag and pulled out a small circular shaped object. "Entrapta gave this to me as a sort-of thank you gift for saving her kingdom from her robots. It's a sort-of thermal camera that'll show you the different heat signatures of different people."

"And this is useful to us because?" Mermista asked.

"Entrapta explained to me that First Ones tech gives off such a powerful vibe that it slightly increases the body temperature of whoever is using it but it does it in a way that isn't noticeable by the person. It also keeps this change in temperature for up to twelve hours. Entrapta's servants used to use it to navigate their way through her castle before she made her robots take care of that."

"So if we use this device," Perfuma started.

"We can still track down whoever used that piece of tech and get them to talk," Frosta finished.

"And I'm willing to bet it's Catra," Glimmer said, spitting the last word out like rancid milk.

"Either way once we find this person, we can hopefully coerce them into giving us a clue on what we're dealing with or how to stop it," Bow stated.

Everyone murmured in agreement before Glimmer slowly stood back up and eyed the rest of the group.

"I remember Entrapta telling me that this particular crystal held more First One's code than anything she saw before," Glimmer said. "It's possible that whatever code is on that crystal could explain just what this virus is and how we could deal with it. After all, Entrapta didn't create the virus, it just appeared there."

"But how can we do that if the crystal's stuck on Adora's sword?" Bow asked.

Glimmer paused for a moment. "If I know Entrapta she probably kept records on everything she ever worked on, especially First Ones tech. We could also venture to Dryl and look through her old records to see if there's any valuable information."

"Well we can't be in two places at once so I guess we'll just have to pick one," Frosta said.

"But what if we could?" Bow asked. "In a sense. We both need to get as much information on this crystal if we're gonna help Adora. The way I see it, half of us could infiltrate the Horde base while the other half can venture to Dryl and talk to Entrapta's servants."

"So half of us face possible life and death while the other half has a friendly afternoon chat," Mermista sarcastically replied. "Sounds like a really fair trade."

"Do you have any other suggestions?" Netossa asked, a little louder than she had expected.

Mermista sighed. "No I guess not but I am definitely not going back in the sewer again."

Perfuma was just about to argue that they could cover more ground if they all went to one location but remembered what had happened last time and the consequences that came of it.

"Being together makes us vulnerable," she remembered saying.

"Does that sound like a good plan mom, uh, your majesty?" Glimmer asked, with hope in her eyes.

The queen bowed her head against her folded hands, as she contemplated the situation. This was one of those days that she wished that such important decisions didn't rest on her shoulders.

"I can't say I love it…"

Everyone's faces dropped.

"But it sounds like it's our only chance." Angella raised her head and gave everyone a ghost of a smile.

"Okay then," Glimmer said, taking on her commander role. "Me, Frosta, Perfuma and SeaHawk will infiltrate the Horde base and find out all that we can. Bow, you, Mermista, Spinerella and Netossa take Swift Wind to Dryl and see what you can find out."

"Yes Ma'am," everyone replied in unison causing Glimmer to smile slightly.

Glimmer turned back to her mom before she wrapped her arms around her. The queen returned the gesture.

"Please be careful Glimmer," she whispered softly.

"I will Mom," Glimmer replied. "And don't worry; we'll bring Adora home somehow."

"She's a Princess," Mermista stepped forward.

"And if you mess with one of them," Perfuma stated.

"You have to deal with the rest of us," Frosta finished.

Glimmer smiled before she and the others raced out of the room.

Angella watched the scene with a smile on her face, happy to see the Princess Alliance together again and willing to do so much to bring one of their own home. It gave her the sense of hope that

she so desperately needed. But after everyone had left, and the silence of the meeting room set in, Angella's mind thought back to Adora's new appearance. The eyes alone had frightened her down to her very core. They bore no semblance of human intelligence, only the desire to kill anything in its path.

And that, she realized, was something that no child should be put through.

Angella placed her hands over her face and began to weep.

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Catra held her Force Captain badge between her index and middle claw. The dim hallway lights made its yellow and green colors glow slightly.

She remembered the day when Adora had received the exact same badge. At the time, she was angry that Adora had bested her at something again. Now she'd give anything to go back to the days when that was her biggest problem.

Growing up, Catra never gave much thought about the war or even what they were fighting for. Even as a kitten, she just wanted to have fun, get into mischief and explore, or at least ponder, what the outside of the Fright Zone contained. She had, and arguably still, never given a damn about Hordak's agenda or even what would happen if his plan came true, she just wanted a chance to call the shots instead of being on the receiving end of them.

But the combination of achieving second in command, being alone with her thoughts more often and the day's earlier events had left her wondering if it was even worth it.

In a way, Adora's leave of absence was perhaps the best thing that had ever happened to her. In another way though, it was perhaps the worst thing that ever happened to her.

She had achieved everything she could wish for since Adora left, a higher ranking, power, influence over other recruits, a couple of friends that enjoyed her company, a chance to lead an army and a chance to beat Adora at her own game.

But waking up in an empty bed, sleepless nights and countless defeats were all things that faced her on a daily basis. And her most recent actions had caused her former friend to achieve a fate worse than death.

She had everything she wanted and it sucked.

Catra threw her badge down the hallway, the impact echoing loudly throughout. She slumped onto the ground and raised her knees up to her chest.

The guilt that had been building in her stomach had diminished slightly.

"Entrapta's a genius," Catra thought. *"She could probably invent a cure for this by the end of the day."*

But even still, an indescribable amount of discomfort vacated her gut. It felt similar to the day she had eaten a piece of bad fish and struggled not to make it reappear on the training grid. Only this was much, much worse. If Scorpia and Entrapta had fallen to the same fate as Adora, Catra would've felt a shred of guilt. But with Adora, it felt like a whole hurricane of the emotion brewed inside her.

"Why did I go along with this stupid data crystal plan anyway?" Catra muttered to herself.

"Because you wanted to capture She-Ra and win a war that you don't even care about," the back of her mind whispered.

Feeling her guilt return full force, Catra's eyes became misty.

"Why can't I get you out of my mind Adora? Catra whispered.

"Because you love her," the back of her mind whispered back. *"But you're so afraid of change that you didn't want to leave the Horde with her or tell her how you really feel."*

Catra buried her head in her knees as the tears dripped onto the cold metal below.

"Catra…"

The sudden whispery voice caused the young Magicat to jump to her feet and unsheathe her claws.

"Who's there?" Catra asked in a barely courageous tone.

The hums and dings of the Horde machinery were her only response.

Wiping her face quickly, Catra took a few steps back.

"Adora if that's you I don't want to fight you, okay? I actually want to help you this time if you can believe that," Catra chuckled nervously.

Suddenly, Catra felt like a cold chill climb up her back. It was like death itself had found her in that exact spot. An overwhelming sense of dread came over her as she felt her heart nearly rip out of her chest.

Catra turned her body in the opposite direction, but kept her head facing the hallway behind her. She began to run, but had only managed to get a few feet before she ran into something hard.

Catra fell to the ground in a daze. When she got enough of her bearings, she glanced up at whatever she had ran into and felt her blood become ice.

Staring down at her was someone that had haunted her throughout her entire childhood and adulthood, someone she thought she had seen the last of.

"Hello Catra," Shadow Weaver whispered coldly.

Chapter End Notes

It really hasn't been Catra's day hasn't it?

Once again thanks for all the views! Hoping to get the next chapter out soon!

Until then: Peace!

Part 5

Chapter Notes

> Good morning/afternoon/evening everyone! Let's dive in to some more creepy goodness!
>
> Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Even before she became She-Ra, Adora had been well trained in the ways of staying calm in certain situations such as sparring practice or being in the middle of a battlefield.

But being stuck in an endless dark void was one situation that she wasn't sure she could stay calm in.

Glancing down at her hands, Adora saw all of her fingers had now vanished into the darkness. The rest of her hands were following suit. But bizarrely, she could still feel her disappearing appendages moving around. And could still make them do anything from tapping a finger to making a fist.

"There's gotta be something I can do to get out of here," Adora thought. *"Maybe if I harness enough of She-Ra's power, it'd be enough to throw off this virus."*

Adora closed her eyes and focused on the essence of She-Ra. She tried to feel her long, blonde hair and red cape flowing majestically in the wind. She tried to imagine the bright yellow glow that accompanied her transformation and filled her with an indescribable amount of power every time. She tried to think of anything related to the mystical princess of power.

But she only succeeded in giving herself a headache.

Adora groaned in annoyance before looking, hoping to see the beam of the light that she had touched only moments before.

Only to find that it was nowhere in sight.

Adora's breath became shaky as the reality of the situation set in. Her inner turmoil became too much for her and she allowed her tears to escape.

"They'll find me," Adora thought desperately. *"Glimmer, Bow, the other princesses, Catra they'll know what to do. They have to… they…"*

Adora's train of thought was interrupted by a sudden, feminine voice coming directly behind her.

"Now, now there's no need for tears."

Adora's eyes widened as she looked around wildly.

"Who's there?" Adora asked.

Adora suddenly felt a pair of hands run their fingers through her hair. She turned her body all the way to see who it was but could find nobody.

"Who I am is not important," the voice replied in the same sickly sweet manner. "What is important is making sure that you never suffer again."

Adora raised an eyebrow as she felt the mysterious hands continue to stroke her hair before they moved to her shoulders.

"I don't want to be here," Adora shook as she spoke. "I can't be here. My friends will come and…"

"Friends?" The voice asked. "You think they'll be able to save you? They don't even know where you are."

Adora shook her violently, trying to stop the voice's opinion from becoming her reality.

"You're w-wrong," Adora tried to say confidently. "They'll save me. Bow and…" Adora's mind froze, as if the words on her tongue had suddenly vanished. "And…and…the others! They always do!"

"They're nothing but a nuisance," The voice replied coldly. "A pointless distraction preventing you from achieving your ultimate goal."

"Ultimate goal?" Adora asked quietly. "What would that be?"

Adora suddenly felt those same hands release themselves from her shoulders and wrap around her frame.

"Why being the perfect daughter that I raised you to be."

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The heavy yellow smog nearly made Glimmer give away her position by coughing. She thankfully caught herself as she looked over a large piece of scrap metal. Several guards, possibly a dozen in total, were patrolling the area while several gigantic skiffs released mountains of scrap metal into the area.

Ducking back down, Glimmer glanced at her device. Several dots littered the area. While most of the dots were of a blue and green color, a few had mixed shades of orange with one particular dot having a distinctive red color.

"Catra," Glimmer bitterly thought.

"Okay here's how it's gonna work," Glimmer began as she glanced at the others."Frosta, you gain the jump on the guards by using your ice powers to freeze the guards' feet to the ground. Perfuma, Perfuma, use your vines to then immobilize the guards And Seahawk…"

"Ah, say no more," Seahawk interrupted. "I know exactly what to do."

Suddenly, SeaHawk pulled out a green bottle filled with an indeterminable liquid. A long white rag ran throughout the bottle with a large chunk of it hanging off the side. Lighting a match, SeaHawk lighted the end of the rag and shot to his feet.

"GIVE ME ADVENTURE OR GIVE ME DEATH!"

SeaHawk threw the bottle towards the company of guards. The explosion of flames was only offset by the barrage of electrical bolts fired out of their staffs.

SeaHawk let out a high pitched scream as he ducked back down. Frosta made several icebergs rise out of the ground as they blocked the solider's fire. Glimmer meanwhile grunted in annoyance while face palming.

"Why did I bring him along again?" Glimmer whispered to Perfuma, as best as she could with the carnage going on.

"I was kinda hoping you could tell me," Perfuma replied.

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Time froze.

Nothing seemed to matter.

An apocalypse could've come and went and Catra would've never noticed.

Shadow Weaver, the same woman who had haunted her all throughout her childhood, the same woman who would beat and torture her at the drop of a hat was once again back in her life. Her soulless white eyes stared back into her own mismatched ones with a look that Catra could only describe as pure malice. The red jewel that she had previously destroyed was back in Shadow Weaver's mask, glowing with a threatening hue.

"S-S-Shadow Weaver," Catra stuttered. "I t-took you down. I had Scorpia imprison you."

"Aw yes," Shadow Weaver replied as she pressed her fingers together. "The rumors of my imprisonment have been greatly exaggerated. But I don't want to dwell on the past. I actually wanted to thank you Catra."

Had Entrapta not checked her hearing last week, Catra would've thought that her ears were broken. "Excuse me?"

"For once you actually did something right," Shadow Weaver hummed.

Catra's initial reaction was to scream out that she had done more things right than she'd ever had. But she was so confused and frightened by the current circumstances that she simply bit her lower lip. She honestly didn't know which was more frightening, the fact that Shadow Weaver was free from imprisonment or that the inevitable explosion of anger hadn't gone off yet.

"Well I have no idea what you're talking about," Catra said as she slowly stepped back. "But I think Entrapta needs me for something so…"

Catra turned around and tried to make it back to the lab as fast as she could before a painful surge of electricity surged through her body. Every limb of her body was immobilized and it felt like torture just to breathe. It was a feeling that she was sadly all too familiar with.

"Not so fast," Shadow Weaver whispered. "I believe that Lord Hordak would be most interested in having a word with you first."

Catra put on a mask of bravery as she tried to move her head to face her tormentor. "Yeah that sounds good. Talk to the person who's on my side more than yours. He'll have you rotting away in a cell before you know it."

Shadow Weaver let out a sound that may or not have been a chuckle. "I didn't think it was possible but you've actually gotten stupider since I've been away."

Catra shut her eyes tightly as the electricity surrounding her caused her blood to boil.

"Go fuck yourself you disfigured bitch."

The subsequent extra surge of electricity into her system caused the feline humanoid to let out a scream of agony. Catra suddenly felt herself being thrown down the hallway at rapid speed. Her journey was cut short when she collided with the cold, metal wall at the very end. Catra groaned as she got onto all fours.

"Oh and by the way," Shadow Weaver began before she made the electrical force field around Catra disappear.

Catra had barely a second to catch her breath when she felt a pair of cold, rough hands grab her shirt. After being raised into the air, Catra felt one of the same hands violently slap her across the face, and then another, and another, and another. After a while Catra lost count and simply wished it would stop. But when it finally did, instead of being put back down, Catra felt a sharp, beam of electricity shoot out of Shadow Weaver's hands and into her chest.

The most bloodcurdling scream escaped from Catra's lips before she fell to the ground in a heap.

"That's for going against my wishes."

A sudden rush of footsteps echoed down the hall. Glancing to her left, or at least as best as she could, Catra saw Scorpia and Entrapta rushing down the hall.

"Catra!" Scorpia cried, a look of pure worry in her eyes. "We heard you screaming! Is everything…"

Whatever Scorpia had intended to say was caught in her throat.

"S-Shadow Weaver, ma'am," Scorpia tried to say casually as she raised her claw in salute. "It's great to see you again. Well maybe not great because these circumstances aren't great but…"

"SILENCE!"

Shadow Weaver's roar caused the scorpion princess to back up slightly, her claws raised in a pleading manner while Entrapta's eyes widened.

"I shall deal with you two after I'm finished with you," Shadow Weaver replied as she grabbed Catra by the scruff of her neck. "After all, the Horde looks down on all traitors. Isn't that right Adora?"

A sudden explosion of smoke blasted through the hallway, causing everyone except Shadow Weaver to cough violently. But when the dust settled, a lone figure stepped out into the light and eyed the group with her black and red eyes.

"Yes Shadow Weaver. They all must suffer."

Scorpia let out a loud gasp as she placed her claws to her mouth. Although she had imagined what Adora looked like, seeing it in the flesh still caused her heart to race faster and faster. Entrapta meanwhile had initially widened her eyes at Adora's new appearance, but soon her eyes grew in excitement as she caught a glance of Adora's sword.

"Fright Zone log day 137," Entrapta spoke into her tape recorder. "My hypothesis about the virus being neutralized has officially been discredited. But I'm sure that a closer inspection of Adora's sword may provide…"

Whatever else Entrapta had intended to say was suddenly caught off by a series of chronological events. Adora's sword transforming into a black rope, Adora lassoing the rope around the recorder, the recorder flying back into Adora's hands and the device being crushed to pieces.

"Come now Catra," Shadow Weaver said. "Lord Hordak is waiting."

Adora walked away in the other direction. Shadow Weaver grabbed Catra's arm and yanked it violently as she began floating in the same direction. It was a feeling that Catra was all too familiar with.

As she passed Scorpia and Entrapta, Catra saw the look of absolute worry in their eyes. Making sure that her tormentor wasn't looking, Catra mouthed the words:

"Help me."

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Perfuma gave a satisfying smile as her vines grabbed the two Horde soldiers, who were walking down the hallway, and smacked them together in one fluid motion.

Despite nearly getting killed earlier, thanks to SeaHawk's over excitement, the group managed to overpower the guards and make it into the base.

Perfuma looked behind her and motioned to the others that it was safe. The quartet made their way down the hallway until they stopped dead in their tracks. Several security cameras littered the end of the hallway. All of which suddenly turned in their direction. Frosta formed several, sharp icicles with her hands and threw them at the cameras, causing sparks of electricity to spray out of the destroyed units.

"I don't recall security being this tight," Perfuma said.

"After you guys broke in here to save me, I think it's safe to say that the Horde isn't taking any chances anymore," Glimmer replied.

A series of rapid footsteps echoed down the hall. With a split second decision, the four of them ran into the nearest door on their left. The door closed just in time as they heard a series of muffled shouts and footsteps running past the door.

Glimmer stopped to catch her breath before she glanced down at Entrapta's device. While several dots littered the area, the device itself was represented with a small, red triangle, making it easier to track where they were. And right now it seemed that they were getting closer and closer to the red dot.

"According to this," Glimmer said. "We shouldn't be much further. If we…"

Something on the screen made the princess stop in her tracks. A new dot suddenly appeared without warning. But it wasn't its sudden appearance that had caught Glimmer off guard; it was how different it looked from the others. This new dot appeared in an all white color. Sensing Glimmer's sudden fixation, everyone gathered around and stared down at the gadget.

"What is that?" SeaHawk asked.

"Well Bow mentioned to me that if a dot has a bluish greenish color it means that the person has had no interaction with First One's tech," Glimmer explained. "Depending on how much the person has been in contact with First One's tech their color can be represented by yellow, orange, red or white. But white's apparently a rare one to see because the person either has to be holding onto the tech at the time or…something more."

"Like invading their entire system?" Frosta asked.

The group looked at each other as the realization hit them at the same time.

"Adora."

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Among the various feelings Catra felt as she was pulled into Lord Hordak's chamber was a bizarre sense of déjà vu.

It seemed like only yesterday when Shadow Weaver had brought her to the leader after she had failed to bring Adora home. But

unlike last time, when her mind raced with thoughts filled with dread over what Hordak would do to her, her mind was now racing with desperate hope.

"Hordak's been supporting me for this long," Catra thought. *"Once I explain my case, he'll imprison Shadow Weaver again, get Entrapta to turn Adora back to normal and allow me to imprison Adora and her stupid sword."*

A sense of guilt came over Catra as she thought that last part, as if her mind suddenly became opposed to the idea of her former friend suffering more than she already had.

Before long, Lord Hordak came into view. As usual he was sitting on his throne with an unreadable expression on his face. His creepy, demon spy sat next to him on the right armrest. Catra never knew where Hordak had gotten the spy from or even if it was a flesh and blood creature and not just a piece of machinery he'd created long ago.

Shadow Weaver finally released her hold on Catra's arm and violently pushed her to the ground. Catra let out a short cry of surprise as she landed on her forearms. Shadow Weaver and Adora walked forward before stopping at the base of the stairs that led to Lord Hordak's throne. They each gave a small bow to the Fright Zone ruler before standing on opposite sides of the stairs.

"Force Captain Catra," Hordak said in his usual monotone. "I expect you have several questions regarding your situation."

Despite wanting to reply "No shit" to the ruler, Catra decided to keep playing nice.

"Yes Lord Hordak. Mainly why Shadow Weaver is up and around instead of being locked up in the prison."

Lord Hordak gave a ghost of a smile as he began tapping his fingers.

"Have you ever heard of Mystacor?"

Catra shook her head. "I heard Shadow Weaver mention it once, but that's about it."

"Mystacor is a floating kingdom populated by all, if not most of Etheria's sorcerers," Hordak replied. "Its invisibility shield makes it unable for us to conquer as easily. I myself would have never have known about it had it not been for one of its residents joining my rank."

Catra slowly placed the pieces together. "You mean…"

"Yes," Shadow Weaver replied. "I once walked among those pitiful fools that wanted to use their magic for the greater good. Disgusting creatures they were, afraid of my power, afraid of what I could do for them!"

"Okay, okay I get it," Catra groaned, annoyed at everyone dancing around the bush when it came to her question. "You were considered least popular, and everyone hated you. What the hell does this have to do with Adora?!"

Shadow Weaver narrowed her eyes but remained in place. "I once found a way to infuse First One's tech with a magical property that would corrupt anything in its path be it man or machine."

Catra slowly pieced everything together. "So you were the one that created that virus on Entrapta's data crystal?"

"Correct," Shadow Weaver replied. "Though I never expected to run into it again after all this time…20 years to be exact. I thought I had lost it forever until your dear friend Entrapta had brought it back to the Horde."

As if on cue, Hordak's demon spy opened its mouth. Entrapta's words echoed throughout the chamber.

"Fright Zone log day 5. I'm still reeling over my friends abandoning me but the amount of progress I've made on my work

here has helped me to cope somewhat. Had I known though that I was going to be here for such a long time, I would've brought over all my equipment and experiments from Dryl. Thankfully, my drone bot has collected a decent amount of my past work including First Ones tech no.58. That little rock still continues to fascinate me. I was especially curious as to how it could affect Adora as much as my robots. Attempts to perform a dissection to uncover a possible truth provoked much anger from the princess of BrightMoon. But it seems as if the virus has been removed from the rock courtesy of Bow's Sonic Arrow. Hopefully the code on the crystal has remained intact as it's still some of the finest and most complete code I've ever seen. With further precaution, I'm positive that the next experiment will be a success."

Hordak's spy closed his mouth and the chamber was encased in an eerie silence.

"I overheard Hordak's spy relay this information to him months ago," Shadow Weaver stated. "Once I realized that the crystal was not only within the Fright Zone but it had also affected Adora, I soon thought of a spell that would make its effects even more potent. With my magic, Adora will have no memory of being She-Ra or the time she spent with her pointless rebellion. She will merely be under my control and back by my side."

Catra glanced at Adora who only smiled from ear to ear.

"And so while Entrapta was asleep at her workstation, I snuck into her workshop, found the crystal underneath her various trinkets and placed my dark magic upon it. I left it exactly as it was so as not to arouse suspicion. I would've used the crystal sooner but a certain someone decided to go against my back, take away my power over the Black Garnett and make me rot in prison for the past two months!"

A deep sense of dread filled Catra's stomach which almost caused her to vomit.

"But I digress," Shadow Weaver replied. "Since you found the data crystal and successfully infected Adora I must thank you for doing all the hard work for me."

Catra glanced back at Lord Hordak who by now had ceased his tapping and was scratching his demon spy under its chin.

"I ventured to Shadow Weaver's holding cell yesterday. I had originally planned to inform her of her upcoming execution when she mentioned this data crystal and the work she had done to it prior. I was intrigued and decided to grant her a potential pardon if this plan worked out. And thanks to you…Adora is finally back where she belongs."

"But…but why did you change Adora into this…this…monster?!"

Shadow Weaver placed her fingers back together as she floated over towards Adora. "It's simple really. Adora has always felt like a daughter to me, in a way she was the daughter I never had. But I soon realized that it wasn't enough that she should simply act like my daughter; she should look like my daughter too. And so I infused a piece of my own DNA into the virus, causing Adora's own DNA to drastically alter into something more to my liking.

Catra froze. *"The black hair, purple and red clothes, bluish skin, I thought it looked familiar."*

"And now Adora is finally back home where she belongs. Isn't that right dear?"

Adora nodded her head. "Yes mommy. I'll never leave you again."

A deep chill ran through Catra's spine. This whole situation just had a sense of wrongness that only grew and grew with each passing second.

"Right…that makes sense," Catra replied, trying to keep her composure. "I infect Adora, she makes her way back her and we can capture her easily. So I guess we let Entrapta change Adora

back, imprison her and gain an advantage over the rebellion now that She-Ra's out of commission. Right?"

The resulting silence hung in the air like a stale odor. But the silence was soon broken by something Catra never expected to hear in her lifetime. Shadow Weaver and Adora cackling wildly.

The combined awful melodies caused Catra to fall to her knees and place her hands over her ears, begging for the sounds to stop. But after what seemed like hours they finally did.

Catra glanced up at Hordak, hoping that the Fright Zone leader would say or do something to bring sense back into the world. But all she saw was his face twisted into a scowl.

"You are correct about one thing Force Captain," Hordak stated. "We shall gain an advantage over the rebellion now that the powers of She-Ra are on our side. Shadow Weaver's new plans will almost guarantee this."

"And what plan is this?" Catra asked.

"That doesn't concern you anymore!" Shadow Weaver shouted in her familiar venomous tone.

The familiar sense of anger boiled in Catra's system. "Oh why? Because Adora's back and you've brainwashed Hordak to follow your plan means I get demoted back to latrine duty."

The old witch darkly chuckled. "Think of it less as a demotion and more of an early retirement."

If someone dumped a bucket of cold water onto her head, Catra would've felt less chilled than she was right now.

"Tell me Force Captain," Hordak said as he began tapping his fingers again. "Do you know what the definition of failure is?"

Catra prayed Hordak couldn't see her hands shaking from where he was.

"Its...not being able to achieve success at a certain time?"

"It's being unable to obtain victory even with all the necessary components to do so," Hordak replied with a scowl.

Catra shook her head. "I don't understand my lord."

"Your claws are sharp enough to be considered lethal weapons are they not?" Hordak asked.

Catra glanced down at her claws and instinctively flexed them out. She often considered her claws to be her most valuable asset. She always tried to keep them sharp by either kneading her bed or using a special grinder that Entrapta had made for her.

"Yes my lord I often..."

"And are you aware that your claws could have easily taken out She-Ra's eyes or severed her jugular vein making her bleed out in a matter of minutes?" Hordak interrupted.

Catra tried to push the gory images from her mind as she kept a brave face. "Yes my lord but I figured that if I simply injure her, she...would be easier to capture. And by having She-Ra as our prisoner, it would prove to be a tactful advantage over BrightMoon."

Lord Hordak kept his passive expression. "And yet even with that mindset you have failed to capture Adora time and time again all because your feelings for the girl have blinded your goals."

Catra thanked the stars that her fur covered the blush on her cheeks. "I do not have feelings for Adora!"

"Oh my dear," Shadow Weaver narrowed her eyes. "Do you honestly think that I wasn't aware of how close you were to Adora growing up? How your pathetic feelings were preventing her from achieving her goals?"

It took every last bit of willpower to keep her rage from slipping. "That was then! Once Adora abandoned our cause I made a promise to let her go from my life. She's nothing but the enemy now!"

Lord Hordak said nothing in return. Only the sound of his constant tapping filled the room. It gave Catra an eerie feeling as the seconds passed by. But before she could open her mouth to explain her case further, Hordak looked down at his demon spy and gave a vile smile. The demon spy once again opened its mouth.

At first, Catra heard nothing but some indistinguishable sounds. She could however make out one particular sound: the rustling of bed sheets. But before long she heard her own voice, sounding half-asleep, projected into the chamber.

"Why'd you leave me Adora? Why can't we go back to the way things were? I don't want to fight anymore I just want you. I...love you Adora."

The demon spy closed its mouth and gave Catra a smile so wicked it made her step back slightly.

"So fascinating what the heart makes us say when our minds are elsewhere. My little spy caught this when he was patrolling through the air vents and passed by your personal quarters. It seems like lying to me is as natural as breathing to you isn't it Catra?"

For the first time in years, Catra felt less like tough, hardened Horde solider she built herself up to be, and more like the scared little girl she hid from the rest of the world.

"Lord Hordak you can't possibly go through with Shadow Weaver's plan! She's the same witch that used the Black Garnett for herself! The same one who went against your orders when I tried hacking into the Black Garnett!"

Hordak snarled. "She also doesn't allow such things as compassion get in the way of accomplishing goals. Something you have disappointed me on time and time again. And that I think is worthy of consideration. And with the powers of She-Ra on our side, I think we have no further use for you."

Catra's brave face cracked and her breath became shaky. "You can't do this to me!"

Lord Hordak scowled. "I can and I shall. Adora?" Adora glanced up at Hordak. "I think it's time this animal was put down."

Adora glanced back at Catra and smiled. Her smile started off as an ear to ear grin before it grew bigger and bigger. The skin on Adora's face began to peel off to the side, with her eyes and nose following suit. Before long, Adora's entire face was made up on one big smile; her teeth ran all the way down from her hairline to the bottom of her chin.

"Yes Lord Hordak" the mouth opened and closed.

Catra's face became disfigured with horror. She turned and tried to run out of the chamber, but a wall of shadows blocked her path. She glanced back and saw Shadow Weaver with her hands raised. Adora came closer and closer in an almost robotic movement.

"Leaving so soon?" The old witch said in a sickly sweet tone. "I thought you wanted to spend more time with Adora."

"Turn Adora back now," she hissed as she locked eyes with Shadow Weaver.

Shadow Weaver fired a beam of electricity at the Magicat that barely reached its target.

"Once I remove your head as a trophy I'll consider your proposition." Shadow Weaver stated coldly.

Catra looked around wildly, hoping to find some way to escape. But her thoughts were interrupted by Adora's sword narrowly cutting her tail off. Catra looked up at Adora, who had returned her face to its original, less nightmarish form. Her look could only be described as a kid given complete access to a dessert bar.

"Adora you can't let Shadow Weaver do this to you! You've got to fight this! You're in there somewhere!"

Adora tilted her head to the side. "You're right. Maybe you should come and find her."

Adora's chest suddenly opened like a mouth, revealing a whole network of red, fleshy tendrils. A swarm of tendrils shot out and wrapped around Catra's whole body. Before long, the red vines pulled Catra closer and closer to their origin.

Catra gave out a few muffled cries before she unsheathed her claws to their full length and began hacking away at the fleshy tendrils. Just when she was reaching the outskirts of Adora's chest cavity, Catra broke free of the virus strands, leapt onto Adora, jumped from her shoulders and grabbed hold of the various metal pipes sticking out from the walls. Using her claws, Catra climbed up the pipes as several lightning bolts struck around her. Whether it was from Shadow Weaver or Adora she couldn't tell. But she soon caught sight of something that made her heart leap for joy.

An air vent.

Catra leapt onto the structure and tried desperately to pry off the grate, but it was practically welded down by the screws on all four of its corners. A sudden gut feeling caused Catra to turn her head just as another lightning bolt raced towards her. Catra dropped down and grasped another pipe just below. As the bolt struck the grate, three of its screws were blown to pieces, causing it to swing down, nearly knocking Catra in the head. Seeing no better opportunity to escape, Catra used her claws to climb onto the grate, ignoring the searing burning sensation on her hands, and escaped into the vents.

Although the sound of her hands and feet on the metal walls filled her ears, Catra's enhanced hearing managed to pick up a few voices.

"That blasted animal must be stopped!"

"Send all search parties to find Catra! But bring her back to me alive!"

"See to it that your plan regarding the Heart of Etheria comes to fruition."

When she felt she was far enough away, Catra stopped to catch her breath, though she soon regretted this decision when she inhaled all the dust that had accumulated in the vents over the years.

"Heart of Etheria?" Catra thought. "What the hell is that?"

Catra shook her head and continued. Not knowing exactly where she was going, or where these pipes even led to.

"I'll figure out some way to fix this Adora. I promise."



Chapter End Notes

My spell check really hates these names XD

The very talented Legendgrass, over at Fanfiction.net, was super kind enough to draw this for me! Definitely recommend checking out her Fanfiction page cause she's written some really awesome stories!

Anyway, hope you all enjoyed my latest chapter. I've lately made the game plan for the rest of this story and have concluded that it'll be about 13 chapters long. I'm hoping to get at least one more chapter before the second season comes out, and before I lose myself in that :)

Until then: Peace!

Part 6

Chapter Notes

> Hey I actually managed to stay true to word and get another chapter out before the next season comes out!
>
> Hope you all enjoy! Thanks again for the positive words and kudos!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Glimmer cautiously poked her head out of the room and looked around.

The sound of rushing footsteps and shouts had died down a while ago. Glimmer knew that the word must've gotten out by now that intruders were within the vicinity.

Thankfully, the hallway was clear of any Horde soldiers for the time being.

Glimmer quietly stepped back into the room and allowed the door to shut.

"Okay, the coast is clear for now," Glimmer addressed the rest of the group. "According to the device, Catra should be just above us."

"And Adora?" Perfuma asked, fearful of the answer.

Glimmer looked back down at her device. The white dot and the red dot were now mere inches apart.

"Practically standing right next to her," Glimmer sighed quietly.

"Glimmer I know I'm going to regret asking this," SeaHawk began in a rarely heard serious tone. "But what do we do if we run into Adora?"

"Or if Adora runs into us?" Frosta asked, with a faint sense of worry in her voice.

Glimmer sighed again.

"Why didn't anyone tell me that being a commander involved making tough calls like this?"

Glimmer was just about to answer when something on the device caught her eye. The red dot was now moving away from the white dot at rapid speed. It moved quickly from the right, then to the left before moving further and further away. The white spot meanwhile simply moved forward at a slow, yet steady pace.

"Catra's on the move!" Glimmer cried.

"Can you figure out if we can get to her?" SeaHawk asked, his familiar cheerfulness returning full swing.

A loud bang from above startled nearly everyone in the room. A series of loud metallic thumps soon followed. Everyone could hear them moving from one end of the room to the other before they stopped in front of the vent's metal grate.

Glimmer looked at the others and gave a quick nod. She then clenched her fists together and produced a pink light that glowed throughout her hands.

A sudden loud bang echoed throughout the room again, only this time it sounded like someone was throwing all their body weight against the grate. Again and again, the banging continued. A sense of dread actually came over the group, worried that the sounds would attract the attention of the Horde soldiers faster than you could say: "For the honor of Greyskull!"

Glimmer was just about to lower her fists when the grate suddenly burst out of the wall, with Catra following suit. But while the lid collided to the ground with a loud bang, Catra managed to flip in the air and land right-side up.

Catra breathed heavily, thanking the gods for her ancestral ability to naturally land on her feet, as she gazed at the metal floor below her. But when she lifted her eyes, she was met with three princesses, and one random pirate, glaring at her with nothing but spite in their eyes.

Ordinarily, Catra would've taunted the group before she sprang into action, but under the present circumstances she had only one thing in mind: escape.

Catra got on all fours and tried to brush past the group, but before she knew it, a sparkling punch hit her in the face, a series of vines threw her against the wall and she felt herself being frozen in a block of ice. Catra struggled to break free but the ice might as well been made out of solid steel.

Accepting her fate for the moment, Catra looked up and saw Glimmer coming towards her, with a look she hadn't seen from the princess before. A look filed with so much anger and hatred, it almost made her recoil.

"What did you do to Adora?" Glimmer coldly asked.

"Tch, nice to see you too cotton candy head," Catra sarcastically replied.

But Glimmer showed no response to this jab. She only breathed slowly, as if trying everything in her power to keep from jumping onto the Magicat and beating her face to a bloody pulp.

"Okay look…I had nothing to do with this," Catra said.

"Oh, so that wasn't you that put that data crystal onto Adora's sword?" Glimmer asked, raising her voice.

Catra paused for a minute. "Okay yeah that was me but I wasn't the one who made Adora go from She-Ra to She-Nope! Shadow Weaver placed some weird magic shit on the crystal and now Adora thinks she's back on the witch's side."

"Who?" SeaHawk asked.

Catra groaned but remembered how not all of them had met her lifelong tormentor in person.

"Shadow Weaver. A complete and miserable bitch that raised us to be perfect little soldiers and favored Adora more than me. I recently took her power away but now she's back and is out to kill me using Adora. Any other questions?"

"Where is Adora?" Frosta asked in a commanding tone.

Catra glanced down at the child. "You guys babysitting now?"

Frosta's only response was forming a perfectly shaped icicle between her fingers and tossing it only inches away from Catra's head.

"She's somewhere nearby," Catra replied, deciding to play it safe. "But Entrapta's already figuring out a way to fix this so you don't need to worry your pretty little heads off."

Catra sighed, closed her eyes and cast her head down. But after nearly an entire minute of silence, Catra decided to look upwards. Everyone's faces were cast in a sea of disbelief. Perfuma in particular looked as if she were one second away from passing out.

"What did you say?" Glimmer asked quietly, her once glowing hands now resting by her side.

Catra tilted in head in confusion before the realization hit her.

"Oh that's right I guess you wouldn't know would you? Entrapta's not only alive but she's been a huge help to us over the past few months. She didn't fit in with your little posse so I thought maybe the Horde would do her much better. I don't think she even misses you much…"

Whatever else Catra intended to say was caught off by Perfuma storming up to her and slapping her hard enough to make a smacking sound despite her thick cheek fur.

"STOP IT! Stop lying to us!" Perfuma cried. "Entrapta's dead! We all saw her in the purging chambers before they…they…" The rest of Perfuma's sentence caught in her throat as she paced a hand over her mouth and turned her back on Catra.

Perfuma walked back over to the group and allowed SeaHawk to wrap an arm around her in comfort. Glimmer meanwhile pinched the bridge of her nose and tried to gather her thoughts.

"How do we know you're telling the truth?" Frosta asked. "You've lied and depicted us before. What makes you think we'd believe you now?"

Catra glared at the ice princess. "Well I can't prove jack shit when I'm frozen to the wall now can I?"

A look of hesitation crossed Frosta's face as she turned towards Glimmer. The princess of BrightMoon only nodded in return. Raising her hands, Frosta allowed the ice to melt away from Catra's body as the pool of chilly water flowed under her feet.

Catra paused, reached into a hidden side pocket and pulled out a small walkie-talkie like device. She held down a side button and began to speak into it.

"Hey Entrapta what's the 411 on the virus cure?"

Catra pushed another button on the side that allowed Entrapta's voice to fill the small room.

"Catra! Good to hear you're not feeling any animosity from earlier. I'm also glad to hear that your meeting with Shadow Weaver went seemingly well despite her hostility. Unfortunately, there's been no progress so far with said cure. It seems that whatever's infecting Adora's DNA is pervious to traditional science. But rest assured I'm working on it!"

Catra pressed the button again. "Good to know Entrapta. Hope to see you soon."

Once again, everyone's faces dropped with the exception of Catra's who only smirked. But after the initial shock wore off, Glimmer returned to her determined gaze and approached Catra until she was practically nose to nose with her.

"Take us to Entrapta now," Glimmer hissed.

"Uh do you mind giving me my personal space back first?" Catra snidely replied.

Glimmer's only response was a hard punch straight into Catra's stomach. It was so unexpected that Catra fell to the ground and began to wheeze. But after a minute she looked back up at Glimmer who only bore a look that signaled she meant business. Catra sighed, got back on her feet and walked slowly towards the door. After the door slid open, Catra glanced around and saw that the coast was clear. She glanced back to the others and motioned for them to keep moving. But before she could even get a few steps in, Catra felt her body go completely stiff. She glanced down and saw a series of vines wrapped around her body. Catra glanced back and saw Perfuma's solemn expression, a look that just screamed:

"Gods help you if you're lying to us."

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Catra sighed as she gestured to the group that the door in front of her was indeed the one to Entrapta's lab.

The journey to said lab was surprisingly uneventful, save for the few patrol guards that the princesses made short work of.

As the door slid open, everyone heard a quiet kind of humming. It didn't take long though to find the source. Scorpia, with her back turned, was happily preparing a tray of tiny cupcakes. Entrapta meanwhile was nowhere to be seen

"Catra! I was so worried after Shadow Weaver took you away. I couldn't relax until Entrapta suggested baking, and what'd you know it works! I figured you'd be feeling down after Lord Hordak yelled at you so I made you some cup…"

Upon finally turning around, Scorpia allowed the tray to crash to the floor.

"…cakes."

Catra took a deep sigh. "It's okay Scorpia they're not going to hurt us…yet. Have you seen Entrapta?"

With the look of surprise still in her eyes, Scorpia slowly nodded before calling out Entrapta's name. The purple haired princess in question, popped out of the air vent right next to her, and with the help of her hair, got on her feet.

"Scorpia! Sorry, I just figured by the echo-matic nature of Catra's voice over the recorder that she was somewhere in the vent system. I tried my best but I don't think…"

Entrapta finally turned her head and noticed the very person she was looking for standing only a few feet away, along with others she thought she would never see again.

For a long while not a sound was made. It was like everyone was trying to confirm that it was indeed Entrapta standing in front of them and not just a hologram or a robot. But after a full minute of silence, Perfuma stepped forward as a few renegade tears fell down her face.

"ENTRAPTA!"

Perfuma and the others ran forward an enveloped the genius in a full blown hug. Caught completely off guard, Entrapta simply smiled and tried to hug everyone back, whether through her real hands or her pigtails.

"I thought we'd lost you," Perfuma whispered softly.

"L-lost me?" Perfuma asked.

"We saw the flames coming out of the chamber while you were still in there!" Glimmer cried.

Entrapta raised an eyebrow before the realization came to her.

"Oh, yes the purging chamber. I made Emily's internal compartment able to hold a single person for transportation before we ran through there. I managed to get in there just in time before the flames came."

"Emily?" Glimmer asked.

Entrapta's eyes widened with excitement. "Oh where are my manners? Emily, dear we have company!"

A section of the wall, at the back of the room, slid open and a circular robot on three legs stepped forward. Emily glanced at Entrapta before it did the same thing to the others. Emily generated a low pitched beep before its purple eye turned red.

"It's okay Emily!" Entrapta ran out in front of the bot and raised both her regular and hair hands up. "They're with me."

Emily made a higher pitched whine before it bent down and allowed Entrapta to rub its head.

"Entrapta did Catra or anyone else in the Horde lay a hand on you?" Perfuma asked, as her fists slowly tightened.

"Oh no they've been very supportive of both my work and my theories. Sure Catra raises her voice sometimes but it's usually not within the range of hearing loss so it doesn't bother me. I can't wait to show you all of the amazing things I've built…"

"Wait," Frosta interrupted. "You're working for them now?"

Entrapta rubbed her hands, nervously. "Well with the help of Emily I managed to escape into the ventilation system. After Catra and

Scorpia found me I realized that I hadn't seen you guys in almost 48 hours. And after Catra convinced me that I'd be better suited to work with the Horde, I decided that it was the best possible action! Being with the Horde has allowed me to make more progress than ever before! Plus I've had ample opportunities to study First One's tech! Catra's been a big help with that too!"

Everyone's eyes glared at Catra.

"Hey don't blame me! She pretty much went along with it voluntarily. Plus you were the ones who abandoned her."

Restraining herself, Glimmer wrapped her hands around Entrapta's shoulders.

"Entrapta if we knew you were still alive we would've come back for you!"

"You…you would've?" Entrapta asked, her eyes widening.

"No princess gets left behind, remember?" Perfuma quietly spoke.

A few tears fell down Entrapta's face as she threw her arms around Glimmer's frame. Soon, Perfuma, Frosta, Seahawk and even Scorpia joined in on the group hug. Catra meanwhile simply rolled her eyes.

After a minute or two, the group broke off the hug.

"Entrapta," Glimmer said. "Catra mentioned that you were working on a cure that could fix Adora right?"

"Well I was but unfortunately whatever else is infecting Adora's DNA seems to be laced with something I've never seen before!"

"I know now though," Catra said causing everyone's eyes to fall on her once again. "When I was in Hordak's chamber, I found out that Shadow Weaver not only caused Adora to change but she also created that virus in the first place."

Scorpia's mouthed dropped while the others looked at each other in concern.

"Adora did mention to me months ago that Shadow Weaver used to be a former sorceress at Mystacor. Back then she was known as Light Spinner," Glimmer revealed.

Entrapta's eyes grew wide with excitement before she suddenly became uncharacteristically quiet.

"If what you're saying is true…I'm not sure if there's anything I can do to reverse this."

The mood in the room dropped faster than a rock off a cliff and the temperature seemed to grow colder.

"And if there is something we can do," Entrapta continued. "We'll have to do it in the next 48 hours…or Adora we'll remain in her new form forever."

Chapter End Notes

Dun dun dun

I can't be the only one that thought Glimmer's hair looks like cotton candy XD

Anyway, needless to say the next chapter's gonna be a while, with season two coming out in a couple days and me subsequently binge watching it like there's no tomorrow. But rest assured that I am working on it and hope to get it out in the next couple of weeks!

Part 7

Chapter Notes

I'M BAAACK! Did you miss me?

So I binge watched season 2 and after getting over the fact that there were only seven episodes, I found myself loving it all the same! In terms of continuity though, I'll borrow some elements from Season 2 but for the most part this story is still an AU version set after Season 1.

Also when I looked at the end credits for the episode 'System Failure', I found that the servants names where literally their occupations (Baker, Busgirl and Sodapop). So for this story I decided to give them some names I made up. Respectively, they are Aries, Molly and Renny.

Enough ranting though, let's get to the story!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

No matter how many times she repeated the word, it still sounded just as foreign.

"Daughter?" Adora asked in a whisper.

"Yes," The voice replied. "A near perfect image of what I've always wanted for you."

Adora shook her head. "I don't understand."

"Oh hush now sweet baby," The voice whispered. "You've tried so hard to understand the wrong things for far too long. Now you can be at peace."

Adora struggled to break away from whatever was holding her, but the thing's grasp might as well been made out of steel and glue.

"No! This isn't right" Adora cried. "I have to…"

A sharp pain, almost like an electric shock, shot through Adora's brain. She let out a short cry before a dopey smile spread across her face.

"That's funny," Adora laughed. "For a second I thought I had… like…a job or something." Adora laughed again. "Isn't that just weird mommy?"

The voice said nothing in return as the darkness continued to reclaim Adora as one of its own.

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Bow sighed as he saw the small castle of Dryl coming closer and closer into view.

It had been one month exactly since the Horde had seized control over the kingdom, intending to use it as a vantage point to gain more ground. However, thanks to the efforts of the Rebellion, the Horde had vacated the premise and left it in the hands of the people, considering that their princess was no longer with them. The whole thing gave the young archer a bittersweet feeling. He was overjoyed that the kingdom's residents could return to their land, without the fear of living under Horde rule, but yet felt a sense of melancholy as he knew that they were still left without a princess to guide them.

"Uh quick question," Mermista spoke up, snapping Bow out of his thoughts. "If we have a horse that can fly, why couldn't we just use like use him to fly here?"

"Well I'm all for helping the greater good but I'm not so much a fan of a broken back," Swift Wind replied. "Plus, you get much more exercise this way."

Mermista muttered a 'whatever' under her breath as they came upon the castle entrance.

"Okay everyone," Bow said. "We need to be very careful around here. There are several booby traps laid out all over the place. So we need to watch our step…"

"What could be out here that's so dangerous?" Swift Wind replied as he kicked over a stone.

But no sooner had he done so, a section of the road in front of them gave way, revealing a shallow pit with several, sharp spikes.

Swift Wind's eyes bulged. "Uh all those in favor of flying into the kingdom immediately hop on my back."

Everyone nodded in unison before they climbed onto the stallion's back and allowed him to take them to the center of the kingdom's square.

Upon touching down, Bow could see Aries, the castle's former baker sweeping out a section of the square. Upon noticing the group, Aries's eyes lit up with excitement.

"Bow!" Aries cried as she ran towards the archer and enveloped him in a hug. "It's so good to see you again!"

Bow chuckled. "It's great seeing you too. After we heard the Horde took over Dryl, I was worried that…"

Aries seemed to pick up on the rest of Bow's sentence as she nodded. "We were fortunate enough to get out when we did. I'm just thankful you managed to drive the Horde away."

"Has there been any change?" Bow asked, regarding the castle.

Aries shook her head. "Well there's a lot more Horde flags within the hallways, and most of the pictures seemed to have been replaced with Hordak paintings but otherwise the castle's in pretty good shape. But enough about that, what brings you all out here? If I'd known you were coming I would've gone back into the kitchen and prepared some more tiny food and…"

Aries noticed the group's solemn expressions after as soon as the words left her mouth.

"Is something wrong?"

Bow sighed and placed a hand on the baker's shoulder as he and the others, minus Swift Wind, walked into the castle.

"We have a lot to talk about."

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Every fiber in Catra's body tensed as the words left Entrapta's mouth.

She couldn't remember exactly walking up to the genius and grabbing her shirt, she could only recall being face to face with Entrapta's wide-eyed expression and hissing into her face.

"What do you mean you can't reverse this? You can rebuild robots, hack into runestones and make tiny food but you can't figure out how a First One's virus works?!"

Before Entrapta could reply, Catra felt a series of vines wrap around her frame as before. Knowing her culprit this time, Catra glanced back at Perfuma's hardened gaze.

"Don't you ever touch her like that again," Perfuma said slowly, her right eye slightly twitching.

Catra let herself relax a bit as she glanced back at Entrapta whose eyes were glued to her workstation computer.

"Remember when I said there was some other matter attached to Adora's DNA?"

Catra nodded.

"Well it seems completely obstinate to all traditional methods, including electricity, DNA duplication, carbon printing…"

"Entrapta," Catra growled.

"The point is, I'm almost completely out of ideas on how to fix this," Entrapta hung her head.

"Wait a minute," Glimmer said after turning her head towards Entrapta's computer, which held Adora's DNA in question. "I think I recognize this. I remember Aunt Casta mentioning how certain sorcerers and sorceresses had this particular gene in their blood. It allows them to handle magical properties better than others. I can't be sure but I think this might be it."

"So Adora's a wizard after all," SeaHawk commented as he rubbed his mustache. "It all makes perfect sense."

Catra had to hold in a laugh at seeing the utter annoyance on Glimmer's face.

"No!" Glimmer replied. "But since Shadow Weaver was once a sorceress at Mystacor it's only natural that it's her gene within Adora's DNA!"

"So how do we get rid of it oh sparkly one?" Catra slowly asked.

Glimmer glared at Catra. "Why do you care? I thought you Horde soldiers didn't care about destroying people's lives?"

Catra hissed at Glimmer as she glanced back. "Is it so hard to believe that maybe, just maybe, I don't want Adora to suffer as much?"

"Yes," Everyone replied in unison.

Catra groaned and shook her head. "Look with me and Adora…it's complicated. But either way Shadow Weaver has done something to her and…she doesn't deserve anything that's become of it."

"But scratching her back and almost killing her is totally fine?" Glimmer snapped back.

Catra snarled and ripped away the vines with her claws. She stepped closer to Glimmer until they were only a foot apart. "You know the more you open your mouth, the more I just want to rip that tongue right out of it."

A deafening silence filled the air as the two rivals stared each other down. Everyone watched with bated breath, with the exception of Entrapta who was rambling on about witnessing a one-of-a-kind social experiment.

A loud buzzing replaced the silence.

Everyone looked around confused until Scorpia pulled out a small radio-like device.

"Oh sorry just have to take this call," Scorpia said as she pushed the button on the side and held the device up to her ear.

"Hello? Lord Hordak I wasn't expecting to hear from you! Huh? Catra she's…"

As Scorpia glanced at her wildcat in question, Catra's eyes widened more than she had ever seen them before and her hands frantically waved in front of her.

"I…haven't seen her. Yes. Yes I'll keep looking for her but if I may what purpose do you have with Catra?"

Scorpia's eyes widened in fear and her chest got noticeably tighter.

"I…understand lord Hordak but surely she still has good intentions. She's gotten closer to conquering BrightMoon than any…"

Scorpia suddenly pulled the device away from her ear and looked down at it in confusion. She then looked back at Catra with worry flowing from her eyes.

"Wildcat…I think you need to tell me what exactly is going on."

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"And so we came here, hoping to find something that could shed some light on this virus." Bow explained to Aries.

"But we were all around that virus last time and none of us got infected," Aries replied.

"I'm not entirely sure but I think since Adora's sword is First One's tech it must have spread into her through that. After all, it doesn't seem to affect organic matter unless there's direct physical contact."

Aries walked in silence for a moment. "Just promise me that you'll destroy that damn disc for good when you get a hold of it."

"I promise, we all do," Bow glanced back and saw everyone nodding their heads in complete agreement.

Walking deeper into the castle, Bow and the others were immediately greeted by the rest of Entrapta's former servants, Renny and Molly.

After they briefly exchanged words, the three servants led the group down the hallway, with one of Entrapta's servant robots leading the way.

"I didn't think Entrapta's robots would still be moving around after all this time," Bow commented.

"I remember Entrapta telling us how she made their battery life last as long as ten years," Molly replied. "So that they could keep working in case of anything bad happening to her."

The air around the group grew heavy. Bow could never forget the looks on their faces when he informed them that their kingdom's princess was dead.

"I'm sorry…again," Bow said after what felt an eternity. "I wish there was more we could've done to save her."

Aries gave a sympathetic smile and wrapped her arm around Bow's shoulder.

"Entrapta used to tell me that focusing on your past failures won't create tomorrow's better inventions. I think that applies in more ways than one, doesn't it?"

Bow glanced over his shoulder and saw Mermista, Netossa and Spinerella nodding in agreement. Bow gave a small smile as they continued down the hallway until the servant-esque robot stopped in front of a seemingly random wall.

Gesturing them to step closer, the group stepped forward the robot as it fired a light into the wall, causing it to swing around them and transport them to the other side.

Upon reaching the door to Entrapta's lab, the servant bot rapidly typed the code into the keypad which allowed the door to open.

The lab was frozen in time.

Several bots, no doubt from their previous encounter, littered the floor. Several experiments and diagrams were left in a state of mid completion and a thick layer of dust left no space untouched.

"Uh, creepy much?" Mermista asked.

"The Horde left this room untouched," Renny replied. "Probably because of how hard it is to get too."

Bow nodded. "Any idea where the information on that data crystal is stored?"

Renny shook his head. "Entrapta was always pretty tight lipped on her work around us. Probably because we never understood a single word of it."

"Did she tell you anything about this crystal specifically?" Netossa asked.

"Nothing that you guys probably know already, it was found in the mines months ago and contained more First One's code than any of the previous artifacts."

"Well if I know Entrapta," Bow said as he walked over to the genius's computer system. "She always keeps detailed notes on anything she's ever worked on. Practically no detail left out."

Bow flicked a switch on the side of the table which caused the computer screens to glow brightly within the darkened room.

"And I'm just hoping to find something, anything, that can help Adora before it's too late."

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"And after I escaped into the ventilation system I ran into cotton candy head and the rest of her group."

Scorpia's eyes widened and her claws grew noticeably shakier. "Hordak and Shadow Weaver are back in cahoots with each other again? I-I-It can't be. Maybe if I persuade Hordak enough he'll consider going easy on you and everything will be alright."

"What is wrong with you?" Catra angrily asked. "Hordak wants me dead! Dead! Do you understand that? I can't come back here anymore, Princess Attitude is going to throw me in prison if I go with her to BrightMoon and Entrapta, the one person I thought could help Adora, can't help Adora! Does that sound like everything's alright?"

Scorpia's face dropped and her eyes fell to the side.

"Karma's a bitch isn't it?" Glimmer said.

Catra's head snapped back towards Glimmer with fire in her eyes. She was just about to march forward and rip the glittery princess to pieces when SeaHawk stepped between them.

"If my methods of observation are correct, and they are of course, it seems that you two are after the same thing."

"Uh who are you and why are you talking to me?" Catra asked, her fiery eyes doused with annoyance.

"Captain Seahawk, master of the high seas and lover of ADVENTURE!"

Catra rolled her eyes. "Okay captain dumbass what's this thing me and Twinkles are after?"

"Adora of course."

This simple sentence caused the two females to stop whatever else they were about to say.

"Glimmer wants to help Adora get back to her normal self while you…for some strange and complex kind of way, want Adora to be her normal self too. Perhaps if we work together we can ensure will be alright in the end."

Glimmer and Catra both snapped their heads to look at SeaHawk, each of them glaring intently.

"Or perhaps we could just kill each other! An experienced adventurer follows any course!"

As SeaHawk made his way back to the group, Glimmer looked down and sighed.

"SeaHawk's right. While we're here arguing with each other, Adora's still trapped in that…thing that Shadow Weaver created. We have to help her…somehow."

"And you think you know how to do it?" Catra asked, her tone lighter than Glimmer had ever heard it before.

Glimmer bent her head to the side. "Maybe. Since it's most likely a sorceress's gene in Adora's blood, it only makes sense that we

need either Aunt Casta or another sorcerer to help fix this."

Catra sighed. "Well since I'm no longer welcomed here, I guess I'll show you guys the way out of here and go with you on the condition that I'm not held against my will when this is all over."

Glimmer raised an eyebrow. "How about we call a temporary truce to help Adora and we don't kill each other in the process."

Catra stayed quiet for a minute before a ghost of a smile crossed her face. "Tough bargain, but I guess you got a deal pinky."

"And my name is Glimmer."

"Whatever, let's just get out of here before Shadow Weaver finds us."

As Catra started to make her way to the door, she glanced back at Scorpia and Entrapta.

"You two are coming too."

Scorpia's eyes lit up in a combination of surprise and excitement. "Wow! Really? I mean I'll gladly go wherever you go Catra but why do you want us to tag along?"

A rare solemn look came into Catra's eyes. "You saw how Shadow Weaver looked at you two before she dragged me away. If she's onboard to kill me…I don't want to imagine what she'd do to you guys."

Entrapta slowly nodded while Scorpia's face beamed brightly as she wrapped Catra in another bone-crushing hug.

"I knew that somewhere beneath that sour expression and mangy hair you truly cared about us!"

Catra tried in vain to escape the princess's grasp. "I do not! You guys…just annoy me the least."

Any resentment in Catra's voice went completely under Scorpia's radar as she continued to hug Catra until she eventually let her down slowly.

"We'll need to get to the vehicle bay if we want to get out of here," Glimmer said. "And after…last time…I'm not sure I want to go through the purging chambers again."

While most nodded their heads, Entrapta's eyes widened as another light bulb went off in her head.

"My time in the Fright Zone has opened my eyes to all sorts of ways to get around the base. But I find that the air ducts are the fastest mode of transportation from one area to another!"

"Do you think it can lead us to the skiff bay?" Glimmer asked.

"Does a quatatomic solvent solidify into a quatermass of electrified subatomic particles?"

Catra groaned. "Just show us the way so I don't have to use your pigtails as a scratching post."

Entrapta walked over to the back of the room and pulled the grate off the air vent before she monitored everyone to follow her lead. Catra immediately followed, then Scorpia, Glimmer, Frosta, Perfuma and finally SeaHawk.

Aside from the thin streams of light from the other grates, the inside of the ducts was practically pitch black. Catra couldn't even fathom how Entrapta could've navigated this system as easily as she could.

But after what felt an eternity of crawling, Catra finally heard the sounds of another grate being pushed to the floor with a loud bang. Ordinarily, Catra would've scolded Entrapta for making such a loud noise when they were trying to be discreet but she was honestly happy just to be free of the dark and dusty catacombs in the ceiling.

As soon as she crawled out of the vent, Catra saw that they were outside the base in the vehicle bay. Numerous skiffs were lined up in an almost synchronized fashion but suspiciously, the area was completely devoid of life. No guards were patrolling the area, no soldiers were piloting the aircraft in and out of the area and not a single sound could be heard.

"I don't like this," Scorpia said as she looked around intently. "The bay's not normally this quiet."

Catra ran ahead of everyone and approached the closest skiff.

"Look who cares if this place is empty or not?! Let's just grab a skiff so we can…"

Catra's razor sharp senses allowed her to avoid the blade coming straight for her head. She leapt out of the way and turned her head.

"Hey Catra, where were we?" Adora asked as she gave a demented smile.

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"Ugh!" Mermista groaned as she flipped through another notebook. "We've been here for hours and there's like nothing here except techno babble."

"I hate to say it Bow," Spinerella said. "But this trip may have been for nothing."

As much as he hated to admit it, Bow knew that it was true. Whatever data they had located on the crystal only revealed what they had already knew. But somewhere, in the back of his mind, Bow knew that there had to be something they missed.

Netossa's coughing snapped Bow out of his trance.

"Can we go now?" Netossa asked before coughing. "This dust is really irritating my lungs."

"Hang on dear," Spinerella replied. "Maybe I can help clean this place up."

Spinerella directed a giant cyclone through the room, causing the dust to lift off Entrapta's inventions while also causing everyone to cough violently.

"Stop! Stop! That's enough!" Renny cried.

In response Spinerella opened the lab door and guided the dust filled cyclone outside. With the dust gone, Bow rubbed his eyes vigorously and soon noticed something that had caught his eye. A small green button lay on the side of the computer. As soon as Bow pushed it, a portion of the worktable gave way and a small glass display rose up in its place. Various recorder tapes were aligned in perfect order, all labeled with various dates and codes.

But one in particular caught Bow's eyes. One particular tape read 03/N0.58. Opening the glass case, Bow pulled the tape out and tried to figure out how to play it, since there was no recorder around. But then he soon noticed a small slot on the side of the computer screen. Bow inserted the cassette and allowed Entrapta's voice to fill the room.

"Log day 71. 72? I'm not sure; anyway my staff has just brought me one of the most intact data crystals I've ever seen! Normally these crystals are missing 50 percent of their original form but this one has somehow survived the test of time. One possible reason for this is the carbon dating surrounding the crystal. According to my most recent tests, the carbon dates back only 20 years ago. Quite an unusual find considering most data crystal's carbon dates are around 1000 or more years. But I'm sure with further testing I can pinpoint as to why this is. Meanwhile my efforts at creating tiny food…"

Bow pressed the green button again causing the system to shut off and the rest of the recording to be silenced.

"Well that was super helpful," Mermista sarcastically commented.

"I'm not even sure what to make out of that," Aries replied.

"Well carbon dating usually refers to how old the soil is surrounding certain artifacts," Bow replied as he placed his chin in his hand. "The fact that this particular data crystal is only 20 years old means that even though the crystal is ancient, it's only been in that mine for about 20 years."

"So someone or something put it there?" Netossa hypothesized.

"I'm not sure but it's definitely something we should pass onto Queen Angella when we get back." Bow turned his attention to the former servants. "Thanks again for everything."

Aries rubbed the back of her neck. "Wish we could've offered you more information but it's always a pleasure to see you and your friends."

Bow smiled as the servants showed them the way out of the castle back to Swift Wind.

"I really wish I was with Glimmer right now." Mermista thought.

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"I really wish I was with Mermista right now," Glimmer's mind raced as she glanced at her transformed friend.

Adora gave out a bestial cry as she charged forward with inhuman speed. Catra barely managed to jump clear of the blade as she pounced off Adora's back and flipped over behind her.

Perfuma shot out a stream of vines out of her hands, causing Adora's body to be completely wrapped in the green foliage. But Adora simply smirked and caused the vines to turn into a sickly black color. Perfuma cut the vines away just in time as a stream of corrosive acid shout out of its ends.

"Get to the skiff!" Frosta yelled. "I'll try and hold her off!"

"Yeah?" Scorpia asked fearfully. "You and what army?"

"This one!"

Frosta crossed her arms in front of her and allowed a thick form of ice to encase her entire body. Then just as suddenly as it had appeared, the ice flew off of Frosta's body and broke off into a thousand pieces. Each piece suddenly formed a perfect sculpture of Frosta and ran towards Adora.

While Adora effortlessly punched and kicked each ice sculpture to pieces, the rest of the group ran past their infected friend and made their way to an undamaged skiff.

Catra got on all fours and ran as fast as her limbs could muster. But just as she reached the end of the skiff, Catra felt something catch her foot mid-air as her whole body went completely motionless. Crashing onto the dirt, Catra looked back and saw her foot was completely wrapped in a whip mustered from Adora's sword.

Adora threw the whip back, releasing Catra's foot, as it reverted back to a sword. As Adora got closer, she raised her sword high in the air. While laughing manically, Adora eyed the young Magicat like a predator that had just cornered its prey.

"ADORA WAIT!" Catra screamed, her eyes stinging from the tears. "PLEASE DON'T DO THIS!"

Adora only laughed harder as she stood overtop the frightened girl and grabbed the hilt with both hands.

"Goodbye Catra," Adora whispered as she raised the sword into the air, aiming it at Catra's throat. "I really am going to miss you."

But before Adora could plunge the blade into Catra's neck, Catra felt the ground rumble around her.

"GET AWAY FROM HER!"

And before she even knew what was happening, Catra saw Scorpia tackle Adora to the ground, knocking the sword out of her hands. Using her claws, Scorpia landed hit after hit across Adora's face. But even as black blood oozed out of her mouth, the twisted smile on Adora's face never changed.

Scorpia grabbed the front of Adora's purple costume and hoisted her in the air, intending on knocking her far away enough to give them enough time to escape. But before she could deliver the blow, Adora outstretched her hand, causing the sword to fly off the ground and back into her hand. It happened so fast that Scorpia had barely enough time to process it before she felt a sharp pain across her chest. She then felt a warm, sticky liquid flow down the rest of her body.

Scorpia stumbled briefly but somehow gathered enough strength to punch Adora squarely in the chest. Adora cried out in surprise as she flew back and crashed through the wall of the base. Scorpia fell to the ground in a daze, as the crimson liquid leaked out of her uniform and painted the dirt below her. Suddenly, Scorpia felt herself being encased in a sea of sparkles. And before she knew it, Scorpia found herself on the skiff as it rose up into the air, piloted by SeaHawk.

Scorpia closed her eyes in exhaustion as she allowed the voices to flow freely into her ears.

"We have to hurry!" Scorpia heard Entrapta cry. "This gash looks pretty deep. Failure to stop blood flow within an hour could result in a loss of limbs or even…"

"Entrapta!" Scorpia then heard Catra yell. "Either do something to help or shut up!"

Scorpia opened her eyes and saw Entrapta pull out a portable kit and began pulling out medical supplies, such as rubbing alcohol and bandages. While Entrapta ripped off pieces of her uniform and tried to tie them around her chest, Scorpia saw Catra's concerned face come into view.

"Scorpia? Are you okay?"

Scorpia tried to sit up but immediately fell back down once she felt her chest cry out in protest.

"Been better," Scorpia breathed, but still maintaining a gentle smile. "But I'm glad you're safe."

"You could've gotten killed you moron!" Catra yelled, her face angry albeit with a look of sadness in her eyes. "Why would you risk your life for me?"

Scorpia simply smiled. "Best friends look out for each other, remember? Just like how you're trying to help Adora after everything you guys have been through."

Whatever comeback Catra had initially planned died in her throat once Scorpia mentioned Adora's name.

"Just try not to die on the way back okay?" Catra asked, her face lightening.

Scorpia raised her arm as best as she could. "You're wish is my command great leader!"

Catra gently shook and her and sat on the edge of the skiff, her mind drifting away as she gazed upon the changing landscape below.

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As the dust settled over the skiff bay, Adora calmly walked out of the hole in the wall. She carried herself as someone who had a slight cold as opposed to someone who had been punched repeatedly and got thrown through a wall.

As Adora continued walking forward, something caught her eye.

A single black claw, no doubt from Catra, lay on the ground.

Adora picked the piece up and took a long sniff of the broken fragment.

"Run while you can kitty cat," Adora whispered as she gazed up at the skiff moving further and further over the horizon. "With a scent as strong as yours, I'll catch up to you soon enough."

Chapter End Notes

Hopefully this chapter was worth the wait!

As most of you know Season 3 is coming out August 2nd! So I'm making it a personal goal to try and finish this story before the third season comes out!

Will I succeed? Don't know but I'll have fun trying! :)

Feel free to leave comments about the story or even just what your favorite part of Season 2 was!

Part 8

Chapter Notes

So far this is probably one of my favorite chapters to write! Lots of action ahead! So let's get to it! :)

Thanks again for all of your lovely comments and kudos!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Queen Angella gave a heavy sigh as Bow finished describing everything they had gathered from Dryl.

"So you're saying your trip to Dryl was uneventful?" Angella asked.

"Aside from avoiding the various castle deathtraps it was a total drag," Mermista replied.

Bow hung his head. "I'm sorry we couldn't have done more your majesty."

The gentle touch on his shoulder made Bow gradually lift his head to meet Angella's soft smile.

"Bow, the worst thing you could've done was nothing at all. I appreciate you, all of you, for at least trying to find some way to help Adora."

A snort from beside her made the queen chuckle briefly before she petted the majestic steed's head.

"And you too Swift Wind."

Suddenly, the giant meeting doors flew open as several palace guards rushed in.

"Your majesty," One of the guards said. "Princess Glimmer and the others have just landed in the courtyard."

Angella immediately rushed towards the guard. "Is she alright? Are they all alright?"

"They seem to have no external injuries but they also brought along two members of the Horde and one…hostage."

"Hostage?" Angella repeated.

"Yes it appears to be Princess Entrapta."

Bow felt his heart nearly leap out of his chest.

"Entrapta?! Alive?! It can't be, we all saw the flames shoot through the purging chambers. It can't be. And yet…I want it to be."

"Well? What are we all doing standing around?" Swift Wind asked. "Let's go check it out!"

Angella quickly nodded and instructed the guards to bring as many of them as possible before she and everyone else raced out of the room.

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Glimmer sighed as she felt the skiff touchdown on the ground below.

Entrapta had managed to slow the bleeding, but Scorpia seemed to grow paler and paler by the minute.

Glancing up at the castle, Glimmer could already see a plethora of guards racing away in the opposite direction, no doubt informing her mother of their arrival.

As everyone disembarked from the skiff, Glimmer could see Catra and Entrapta hoisting Scorpia down gently on the floor.

"Just stay calm Scorp," Catra said. "We'll get you patched up."

Glimmer could see Scorpia move her head and smile slightly, but it was obvious that the large woman was fading by the second.

"GLIMMER!"

Glimmer snapped her head back and saw her mother and several palace guards rushing towards her.

"Oh Glimmer I'm so glad you're safe!" Angella whispered as she hugged her daughter tight.

After breaking the hug, Angella looked over and felt sick to her stomach when she noticed Scorpia on the ground.

"Glimmer…"

"Mom, Adora nearly killed us trying to get out of the Fright Zone. Scorpia tried to hold her off but Adora sliced her across the chest and she's bleeding really bad. I know she's a Horde soldier but she still tried to save us and now she's probably going to die and you're going to hate me for being so stupid and…"

The gentle touch on her shoulder caused Glimmer's increasingly fast rant to die in her throat.

"We can discuss this all later Glimmer," Angella said with a slight smile. "Right now there's a life that needs to be saved. Guards, take Scorpia into the medical bay and keep constant watch on her at all times. And escort Catra to the dungeons."

The guards nodded before some of them carried Scorpia away while the others cuffed Catra's hands and feet and dragged her forward.

As Catra passed by Glimmer, the two of them made brief eye contact. And while Glimmer's eyes showed a hint of sadness, Catra's only showed resentment. Whether it was for her current situation or Adora's current situation she couldn't tell.

"GLIMMER!"

Glimmer turned her head and saw Bow, Mermista, Spinerella and Netossa riding on Swift Wind's back as he touched down beside her. After disembarking from the horse, each of them ran forward and hugged Glimmer all at once. Bow's eyes soon fell upon Entrapta, who was standing by the skiff awkwardly, as if she had no idea how to react to the situation.

But when the two made eye contact with each other, they became less like humans and more like a deer caught in a blinding light.

"ENTRAPTA!"

Bow ran faster than he had in his entire life as he enveloped the genius in a bone-crushing hug.

"Uh, Bow," Entrapta wheezed after a few minutes. "As much as I'm fascinated by public displays of affection, my lungs still need about 70 percent capacity to breathe."

No sooner had Bow broken free; Spinerella and Netossa also wrapped the genius between their arms. Mermista meanwhile gave a small smile as she placed her hand on Entrapta's shoulder.

"Could you not scare us again like that?" Mermista asked. "I'd like to keep grey hairs away for at least another four decades."

Noticing Angella coming towards them, the three women stepped beside Entrapta as the tall woman placed both of her hands on the girl's shoulders.

"You don't know how grateful I am to have you back in our presence Entrapta. I only hope that your technological expertise can help save Adora."

"Well my efforts have proven fruitless so far, but I'm sure that I can still aid in the rebellion's efforts for a short time."

Angella's face dropped. "Short time?"

"Well…yes. Since the Horde has provided me with more than enough resources to pursue my scientific interests, and has given me so much more First One's tech to work with, I figured that after Adora's condition has improved, I could just…return to the Fright Zone."

Whatever happiness was in the air was shattered. Angella in particular could barely contain the shock on her face.

"Entrapta…whose side are you on?" Angella managed to ask.

"I'm on the side of SCIENCE of course!" Entrapta beamed, as if it were a stupid question. "But based on my experience with the Horde, and the fact that Catra and Scorpia have proven to be better company for me than the other princesses I guess…the Horde?"

Angella lowered her head and closed her eyes as she tried to wrap her brain around the young girl's thoughts.

"Glimmer?" Angella finally asked. "Where you aware of this?"

Glimmer's face dropped. "Mom…Entrapta mentioned that Catra convinced her to join the Horde. But she thought we abandoned her and we thought she was dead. We thought that maybe… Shadow Weaver did something to her mind that made her willing to work for the Horde."

Entrapta laughed. "Well that's completely non-factual since Catra severed Shadow Weaver's connection with the Black Garnet around the same time. I'm glad she did though otherwise I couldn't have been able to hack into the Black Garnet and see its effects on the planet."

"That was you?" Bow asked, a tinge of sadness in his voice.

Entrapta glanced over at the archer and only then noticed the looks of the others. Mermista and Frosta both had a look of anger mixed with shock, Spinerella, Netossa and SeaHawk had shocked

expression, Swift Wind simply bore a look of confusion and both Glimmer and Bow looked simply depressed.

But it was the look on Perfuma's face that really caught the inventor off guard. The flower princess looked like she had just been slapped in the face. Her eyes showed nothing but disappointment and despair. It gave the Dryl princess an uneasy feeling, one she hadn't felt in a long time.

"Guards," Angella's voice made Entrapta glance back at the queen who by now had eradicated the smile off her voice as a coldness took over her features. "Place Entrapta under arrest."

"WHAT?" Glimmer asked loudly. "But mom I'm sure…"

But the sparkly princess's words fell on deaf ears as two palace guards came up and forced Entrapta's arms behind her back and placed her hands in crystal handcuffs.

"I…don't understand," Entrapta asked, her voice cracking slightly.

"Princess Entrapta you are charged with treason, based on your actions with the Horde. What do you have to say for yourself?"

Entrapta's eyes fell to the floor. "I fail to see how pursuing scientific interests constitutes as a crime."

Angella sighed. "We will hold a trial once this matter with Adora is sorted. Once you are found guilty you can expect to receive life imprisonment for your actions or a possible execution if the council deems it necessary."

The gravity of the situation finally began to weigh in Entrapta's mind. As the guards began to take her away she made eye-contact with Glimmer, who simply mouthed the words:

"I'm sorry."

Once Entrapta has far out of range, Angella walked up and placed a hand on Glimmer's shoulder.

"Glimmer when we get back to the meeting room, I want you to tell me everything."

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"And then we managed to escape from the Fright Zone while trying to heal Scorpia's wounds."

As Glimmer finished recapping the previous events, Angella sighed and placed her forehead against her entwined hands.

"By the way…" Glimmer started to ask before being interrupted by Angella.

"Don't worry," Angella replied as she brought her head up. "I just got word from the doctors that say that Scorpia is in stable condition. In fact if it wasn't for Entrapta's quick thinking she may have died from blood loss much sooner."

"This is why Entrapta could still prove effective for the rebellion!" Glimmer argued. "She's the only one who could possibly find a cure for this virus!"

"And you think this automatically forgives her actions of hacking into the Black Garnett, destroying the Whispering Woods and joyfully conversing with the Horde?"

Glimmer tried to make a comeback but could only muster a few quiet murmurs as Bow rubbed her arm in silent comfort.

"Besides," Angella continued. "If Adora truly has been infected with a sort of Sorceress gene, then it could have only been made by a Sorcerer or former Sorcerer, in this case Light Spi-Shadow Weaver." Angella breathed out. "And there's only one person I know of that could shed light on any of this."

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Castapella hummed a happy tune as she finished watering her two hanging plants in her main study.

While most Sorcerers typically used magic to grow their plants, Castapella always preferred the old fashioned methods. In part, it made her feel proud whenever she could create something beautiful based on her own efforts rather than simply using magic as an easy method.

Castapella was just about to put her watering can away when a knock came at the door.

"Yes?" Castapella asked.

As the door opened, a young servant girl peeked her head through the door.

"Castapella there's someone here to see you, says it's of the upmost importance."

Castapella sighed. "Alright send them in. But they'll have to make it quick. I'm on my way to…"

Queen Angella stepped into the room as if she were stepping into a royal ball.

"Angella." Castapella breathed.

"It's been a while," Angella replied.

"I didn't know it was once in a blue moon already!" Castapella laughed but the queen's expression bore no sign of amusement.

"Can I offer you a chair and some tea?" Castapella asked after an awkward silence.

Angella nodded as she took the chair opposite Castapella's desk. Castapella grabbed the teapot off the heater in the corner, along with two small cups before she made her way back to the desk. Castpella poured the dark colored liquid into both cups before she handed one to Angella. Angella and Castapella both took a slow sip of their teas as another awkward silence filled the room.

"This is nice," Castapella said. "We should do this more often, if you decide to visit me more that is."

Angella lowered her head. "I didn't think you'd want to make fancy with the person that ordered the battle that killed your brother."

Castapella nearly dropped her cup. "A-Angella you can't still possibly blame yourself for…"

"Please Castapella…" Angella raised her hand. "As much as I'd love to discuss this further I'm afraid that there's another matter to attend to, one involving Adora. She's in horrible trouble."

"What do you mean?" Castapella asked as her eyes widened.

Angella took a deep breath as she tried to gather her thoughts. "One of Adora's former friends, Catra, managed to infect her Sword with a corrupted First One's data crystal and it…turned Adora into some sort of monster. At first we didn't know why this was, considering that the last time this happened it only made Adora slightly disorientated." Angella took a deep breath. "But after Entrapta ran some tests, it showed that a sorcerer's gene had attached itself to Adora's own DNA. And there's only one sorcerer who could've had that same kind of dark magic and was capable of performing it."

With shaking hands, Castapella placed her teacup back on the table. "L-Light Spinner."

Angella nodded. "Or Shadow Weaver as she calls herself now."

Castapella shook her head and placed her head in her hands. She only looked up when she felt a light pressure on her arm. Glancing up, Castapella saw Angella giving the sorceress a sympathetic smile.

"Please Casta, Adora has less than two days before she's trapped in that body forever. We need all the help we can get."

Castapella sighed. "I'm not sure where to begin."

"Shadow Weaver somehow knew how to infect First One's tech to change a person's make-up like that. How could she have possibly have known that?"

Castapella stood up and walked over to the large window behind her.

"When Light Spinner first found out about the Horde she purposed a way to use First One's crystals to their advantage. She thought that by using her magic, she could allow the crystals to infect the Horde's technology so that it would either malfunction or turn against the soldiers using it. But after sometime, she went even further with her idea, convinced that her data crystals could try and infect the soldiers themselves. They would possess such powers as teleportation, shape-shifting, electric powers and more. Light Spinner had managed to retrieve a particular crystal, a green one, from the mines of Dryl. She was convinced that this one crystal could infect an entire squadron of Horde soldiers and make them slaves to their cause."

Castapella stopped briefly to gather her thoughts.

"Much like the Spell of Obtainment, Master Norwyn absolutely forbade Light Spinner from performing such a twisted spell, considering it far too dangerous to infuse First Ones tech and Sorcerer genes into a regular person. Thankfully, Light Spinner soon gave up this plan when she focused all of her efforts on achieving the Spell of Obtainment with Micah. After Light Spinner vanished, Micah and I thought we were safe."

Castapella placed her hand against the windows as the unpleasant memories rose to surface despite trying desperately to bury them for years.

"We were wrong."

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As the Moons began to set, the hallway in front of Micah grew darker and darker.

The young sorcerer quickened his pace.

In the past, he used to enjoy wandering through the multiple, giant hallways within the kingdom. Whether it was to glance at the statues of former Sorcerers or to look at the many paintings and sculptures that decorated the halls, Micah always found the hallways to be his personal sanctuary.

But after what happened to his former mentor, the hallways began to feel colder, darker and almost devoid of any life, even if there happened to be some around. Micah also felt like he was being watched by someone or perhaps something. It was almost as if Light Spinner's presence was permanently stained on the grounds of Mystacor, even after a year had passed since the former sorceress was corrupted by the dark magic she sought to control.

Since then, Micah also became somewhat more responsible. He was still just as eager to fly into action and try out new spells but a sort of maturity had grown on him. With each new day, he practiced harder and harder, hoping to perfect his skills so that no one else would suffer at the hands of the Horde or dark magic.

Feeling various eyes peering at his back, Micah hurried down the hallway to his room.

When he reached his destination, Micah threw open the door and ducked inside quickly. He closed the door behind him before he leaned against it and caught his breath. Once his heart was at a steadier pace, Micah opened his eyes and found his room to be in near complete darkness. This was odd considering that he was sure that he had left his bioluminescence lamp on earlier.

The room itself felt colder than the air outside and the overwhelming feeling of being watched, instead of receding like it usually did when he entered his room, only grew stronger.

"Micah."

The hollow voice nearly made the boy jump out of his skin.

"Hello?" Micah asked.

Micah spun his head in all directions, trying to find the source of the voice. But when he looked at the far right-hand corner, Micah felt the air rush out of his lungs.

A lone figure stood in the corner with its back turned to him. The figure wore a purple gown that was so long Micah couldn't see their feet. The figure's long black hair flowed upwards like it had a mind of its own and their skin was a sickly color of blue and grey.

Micah backed up against the door. "Who are you? How'd you get in here?"

The figure turned around and Micah felt the soulless white eyes bore into his soul.

"Don't you recognize your old teacher Micah?"

Micah's eyes widened as he felt his heart nearly stop dead in its tracks.

"L-L-Light Spinner?" Micah whispered.

Light Spinner narrowed her eyes and shot out a beam of red electricity through her hands which shattered the lamp on Micah's desk into a thousand pieces.

"Never use that name in my presence again. The woman you knew as Light Spinner died that day the Spell of Obtainment was cast. But you may call me Shadow Weaver, the Horde's second in command."

Micah's mouth hung open. "You're working for the Horde? It can't be! You wanted to stop the Horde from conquering Etheria! You wanted to help the Princesses in their fight against them! And now you're…a Horde solider. Why?"

"The Spell of Obtainment opened my eyes to what was really happening around us. I saw that you and all the other Sorcerers were only holding me back from becoming who I was meant to become. I was held back from obtaining more power than what was possible. The Horde understood this, welcomed me into it and allowed me to draw out more power than ever before!"

"But you're still Light Spinner! You still have to have something good inside you! You still have to have some semblance of how evil the Horde is."

"The only thing inside me now is hatred. Hatred for Etheria, hatred for hope and hatred for everything that stands in my way and this includes you."

Micah froze in terror before he turned his back to try and open the door. But just as he pried the door open a crack, Micah felt a dark force wrap around his entire body before it threw him back. Micah turned and saw Shadow Weaver roping him closer with the dark shadows that seemingly outlined her body. Shadow Weaver continued pulling her former pupil closer until he was practically face to face with her.

"Please don't hurt me. You've shown me mercy before; I know you can still give me that at least."

Though it was impossible to tell from the mask, Micah felt as if Shadow Weaver was smiling at him.

"Oh dear Micah I don't intend to hurt you. You were one of my brightest and most gifted students. I couldn't possibly snuff that out like all the others, you deserve more. That's why I'm asking you for your assistance."

Micah stopped struggling in his dark restraints as he looked back at his former mentor. "My w-what?"

"Do you remember when I considered using First One's tech as a kind of weapon against our enemies?"

Micah nodded.

"I want you to use a piece of First One's tech, preferably the one I gave you, and use it to infect all of the Sorcerers within the vicinity. With their combined powers I could hack into the Heart of Etheria!"

Micah gasped. "But that means…"

"Yes, the whole planet will succumb to my dark power and everyone on it will be slaves under my control!"

Micah shook his head rapidly. "No! This isn't right! This is insane!"

Shadow Weaver tilted her head. "Oh dear Micah, since when did anyone ever accuse me of being sane?"

Micah struggled desperately to escape his restraints but they only seemed to grow tighter and tighter.

"It's no use trying to escape," Shadow Weaver said. "My magic far outweighs yours. You might as well just accept my offer before I'm tempted to snuff out your pathetic life."

"I…I don't know where any First One's tech is! I threw out that piece you gave me months ago!"

It only took a single glance at the bottom of Micah's bed to see a familiar green item.

"Lying was never one of your strongest suits."

Shadow Weaver threw Micah against the wall. Micah fell to the ground in a heap as he groaned loudly. But just as Shadow Weaver collected her prize, there was a slight knock at the door.

"Micah?" The voice of his young sister called out. "I had a nightmare. Can I sleep in your bed?"

Micah was just about to yell out for his sister to get as far away as possible but the shadows covered his mouth.

"Come in dear," Shadow Weaver called out as she mimicked her brother's voice.

The six year old Castapella opened the door and began to walk in before she immediately stopped.

"Micah who's that?" Castapella asked.

Micah somehow managed to open his mouth wide enough to yell out a muffled:

"RUN!"

But before she could process any of it, Shadow Weaver used her shadows to wrap around the young girl's body. Castapella screamed as Shadow Weaver pulled her closer and released Micah.

Micah screamed with rage as he tried to release his sister from her grasps.

"Light Spinner let her go! She has nothing to do with this!"

"If you want me to let her go than you'll do exactly what I say. Otherwise your sister won't live to see her next birthday, or any day for that matter."

Micah stopped as Shadow Weaver tossed him back the green data crystal.

"You have two hours to decide. If you choose to accept my offer, bring the crystal to me at Mount Stevenson in the kingdom of Dryl. Otherwise, I'll be sure to send back your sister's head."

And with a flick of her wrist, Shadow Weaver began to sink though the floor as the shadows guided her path.

"MICAH!" Castapella screamed.

Micah tried one last ditch effort to pull his sister free but he only felt his sister's hand slip out of his grasp as the shadows vanished through the floor. Micah let out an enraged scream as he punched the floor repeatedly before he finally got on his feet. As he glanced at the green crystal, a plan was already forming in his mind.

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Micah always fantasized travelling once he had achieved the rank of Master Sorcerer.

He could see himself braving the cold of the Northern Reach, swimming with the wildlife in the seas of Salineas and even climbing the mountains of Dryl.

And while he did get to fulfill that last item on his bucket list, he also wished it could've been under better circumstances.

At that moment, a storm was beginning to rage over the land. Dark black clouds covered the sky and the far off sounds of thunder could be heard.

"Did you bring it?"

The familiar cold voice echoed through the air. Micah turned and saw Shadow Weaver on the edge of the mountain, dangling his terrified sister over the edge.

"Yes," Micah replied holding the green data crystal up in question. "But first let my sister go!"

Micah tossed the crystal in Shadow Weaver's direction. The old woman caught the data crystal with ease as one of her shadows levitated Castpella towards her brother before she placed her on the ground.

"Now then Micah," Shadow Weaver began as she held the crystal up. "About my proposal…"

Shadow Weaver was suddenly interrupted by the crystal vanishing between her fingers. Shadow Weaver held up the green data crystal in his hands.

"Oh you wanted the real crystal? You should've been more specific."

Shadow Weaver gave out an enraged snarl as she flung her shadows towards the siblings.

Fortunately, Micah had placed a protective shield around his sister to protect her from Shadow Weaver's wrath. Micah meanwhile leapt out of Shadow Weaver's way as he formed a circle with his hands and allowed a beam of energy to shoot out from the center. But Shadow Weaver had been expecting this and broke the beam apart using her own shadows.

Micah then formed another circle with his hands and formed a large, blue horned sheep which charged at the old witch at rapid speed. But although Shadow Weaver managed to destroy the sheep with her electric shocks, she didn't count on a blue falcon picking her up into the air before it threw her on the ground.

After landing with a thump, Shadow Weaver glanced up and saw Micah operating two circles, one with his left and one with his right.

"Impressive Micah," Shadow Weaver said. "It seems as if I taught you well. But if you join me and rule by my side, I promise you will wield power far greater than you could ever imagine."

Micah narrowed his eyes. "You may have taught me magic Shadow Weaver but you never taught me right from wrong. You only taught me what you thought was right. You thought that using dark magic was the only way to combat the Horde, you thought that the Horde was the only one who could take you in and you thought that kidnapping my sister would make me join

your twisted quest. But now all I see is who you really are, a bitter and cold woman who wants nothing more than to destroy the people and things I care about. I'm nothing like you…and nothing you say or do is going to change that."

Shadow Weaver let out another enraged roar as she charged at Micah and resumed their deadly dance of spells and fighting. Sometimes, Micah would knock the witch back with his magical creatures and sometimes Shadow Weaver's shadows would rush past Micah's skin, causing painful burns in their wake. But sometime during the battle, the green data crystal fell out of Micah's pocket when one of the shadows knocked him back.

Shadow Weaver picked up the crystal as she stood over Micah's body, his clothes ripped to shreds and several burns marking his body.

"If you will not join me Micah I'll be sure to turn you into my first slave," Shadow Weaver said as she raised her data crystal over her head and caused her magic to run rampant throughout it. "Any last words?"

Now that he wasn't fighting, Micah noticed that the thunder was now almost deafeningly loud and his hair was standing on end.

"Yeah, duck."

Before Shadow Weaver could process what her former pupil's words meant, a bolt of lightning shot out of the sky and stuck the former sorceress in the chest. Shadow Weaver screamed as the data crystal fell from her hands.

Seizing the opportunity, Micah made one last circle with his hands, conjuring another falcon that grabbed the crystal within its talons before carrying it off the edge of the mountain. When he thought it was far enough, Micah allowed the bird to drop the crystal into a deep crevice below. Micah then caused the bird to cause against the side of the mountain, causing the rocks and dirt to tumble into the crevice below.

Shadow Weaver slowly stood up and glared at Micah.

"Good strategy Micah, but you forgot one thing, my darker power has given me greater endurance than any normal person. A simple lighting strike would kill most mortals, it only gave me a headache," Shadow Weaver grabbed Micah's shirt and hoisted it into the air. "And now that you've wasted enough I think I should just…"

Shadow Weaver tried to feel for the crystal but found only empty air. She patted herself over and over for her secret weapon but found it to be nowhere in sight. Shadow Weaver pulled Micah forward until he was face-to-face with her.

"WHERE IS THE CRYSTAL YOU WORTHLESS BASTARD?!"

Micah grinned. "I thought you were supposed to be smarter than me. You figure it out."

Shadow Weaver let out an enraged scream as she threw Micah against the force field surrounding his sister. The force field shattered as soon as he made contact and his sister was once again in the open.

Micah quickly got to his feet and took a battle stance as Shadow Weaver approached them. But when the old witch was only ten feet away she stopped dead in her tracks.

"No…it's too easy this way. But rest assured Micah, no matter where you go, no matter what you do with your pathetic life and no matter who gets involved with your affairs, I'll always be there, watching you in one way or another. And when you least suspect it, you can be sure that your life will end at my hands."

And with a flash of black shadows, Shadow Weaver disappeared.

Micah and Castapella sat there for a long time, even after the rain started to fall on them. Castapella began crying after the ordeal. Micah wrapped his arms around his baby sister and hugged her as if his life depended on it.

"It's okay Cas. It's okay."

Chapter End Notes

Ooh boy, what a ride!

Fun Fact: In my initial draft, before season 2 came out, I imagined Shadow Weaver's face got that way because of a lighting bolt striking her face while she was fighting Castapella at the edge of the mountain. But being dragged into a giant eye monster and being corrupted by dark magic works too. :p

I'm definitely loving this story so expect the next chapter soon! :)

Part 9

Chapter Notes

> Alright! Alright! Alright! Let's dive back in and go on a FEELS trip!
>
> Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Castapella let out a shaky breath as she finished her story. The memories she long thought of as suppressed were now as fresh in her mind as if it all happened yesterday.

Not a word was spoken between the two women for the longest time. Castapella didn't know if Angella was simply giving her a moment to recover from re-living her traumatic experience or if she simply had nothing to say.

But either way, she appreciated the silence.

After what seemed like an eternity, Angella slowly walked over and gently placed a hand on Castapella's shoulder.

"I thought that was the end of it," Castapella shuddered. "I thought I could just put this whole thing to bed and move on. And now…Shadow Weaver has the power to destroy all of Etheria."

"But neither Shadow Weaver nor Adora have been here to try and use the combined power of the sorcerers," Angella argued.

"She doesn't have to," Castapella replied. "Adora may not have realized this, but She-Ra wields more power than every Sorcerer on Mystacor, possibly even all of Etheria, combined. With Adora willing to use her power for Shadow Weaver…"

"She could easily use the Heart of Etheria against us…" Angella finished.

The vast gravity of the situation made the two women's eyes wonder out the window. Several young children could be seen practicing their magical skills or simply playing children's games like tag or kickball.

It was times like these that Angella wished she could be such a child again. To carry on her life without a care in the world, never knowing the dangers that lurked beyond the horizon, never acknowledging the possibility of tomorrow never coming and never realizing that their world they knew could vanish in the blink of an eye.

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Blackness.

That's all she knew.

That's all she could ever remember.

Adora couldn't remember how she got there, what she was doing there or even where she had been earlier.

She just felt the surrounding darkness coursing through her system, consuming her body with each passing minute.

Sometimes the voice behind her would whisper words of comfort; sometimes it would just make the sounds of breathing

But Adora still appreciated it. It was like her own mother was beside her again.

And yet something deep inside, something she couldn't pin down, longed for something else, or rather someone else.

The name escaped Adora's mind long ago (hours, days, years? She couldn't tell) but the image still burned in her subconscious.

A girl with a slender frame, discolored eyes and big fluffy ears.

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Castapella sat in the meeting room, in her brother's chair, with her hands folded.

She had just told the other princesses, along with SeaHawk (who was currently sitting in Adora's chair) and Swift Wind, everything she had previously told Angella.

The resulting silence was thicker than one of Frosta's icicles.

But interestingly, it was Mermista that finally broke the silence.

"The Heart of what now?"

Angella sighed.

"As far as records show, the First Ones not only settled on Etheria, they were responsible for making the planet as it is today. Everything from the climate, food supply and even the air quality they improved using their advanced pieces of technology. But they simply didn't use these crystals they infused the entire planet with their great power."

"You mean…" Bow began before Angella answered.

"Yes, Etheria in its entirety is comprised of First One's tech. But the First One's knew that such power would be entirely impossible to control by hand. And thus they devised a contraption that would monitor and stabilize the First One's technology throughout the entire planet."

"But how could Shadow Weaver hack into it?" Glimmer asked. "She's powerful but even she's not powerful enough to hack something that has more energy than every Runestone combined."

"That's initially why she tried to take over Mystacor," Castapella added. "With every sorcerer at her command, Shadow Weaver could've harnessed enough energy to take control of the Heart."

"Until She-Ra came back…" Glimmer spoke softly.

Angella nodded. "With her power…hacking into the Heart of Etheria is mere child's play."

"And then?" Perfuma asked, already regretting the answer she'd receive.

"The virus within Adora, or possibly even Adora herself, will be sucked into the device and will flow throughout the entire land. Climate will be thrown out of line, all plant and animal life will either die from exposure or become a twisted version of its self. The air itself will carry the virus and as people breathe it in…"

Castapella took a shaky breath as Angella placed a hand on her shoulder.

"They'll become similar to what Adora looks like now?" Glimmer regretfully answered.

Her aunt gave a slow nod as a deafening silence filled the room.

"Well what are we doing just moping around for?" Swift Wind asked from the side as his majestic wings spread out. "Let's find this hearty thing and stop Shadow Weaver!"

Angella shook her head again. "It's not that simple Swift Wind. We…don't exactly know where the Heart of Etheria is."

Swift Wind tilted his head to the side. "Okay now you're just confusing me."

"Knowing how powerful the Heart of Etheria was," Angella began.

"And how devastating it would be in the wrong hands," Castapella added.

"The First Ones hid the Heart away in a secret location. There have been many attempts to locate it over the years but they have all proven fruitless. And any records that may have indicated

where it has have mostly vanished along with the First One's themselves."

Another brief silence made its presence before Frosta spoke up.

"So…that means that Shadow Weaver won't be able to carry out her plan since she can't find the Heart?"

Castapella sighed. "Yes and no. She sounded so sure in the past that she not only knew about the Heart and where it was but I don't think she quite exactly knew where it was either. But then again…maybe she didn't have too."

Uhh…I'm afraid I don't understand," Bow replied.

"Magic is like putty, the more there is the bigger it gets. And the bigger it gets, the more the receptor of the magic is able to track down other sources of mystical energy."

Bow nodded as the pieces fell into place. "So every Sorcerer would've led Shadow Weaver to the Heart of Etheria because they could sense where it was?"

"Correct," Castapella replied. "Or in this case…She-Ra. No matter how hot or cold the climate or how tight or narrow the passages, She-Ra could just power through all of it and find the Heart easily."

"Either way," Netossa argued. "We gotta find out where that Heart is before Adora does!"

"I agree," Angella replied. "But with the original documents about its location lost to the sands of time…I'm not sure if it will be that easy to track it down."

The resulting silence, mixed with a hint of hopelessness, filled the air. Like her father before her, Glimmer refused to give up.

"There has to be something we can do! Maybe there's like a book or a manuscript or something that could show us where the Heart

is!"

An idea popped into Bow's head. "Not something, someone."

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Glimmer stepped down the stairs, along with one the castle guards, before walking down the narrow hallway of the dungeon.

Unlike the rest of the castle, which employed warm tones of white, pink and purple, the dungeon utilized its oppressive atmosphere with harsher tones. The walls were aligned with dull, grey bricks, the tiles of the floor were a faded brown, the various lanterns on the wall highlighted the black ceiling above and the cells themselves seemed to be colored a sickly shade of red.

Many of the prison cells were empty. Most of their enemies would either retreat from a losing battle or perish before they could even step foot in the dungeon.

But currently, two of its stalls were occupied.

As Glimmer passed by one particular cell, she glanced in and found a pair of mismatched eyes watching her from a darkened corner. The eyes in question narrowed on the princess's body with a deep seated anger burning beneath them. But as Glimmer turned her head, she thought she could hear the quiet sounds of muffled crying.

Shaking her head, Glimmer ventured forward and stopped in front of the cell she was seeking. Much like Catra, Entrapta sat in a corner of the cell. But unlike Catra, Entrapta had her back turned and her pigtails were wrapped around her like a security blanket.

"Princess Entrapta?" The guard asked in a commanding tone.

Entrapta didn't move a muscle.

"You have a visitor," The guard turned her head towards Glimmer. "If anything happens…"

Glimmer sighed. "It'll be fine. I can teleport remember?"

The guard didn't say anything in return. She merely nodded and walked off towards the stairs.

"Entrapta?" Glimmer called.

"Oh hi Glimmer," Entrapta replied in a quiet, somber tone.

"Entrapta are you okay?" Glimmer asked as she teleported into the cell.

"Really Glimmer?" Her brain scolded her. *"She just got charged with treason, thrown into a cell and could be killed in the next few weeks and you ask her if she's alright?"*

"I'm okay I guess," Entrapta replied in the same tone as before. "I've just been counting all the cracks on the walls. Unlike most Horde cells that have 1,070, BrightMoon seems to have better maintenance since they only have 356. But I guess…"

The rest of Entrapta's words flowed in and out of Glimmer's ears like the clouds at Mystacor's beaches.

The person in front of her looked like Entrapta, sounded like Entrapta and yet the tone of her voice sounded more like one of Entrapta's robots than the genius herself.

It was only when Glimmer noticed the awkward silence in the air did she speak up again.

"Entrapta, we've figured that Adora's planning on hacking into the Heart of Etheria and corrupting everything in its path. But we have no idea where it could be. You're the only person I know of that's studied enough of Etheria. You have to help us find it!"

"It's no use," Entrapta replied. "Everything I've done has just caused more harm than good to everyone. I'm better off just being alone…I've always been better off alone."

Glimmer gathered enough courage to place a hand on Entrapta's shoulder.

"Entrapta that's not true! You helped us fight the virus in Dryl and you helped Adora rescue me and Bow from the Fright Zone! You're a valuable member to the team!"

Entrapta finally turned around to look at Glimmer. It was then that Glimmer noticed the glassy look in Entrapta's eyes and the dried tear marks on her face.

"I've also disrupted the entire planet by hacking into the Black Garnett, probably injured several people with the upgrades I've made to the Horde bots and I welded that data crystal back together even after everything that happened last time. Being in this cell is probably where I belong."

"That's not true! With your help we could easily stop Shadow Weaver, save Adora and destroy that crystal for good. I'm sure once my mom sees how much good you've done for the Rebellion she'll gladly welcome you back!"

Entrapta sniffed. "At this point I think it's a useless cause. Everyone hates me now anyway. They'll probably all cheer once my head leaves my body."

"Perfuma won't," Glimmer stated quietly.

Entrapta looked back up at Glimmer with surprise. "Perfuma?"

Glimmer nodded. "When we thought you were dead, she built a statue of you completely out of vines and flowers."

A slight blush crossed Entrapta's face. "That's…exceptionally nice of her. I never thought she cared that much about me."

"I think she took your death," Glimmer said as she made air quotes on the last word. "The hardest. I even remember her telling me that every time she was on the battlefield…she was doing it in your memory, so that your death wouldn't be in vain."

"And now she knows I'm not only alive but working on the side she's fighting against. She'll just turn her back on me like everyone else. It's probably for the best anyway. She's organic matter and organic matter eventually dies and I…don't like death. Death takes…everything. Machines and tech though that lasts forever. It won't leave me like…mom…dad."

Glimmer's breath hitched. She had never asked the genius why she lived on her own or even where her biological parents where. She never liked to pry into other people's business, especially Bow's.

"Your parents?" Glimmer asked softly as she sat next to Entrapta.

Entrapta sniffed. "Much like the others, my parents fought in the rebellion, but they never considered themselves to be the warrior type. So they just usually stayed on the sidelines and tried to uncover new weapons or techniques that the other princess's could use. Based on what the older villagers of Dryl have told me, my parents were good friends with almost everyone in the Rebellion. They may not have been as sociable as the others but they still provided a great advantage to the Princess Alliance with their innovations."

Entrapta sniffed again as a gentle smile crossed her face.

"I was born about two years after the first Princess Alliance was established. It didn't take long for my parents to realize how gifted I was. By six months of age I was already speaking more words than other infants. By the age of one I was reading encyclopedias while other kids were reading fairy tales. And after I turned four I was already experimenting with various household items to see if I could make them better. My parents would usually be angry with me if one of my experiments ended up blowing up a wall or plastered paint all over the room but they always used to tell me that I was a very special kind of girl. And they also mentioned that I should never give up doing what makes me happy. And inventing…gave me more joy than any children's toy my parents could've given me"

A frown found its way onto Entrapta's face. The string of memories she wished were forgotten started to rear their ugly head.

"But once I started kindergarten, my parents also found out how different I really was. Not only was my intelligence far above the class average, but my social and communication skills were far lower than the average child's. Every time an adult would try to talk to me I would either look the other way or just desperately look for something else to tinker with. While other kids were playing tag, I would just stay inside and comprehend how to make a building block tower that could reach the ceiling. But I also never reacted the same way as the other kids; my emotions never matched the situation. When our teacher read us the story of the boy and his dog and how the dog ends up passing away from old age, every kid cried their eyes out. Me on the other hand…I was just confused as to how the boy couldn't just get another dog or try resurrecting his old dog."

Glimmer placed a hand on Entrapta's shoulder as the dam of her mind kept breaking away.

"I was later diagnosed with a moderate form of Asperger's Syndrome, a high functioning type of Autism. I never really saw it as a bad thing. I actually thought it was fascinating how my brain could be wired so differently from everyone else's. It was only really difficult when I was expected to interact with the other children. I could never maintain eye contact for long nor could I ever tell if their comments were of a serious or joking nature. As time went on, more and more kids just saw me as the classroom weirdo and avoided spending any time with me. But at the same time I realized that I enjoyed the company of machines far more than other people."

Entrapta's expression brightened.

"After all, machines don't look down on you, think mean thoughts about you or even talk behind your back about you…they're just there, willing to listen to whatever you say. I was so obsessed

with robots in particular that I was able to create a fully functional android by the age of six. My parents were of course proud of me but they always told me how important human interaction was and to never doubt its significance. I knew they meant well but I couldn't help but just be more fascinated by how a planet like Etheria could exist, who exactly the First One's were and just how advanced I could build my robots."

The excitement in Entrapta's voice died down.

"My father used to educate me on what Etheria was and all the different lands there were in the kingdom while my mother used to read my bedtime stories about the First One's, their history, their culture and all the amazing tech they utilized. I always thought to myself that someday I would be able to use that tech to do great things for Etheria, uncover more of the First One's history and exactly discover the secrets of the world in general. I was so thankful of my parents guiding me on this path that I decided to show my appreciation for them by building a robotic version of them. I thought that it could keep an eye on me while they were off on their Princess business. I worked day and night to try and build them to perfection and on the day I expected them to come back, I eagerly waited for them to walk through the door and show them my best work."

Entrapta sniffed as her eyes became misty.

"Hey it's okay Entrapta," Glimmer said softly. "You don't have to talk about it if you…"

"One of the castle servants walked in with a look I'd never seen before. He knelt down to my height and told me my parents had been killed during a recent battle with the Horde. I didn't believe him of course, he could've just been mistaken. I thought my parents could've just been in a coma that they had yet to wake up from or maybe they were just captured by the Horde and presumed dead. But…when the two wooden coffins rolled into the kingdom square and I saw my parents lying there motionless…I realized the truth. It made me feel something I never wanted to

feel again. On that day, I realized why I never wanted to get close to people…they die, they eventually cease to exist and will never be seen in the same light again."

The tears were flowing down Entrapta's face like a waterfall.

"Every time I tried to talk to someone, or if someone was actually nice enough to come and sit by me at lunch, I could only think about how this person was going to die someday, that I would be all alone and I would get that awful feeling again. But machines… they never die or at least never leave you. If one of my inventions exploded or died naturally I would just place them in the corner so I knew that they would still be with me. My robotic parents in particular…I think the staff found me sleeping next to those more times than I could remember."

Glimmer found her own eyes becoming misty. "I know what it's like to lose someone to the Horde. But I…"

"When you and the others came by and offered me a chance to be a part of the Princess Alliance, I was ecstatic. I felt like I could continue my parents work and make friends with the other Princesses since I got along so well with you, Bow and the tall slash semi tall one."

"Adora," Glimmer corrected.

"But once I was at the Princess Prom, those same feelings came back. Every time I tried to talk to somebody they would just walk away or stare at me in confusion. And then anytime someone came up to me…my brain would just freeze up and my analytical side would just convince me that it wasn't worth getting close to them. I still felt privileged to be a part of the Princess Alliance but I felt like I never connected with any of the other Princesses. And when I thought you guys left me…it was like that old wound got torn open all over again.

Entrapta wiped her eyes with one of her hair hands.

"But once Catra offered me a spot in the Horde…I honestly jumped at the chance because it gave me a chance to peruse my interest in science. But over time I found myself growing closer to Catra and Scorpia. Unlike the other princesses they actually seemed interested in my theories or what I was working on. It felt like…I belonged somewhere. And when your mom offered me the chance to come back to the Alliance…I just didn't want to venture into something that I knew I didn't belong in. With the Horde…at least I knew that some people would still like me."

Glimmer sighed. "Entrapta…I know the Horde has better tech and maybe more like minded people but I gotta know…did your parents love you?"

Entrapta raised an eyebrow as if she was asked what two plus two was. "They always considered me to be the theoretical apple of their eye. No matter how difficult I was, they always claimed that they wouldn't change a thing."

"But did the servants ever say who took their lives?" Glimmer asked to which Entrapta nodded before her eyes grew wide.

"The…Horde soldiers are what they said."

Glimmer placed her hand back on Entrapta's shoulder. "Entrapta… when my dad was killed by the Horde…it practically destroyed me. I couldn't count the number of times I woke up crying his name or when my mom found me sleeping by the painted mural of him. But you know what I did later? I made a solemn promise that I would do everything in my power to make sure that my father didn't die in vain. I did it because I knew that's what he'd want from me."

Glimmer paused. "Entrapta…science as a place in the world and the fact that you care about it so much is one of the many things that makes you unique. But the Horde wants to destroy everything and everyone in its path. What's the point of pursuing science if there's no one left to share it with? Your parents would

want you to use your gifts to help people, to help Etheria. Wouldn't your parents want you to do the right thing?"

Whatever mask Entrapta had been wearing was shattered as she threw both her regular and hair arms around Glimmer as she wailed loudly into her shoulder.

Much like how her mother comforted before, Glimmer rubbed small circles on Entrapta's back as she spoke softly into her ear.

"Shh…it's okay. It's gonna be okay."

"I'm sorry…I'm so sorry," Entrapta found herself repeating over and over again.

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Catra jumped down from the corner of the cell, where the little crack in the foundation had allowed her to eavesdrop on the two princess's conversation.

To say she felt sick to her stomach was a grave understatement.

Catra had never known of Entrapta's past, probably because of the same reason she never knew much about Scorpia's past, she didn't care to know. After all, she never wanted to disclose her past, or rather her past abuse at the hands of Shadow Weaver, to other people, why should she try sticking her nose into other people's business.

But after learning about the genius's upbringing, a strange feeling (guilt perhaps?) made its presence in her stomach.

Entrapta never really did fit the mold of the princess archetype she was spoon-fed in the Horde. She didn't have glamorous clothes, have a giant kingdom or carried herself like she was better than anyone else.

She was simply a confused, scared little girl trapped in an older woman's body who was simply trying to cope with what life had

thrown her.

"Just like me," Catra thought to herself as she slumped back in the corner, her tail automatically wrapping around her frame.

"And how did you pay her back? Manipulating her? Yelling at her for making mistakes? Making her hurt the one you love? You're no better than Shadow Weaver. You're pretty much her equal."

Normally, Catra would try and shove that last thought to the dark recess of her mind but this time she allowed it to fester.

"You always have reminded me of myself," Catra remembered Shadow Weaver saying during one of her weekly visits to her prison cell. *"You always have."*

"S-s-shut up," Catra muttered to herself.

"Aw but you are just like me. You always will be," Shadow Weaver's words echoed in her mind.

Catra let out an enraged scream as she scratched the walls of her cell. Every ounce of pain, fear and heartbreak she had felt all day, and every other day since Adora had left, left her body in the form of hot tears.

"SHUT UP! SHUT UP! SHUT UP! Shut up! Shut up. Shut…"

With one last weak swipe, Catra felt the rest of her inner fire die off as she collapsed on the cold, hard floor.

She didn't care if anyone heard her. She didn't care if all of Etheria heard her. She just wanted something…anything, to break the vice off her heart.

Catra lay on the floor, breathing slowly in and out for what felt like the longest time. But she felt her hurricane of a mind finally merge into a calm pond, her thoughts began to change.

"I may share some of your qualities Shadow Weaver. I may have made the same mistakes as you. But at least I recognize my mistakes. You may have raised me, strike that, abused me to be the emotionless Horde soldier you wanted…but there's something you forgot…what was right and what was wrong. You never saw yourself as doing wrong…you only saw yourself doing what was right. And you…thought that manipulating and hurting Adora was the right thing to do."

Catra clenched her fist so tight she felt a warm liquid oozing out.

"And nobody…hurts the one I love."

Chapter End Notes

Hell hath no fury like a woman scorn, especially a lesbian Magicat.

That scene between Glimmer and Entrapta has been rolling around in my head ever since I started this story so I'm so happy to finally have it down on the page! :)

Thanks for all the favs and follows! It definitely gives me the motivation I need to keep going!

Next chapter may or may not be a while since I'm hoping to enjoy the long weekend, celebrating my country's birthday and all. But rest assured it will come soon.

Until then: Peace!

Part 10

Chapter Notes

> We are now less than a month away till Season 3! Can you say all aboard the hype train?!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Entrapta hung her head low as she, Glimmer and one of the castle guards opened the doors to the meeting room and walked in.

Entrapta's ears picked up several gasps as she made her way to the edge of the table.

"Your majesty," The guard announced. "Princess Entrapta has requested to see you."

The queen's face remained stoic as she lifted an eyebrow. "And you brought her up here without my permission to do so?"

Glimmer stepped forward. "Mom-your majesty, I've talked to Entrapta and she's seen the error of her ways. She's vouched to help us find the Heart of Etheria."

"How do we know she's telling the truth?" Frosta asked.

"She could just lead us into a trap where Shadow Weaver and Adora could get to us!" Netossa argued.

"Or she could just like stab us in the back and run off to be with her Horde family," Mermista scowled.

"She's betrayed us once before," Spinerella added. "How can we sure that it won't happen again?"

"ENOUGH!"

Perfuma's sudden outburst caused everyone to nearly fall out of their seats. Glimmer practically jumped back when she saw the

flower princess's angered expression. It actually scared her a little.

"BrightMoon is supposed to be a kingdom of free speech and goodwill towards everyone. Even Horde prisoners are treated with compassion and an ounce of respect. Shouldn't we allow Entrapta a moment to explain herself instead of just jumping to conclusions? Or have second chances gone the way of the First One's too?"

Angella waited until Perfuma was finished before she gave a heavy sigh. "Entrapta…would you care to tell us why you wished to meet with us?"

Entrapta let out a heavy sigh. "I've done…many terrible things within the Horde's walls. For so long I thought that the pursuit of science was worth any sacrifices that came from it. But after talking things over with Glimmer…I've realized just how insane their true intentions were. Looking back I've realized that you guys wouldn't have let me behind if you knew I was truly alive. I should've found some way to either escape or let you guys know that I was alive all along." Entrapta sniffed. "But as Glimmer pointed out…I can't do anything to change the past…no matter how much I want to…but I can focus my efforts on the issues of the present, namely trying to locate the Heart of Etheria. I don't expect you to forgive me, trust me or even allow me to rejoin the Princess Alliance once this whole affair is over with. But…please allow me just this once chance to fix the mess I helped to create."

Entrapta hadn't noticed she was crying until she saw a tear splash onto the floor below.

"Mom," Glimmer argued. "Entrapta's the only one who can locate the Heart of Etheria faster than anyone. Without her we'd just be on a wild goose chase trying to find it. And if by some miracle we do find it, it'll be too late and Adora will be lost forever."

"But she was like working willingly with the Horde…" Mermista started to say before Glimmer cut her off.

"So was Adora! She was being brainwashed by the Horde's teachings until she saw what they were really like. She saw the error of her ways just like Entrapta right now! We could've locked up Adora even after she proved herself worthy to the cause! But we didn't! We saw past her image to see the person she truly was!"

"Your majesty," Entrapta finally looked up to meet the queen's gaze. "My parents died in the battle against the Horde. They fought with the other princesses to help build a better world for their children. Please allow me a chance to make sure their deaths were not in vain."

Angella breathed in and out as her eyes showed mercy. "Commander Glimmer, you will keep Entrapta under constant supervision?"

For the first time, in what felt like an eternity, Glimmer smiled. "Yes, I and everyone else will ensure that Entrapta stays safe."

"Or loyal," Mermista added which earned her a glare from Perfuma.

"Princess Entrapta, you claim to know the location of the Heart of Etheria?" Angella asked.

"I…have an educated guess on where the Heart is most likely located," Entrapta replied.

Angella sighed. "Please demonstrate using the map on the table." With a wave of her hand, Angella caused the meeting room table to turn from a wooden structure into a holographic landscape representation of Etheria.

"Fascinating," Entrapta breathed. "You can observe every known part of Etheria. Imagine what kind of progress we could make if I made just a few minor adjustments…"

"Entrapta focus," Angella said.

Entrapta cleared her throat before she moved her hand across the table. "First One's data crystals have been found all over Etheria. But from my calculations, the majority of them seem to be found in Dryl or at least in close proximity to the kingdom. The mine in particular has uncovered the majority of my data crystal collection. I thought nothing of it at the time but my castle servants began hearing strange rumors that the mine was haunted by spectral anomalies."

"You mean ghosts?" Castapella asked.

"Well to put it one way yes!" Entrapta replied. "Anyway, workers in the mines used to say they heard strange voices coming from deep within the soil. Others claimed they saw a strange ray of light peeking through the cracks of certain tunnels that ran deeper into the ground than others. I can't say I believe in ghosts, considering I haven't gathered enough scientific proof to prove their existence, but it does seem highly improbable that so many reports of spectral anomalies would come out of one location instead of various locations across Etheria."

"But what does this have to do with the Heart of Etheria?" Glimmer asked, sounding impatient.

"Based on ancient texts of the First One's," Castapella began. "The Heart of Etheria was rumored to have an almost blinding light to it and would make strange noises at certain times, usually whenever there was a disturbance to the land."

"Like whenever the Horde was poisoning the forest with its machinery," Perfuma said.

"Or when the Black Garnett was hacked," Entrapta added.

"So this means that the magical heart thingy is deep within the mines of Dryl?" Perfuma asked.

Entrapta paused for a second, mentally adding up all the pieces. "It seems like the most likely."

"Then that's where we have to go!" SeaHawk added before he jumped up on the table causing the holograms to vanish. "Onward to adventure!"

"Wow calm down," Mermista said. "Do you know how big Dryl is. It would take us like a really long time to locate this thing."

"Mermista's right," Frosta added as SeaHawk sat back down in his chair. "We need something that could easily track down the Heart to its exact location."

Bow's eyes lit up. "Wait a minute! Entrapta, I still have your heat seeking device that allowed us to find Catra in the Fright Zone. Can you reconfigure it so that it can pick up the Heart?"

The burning flame of curiosity within Entrapta began to flare up as her eyes lit up. "Consider it done yesterday! That is…if I can request a lab to work in your majesty."

"Bow take Entrapta to the basement and report back to me as soon as she's finished," Angella said.

Bow nodded before he and Entrapta walked out of the meeting room.

"But even if we find the Heart that still doesn't help us figure out how to cure Adora of this disease!" Glimmer stated.

Castapella placed a hand under her chin. "Shadow Weaver's magic is much more powerful and darker than mine. Her magic would probably outdo whatever spells I or any other Master Sorcerer could create."

Everyone's face fell as silence penetrated the room.

"But there is one way to help Adora…but it's risky."

Glimmer nearly jumped out of her seat. "There is?! Tell us we have to do it. We have to do something…"

"Glimmer deep breaths," Angella replied.

Glimmer did as she was told as Castapella continued.

"With this particular spell, it seems that the Adora you and I know is not truly gone. She's trapped somewhere in the subconscious of this corrupted being. In order to bring her back…someone must perform the act of Soul Immersion."

"Soul Immersion?" Netossa asked.

"With a bit of magical powder and a certain chant, a person's subconscious can enter the infected being's subconscious in order to find that very person. Once they find them they will have to guide them back to reality."

"So any one of us can go in and find Adora?" Bow asked.

Castapella shook her head. "In order for this spell to be of maximum efficiency, it has to be someone that's known the person for the longest time. I know that you and Glimmer and everyone else here have grown close to Adora over the past few months, but there's no guarantee that it'll be enough to bring Adora back to her senses and take control of her body once again. We need someone who's grown up with Adora, possibly someone who knows her better than anyone else."

Bow glanced at Glimmer who in turn glanced back. "Are you thinking what I'm thinking?"

Glimmer groaned. "Unfortunately I am."

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Despite all the strangeness that had happened to her today, Catra still thought that being removed from her prison cell, and coming face to face with the same woman she tried to shoot at with a canon, was utterly surreal.

As she glanced around the table, Catra saw several of the princesses, and the same pirate whose name she'd already forgotten, looking at her with a hint of malice. This hadn't surprised the young Magicat though as she had expected this kind of reception no matter how she ended up in BrightMoon. But beneath their malicious glares, Catra almost thought she saw a look of relief in their eyes, as if she were there last hope at the end of their ropes.

"Prisoner," Glimmer began.

"I have a name you know. Or do prisoners get that stripped away too?" Catra sneered.

Glimmer took a quick deep breath, trying so hard to not get into an argument right now.

"We may have found a way to bring Adora back but we need your help."

Glimmer had expected Catra to roll her eyes, make a nasty comeback or simply refuse outright. But instead the ex Horde soldier's eyes lit up and a ghost of a smile crossed her face.

"I'll do it." Catra replied. "Just tell me what to do."

To say she rendered everyone speechless would be a grave understatement. But after a full minute of silence, Castapella began explaining the process of Soul Immersion to Catra. Catra's face remained stoic throughout most of it, only raising an eyebrow or twitching one of her ears in response. But once Castapella finished, Catra simply rolled her eyes, much like she used to do back in the Horde's cadet classes.

"So? A little hocus pocus and Adora's free." Catra said.

"It's not that simple Catra," Castapella replied. "This spell will only work if you and Adora are face to face with one another."

Catra shrugged. "So? We have like half a dozen princesses and a brunch of princess magic mumbo jumbo bullshit. Just place a spell or subdue her long enough so I can do it. Why are we wasting time explaining everything when we can just get it done today?"

"Catra," Castapella sighed. "You have to understand the potential consequences of such a practice. It's so experimental that the Sorcerers guild doesn't even have it listed in their official spell books. Unless it's performed correctly and/or you are successful… you could potentially lose your life."

For a fraction of a second, fear clouded Catra's heterochromatic eyes but was swiftly replaced with determination and bravery, per her Horde teachings.

"So? All of you waste dying every time you're out there fighting the Horde? What makes you think I can't handle this? What's the worst that can happen?"

Castapella placed her head in her hands for a solid minute before she glanced up at Catra with the gravest of expressions.

"If the person is unable to make the other come back to reality… their subconscious would be forever trapped in the others mind forever. Their body meanwhile remains in a vegetative state and would almost be mistaken for being dead if not for the continued warmth that radiates throughout it. If a person reaches this state…they can't come back. No spell, or mumbo jumbo bullshit as you put it, can even come close to reversing the effects. You could potentially…in a sense…die…Catra."

Catra raised her cuffed hands and slammed them on the table, causing several to jump in their seats.

"I don't care about the damn risks! This is my fault that all this is happening so I may as well be the one to do it! If it works, great, you get your precious princess of power back! If it doesn't you rid the world of one less Horde soldier and you can take pleasure in knowing that I got my just desserts! But I am not going to just rot

in a cell and think about what I could've done to stop this! You wanted someone who knows Adora inside and out! Well you got her! Now let's stop running our mouths and go find Adora!"

Catra allowed herself to catch her breath as the other princess and SeaHawk stared up at her with wide eyes. Angella herself looked taken aback by the young girl's outburst. Her eyes widened for the briefest of seconds before she returned to her neutral state.

"Very well," Angella said. "We will let Entrapta alter Bow's device to locate the Heart and then rest up for the night. We'll head out at dawn."

Catra's snapped her head towards Angella with a look of utter disbelief on her face.

"You're joking…we actually have a chance to locate this heart thingy, save all of Etheria and Adora and you want to take a fucking nap?! Do you realize the longer we sit here the better a chance Shadow Weaver has in destroying all of us? All of Etheria? No of course you wouldn't know that, you princesses just care about what happens in your own little world. You never give a damn about what happens in the world or to regular people. You just act all high and mighty while I just get told how worthless I am from a young age and am always living in the shadow of someone I thought I could count on and…"

A gentle touch on her shoulder made Catra pause her rant. Normally she'd claw whoever decided to lay a hand on her, but she was so mentally exhausted that the thought never entered her mind. Glancing up, Catra saw Angella with a stern expression, yet with a hint of sympathy in her eyes. Catra had been so wrapped up in her rant that she hadn't noticed the monarch had walked over to her.

"Catra…I may not know all the details of what's happened to you today but I know the telltale signs of burnout when I see them. You're not thinking clearly and need rest."

Catra slapped Angella's hand with fury in her eyes. "Don't tell me what I need! I can take care of myself just fine and don't feel the least bit tired…" A loud yawn suddenly erupted from Catra's mouth as she began to fall forward. Angella thankfully caught her before the floor provided her with a rude awakening. Catra blinked rapidly before she looked up at Angella with a dazed look in her eyes.

"I am not questioning your abilities Catra," Angella said. "I'm noticing how fatigued you are right now. What good is it to face Adora and the rest of the Horde in your current state? We'd have a much better chance if you rested…we all would." Angella glanced at the others who nodded in agreement.

Angella brought Catra back onto her feet.

"I…can't…stop," Catra wearily muttered. "Adora…needs…me."

"She does but I'm sure she'd also want you in one piece, which your chances of doing so would dramatically decrease if you went into battle in your current state. Please rest, for Adora, for everyone's sake."

Catra sighed as she dropped her shoulders. "First thing…in… morning."

"Of course," Angella faintly smiled before she motioned for two palace guards to carry Catra back to her holding cell. With one to her the left and one to her right, the guards hooked their arms under Catra's and began to carry her away.

"I want everyone to rest up and prepare for tomorrow. Regardless of whether Entrapta is right or not about the Heart of Etheria's location…we're gonna need all the strength and willpower in all of Etheria to save Adora. Let's do this for Adora!"

"FOR ADORA!" Everyone cheered in unison before they existed out of the meeting room.

As per usual, Angella was the last to leave the room. She also instructed the guards to warn her of any developments immediately.

As the guards closed the doors, an eerie silence filled the once lively room. At first glance, everything seemed normal, until a part of the meeting room table's shadow broke off revealing a black, shadowy creature with a single red eye. The creature looked around briefly before it slinked under the doors and flew out of the closest adjacent window.

The creature flew to the ground before it began to slither further away from the castle like a snake looking for its next prey. But eventually it did find its intended target, a tall blue skinned woman with black hair and an emotionless mask.

"What did you find out my little one?"

The shadow swirled around Shadow Weaver's hands for a moment before it flowed into her hair.

"Aw I see now."

"See what mother?" Adora called from behind her.

"The princesses are still trying to steal you away from me," Shadow Weaver replied.

Adora growled. "They still don't get that I don't need saving! We should strike now and see they never bother us again!"

"There's no need for violence quite yet Adora," Shadow Weaver replied. "Thanks to your former friends they may have just located the Heart of Etheria for us."

Adora's smiled widely as her red pupils expanded. "So we can follow them straight to the Heart and pick them off as soon as we reach them."

Shadow Weaver chuckled darkly. "Oh I have a much better idea dear daughter, one that will ensure that those princesses will never bother us again."

A twisted chorus of laughter grew louder and louder in the forest as the afternoon moons began to set.

Chapter End Notes

So yeah not too much going on I know but next few chapters will definitely amp up the game!

Looking forward to getting to those soon!

Until then: Peace!

Part 11

Chapter Notes

Let's get this party started again!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra would never admit that the beds at the Fright Zone were comfortable. Her body simply adjusted to the firmness over the years. It was her mind, utterly exhausted from training exercises and various antics with Adora, which allowed her the sweet eight hours away from reality.

Needless to say, her body was having a hard time adjusting to sleeping on a, surprisingly, comfy bed in her cell.

"Damn it," Catra sneered as she flipped over for what felt like the fiftieth time. *"Even their prisoner beds have to be soft and friendly."*

After what felt like hours of tossing and turning, Catra finally sat up on her bed and felt a sudden thirst come over her. She walked over to the cell bars and glanced down the hallway. She soon eyed a BrightMoon guard standing by the dungeon door. Although their uniform could be seen, their face and even their helmet were hidden by shadows.

"Hey guard," Catra called. "I know I'm public enemy number one but can I get some water in here?"

No reply.

Catra frowned. "What are you deaf? I said I want some WATER!"

No reply.

Catra snarled and gripped the bars. "I WANT WATER AND I…"

Catra pulled away quickly when the bars in her hands separated from the wall and fell onto the ground. The loud clattering actually made the young feline humanoid jump back in surprise.

After she regained her bearings, Catra slowly made her way out of the cell. The guard still hadn't reacted to any of the commotion which caused Catra to furrow her brows in confusion.

"Uh sorry about the gate there but I think I'll just get myself some water and then…escape or something."

The guard still didn't reply. Catra stood right in front of the guard and pocked the helmet with one of her claws.

"Anybody home in there?"

The guard's head rolled off its shoulders and crashed to the floor with a loud bang. Catra screamed and immediately flattened herself against the wall before she dared to look down.

A human skull lay within the helmet, as pieces of it were scattered across the floor. The eyeless face of the severed head stared up at Catra, its teeth made up into a huge grin.

Catra threw open the dungeon door and ran up the stairs faster than if she were chasing a mouse.

When she reached the top of the stairs, Catra allowed herself to catch her breath. But when she glanced up, Catra saw that the hallways of the castle were in ruins.

The bright pinks and whites from before were now muted blacks and browns. Stone pillars littered the hall, murals lay broken and scattered across and even portions of the wall were chipping away. Black vines crept through the ceiling and through the floor, as if nature were trying to reclaim the building as one of its own.

Catra wrapped her arms around as he slowly continued down the deathly silent hallway. But when she passed by a certain door, Catra thought she heard a quiet mumbling coming from behind.

Slowly, Catra grabbed the door handle and opened the door. The room was huge, round in shape, like some sort of meeting room. But by now the chairs had been thrown across the room, painted murals were broken off the walls and their pieces lay scattered on the floor. Portions of the roof had given away, revealing nothing but empty blackness beyond.

But it wasn't these details that had caught Catra's mismatched eyes; it was the figure hanging in the center of the table by their neck. Their feet were just barely touching the end of the table.

Despite everything in Catra's body screaming at her to run away and never look back, her natural feline curiosity made her step forward to see who the figure was. As Catra came closer and closer, the mumbling she heard earlier was becoming less and less garbled than before, but even her keen hearing couldn't make out what they were saying.

Suddenly, the figure turned its head to face Catra who in turn had to bite her tongue to keep from screaming.

Angella gazed at Catra with a look she had never seen before. The eyes appeared wide-eyed and crazed, as if reality were a mere fairy tale to her, while her face was frozen in a permanent smile.

"I will die, I will die, I will die…"

Angella kept repeating these words again and again as she spun around in the noose around her neck.

Catra slowly stepped backwards, wanting nothing more than to get away from the sight before her, but also afraid to turn her back on the woman as well.

When she had passed through the open door, Catra finally had the will to turn around and run down the hall as fast as she could without stepping on any of the debris.

Seeing a large opening ahead, Catra ran and ran until she thought her lungs would explode.

But when she passed through the opening, and subsequently found herself outside, Catra couldn't hold back the gasp that escaped her body. The sky was a deep shade of red, as if it were bleeding. Petrified remains of several animals (horses, birds and even cats and dogs) littered the grounds, with each of their faces frozen in sheer terror.

The once tall and lush trees were now barren as their skeleton like branches breached out into the sky. The grass itself was a sickly reddish brown color and littered with dead leaves and debris. More black vines covered the castle's steps and everything else in its way.

But despite everything, the thing that unnerved Catra the most was the utter silence. The sound of birds chirping, children playing or even the whispering of the nearby woods had all but ceased.

"Hey Catra."

Catra nearly jumped out of her skin. She swung around and dropped onto all fours to see Adora leaning against the castle entrance, smirking as if they were back in the locker rooms at the Fright Zone.

But thankfully it wasn't the demonic version of her former friend, it was the version that Catra had grown to love. Golden blonde hair, fair skin, sky blue eyes and clad in her normal Horde attire of a red jacket, brown pants and red boots.

"Adora?"

Adora laughed. "You should've seen your face. It was just like: 'Ahh who's there?'"

Catra slowly got to her feet before she took a few steps forward. "Is it really you…Adora?"

Adora scoffed. "Who else would I be dummy? Shadow Weaver?"

Catra's fur bristled at the mere mention of her lifelong tormentor's name.

"What the hell happened here?" Catra asked.

"Why don't you know Catra?" Adora laughed. "You caused this."

Catra felt her stomach turn. "I…I don't know what you're talking about."

Adora walked closer to Catra. "You infected me with crystal and I managed to hack into the Heart of Etheria. And now everything is how it should be and it's all thanks to you."

Catra's eyes widened. "How can you be okay with this? Everything's dead! The whole kingdom's a wasteland!"

Adora shrugged. "Hey, it doesn't what happens to us, remember? The two of us look out for each other and now we're calling the shots. Isn't that what you always wanted Catra?"

A strange sense of déjà vu came over Catra as she flashed back to the battle of Thaymor, a moment that seemed like a century ago.

"No…maybe…AUGH! I don't know what I want Adora! I've never known what I've wanted. I was raised to be a soldier in some war that I have no idea what the end goal is and raised by a woman that would beat me at the drop of a hat! I just played follow the leader like everyone else in the Horde! But…I know that…I wanted to be with you. No matter what happened to us…we'd look out for each other and then…maybe…"

"That was then, this is now," Adora replied coldly.

Catra let out a humorless chuckle. "Ya know, at one time, hearing you say that would've made my day."

"And now," Adora replied, ignoring Catra's words. "Since you made all this happen, I feel it's only right for me to thank you…in my own way."

A wicked smile crossed Adora's face as she slowly walked towards Catra slowly. Catra's eyes widened as she stepped back.

"Adora…this isn't you. Shadow Weaver's making you think like this, just like how she manipulated us as kids! I know you! You're too…naïve…determined…wholesome and caring to want this for the planet. You don't want this! I don't want this!"

Adora simply continued walking. "Oh but you did. You're nothing but a vile wicked animal, you always have been. All the hate that Shadow Weaver fed upon you has manifested in your soul and influenced your actions in the present. She would be so proud of everything you've done for her. Isn't that right mother?"

Catra felt the electricity surge through her system before she could utter a syllable.

"Yes my child," Shadow Weaver's said from behind Catra. "I and everyone else can't tell you how much we appreciate your efforts."

"Everyone else?" Catra whispered.

Suddenly, the other princesses, along with SeaHawk and Bow, appeared next to Adora via a smoky teleportation. They were the spitting image of Adora's transformed image. They all bore black, flowing hair, pale blue skin, sharp fangs, purple versions of their costumes and soulless black eyes with red pupils.

"It's beautiful Catra," Glimmer spoke in a distorted tone.

"You have no idea how good it feels," Bow said.

"You don't feel pain," Perfuma said.

"You don't feel remorse," Mermista said.

"There's only…one mind," Frosta said.

"And it's all from mother Shadow Weaver's love," Spinerella and Netossa spoke in unison.

Catra tried to shake her head. "No, no. Shadow Weaver doesn't do love! All she knows is hate and malice. She wouldn't know love if it bit her in the ass."

A particularly painful shot of electricity rang through Catra's body as she fell to the ground.

"We don't say bad things about mother, Catra," Entrapta said.

"Mother is love, mother is life," Scorpia said.

Catra slowly lifted herself onto her elbows. "Scorpia, Entrapta… this isn't right! You're not like this! You've never been!"

"You've always been a poor judge of character Catra," Entrapta replied. "Just like how you thought Adora was your best friend but she only served to prove how worthless you are."

"How so much better she is without you," Scorpia added. "She only pretended to like you because of how sorry she felt for you."

"SHUT UP!" Catra screamed.

"Ahh denial, the first step," Entrapta replied as she let Shadow Weaver pass her by.

"I've always envisioned the day when I'd wipe your primitive self off the face of the planet. And now all my patience is about to pay off. Adora?"

Adora's morphed herself into her new transformed state.

"Make mommy proud…dispose of this creature for good."

Adora smiled wickedly before she opened her mouth, far wider than humanely possible, as a stream of red tentacles shot out of her orifice and wrapped around Catra's entire body. Catra let out a

loud muffled scream as she felt herself being dragged closer and closer towards the gaping, red open cavity in Adora's chest. Try as she might to escape her restraints by using her claws, they seemed to endlessly grow back no sooner than when she cut them.

"Goodbye Catra," Adora spoke, her voice growing more distorted and deeper with each word. "I really am going to miss you."

Catra felt the last of her body slip under Adora's skin. The last sounds she heard were the chorus of twisted laughter and Shadow Weaver uttering one last final statement.

"This is inevitable."

XXXXXXX

"AHHH!"

Catra screamed as she woke. She felt her fur caked with sweat, every muscle in her body was trembling in fear and she already felt tears streaming down her face.

For a solid ten minutes, Catra wrapped her arms and tail around her body as she tried to think rationally.

"Don't believe anything she tells you. That…world is not inevitable! I can do something about this. I'm going out to the Dryl mind and I'm gonna cure Adora of this even if it kills me. Even if I'm trapped in Adora's mind forever…at least I'll be in the one place I've always felt like I belonged."

Catra was so focused on her inner monologue that she failed to notice the figures approaching her cell.

"Catra."

Catra let out a loud shriek as she instinctively jumped on all fours and hissed.

Queen Angella, along with Castapella stood by her cell. While Angella's face was cast in a stoic gaze, Castapella's was cast in a blanket of worry.

"You scared the shit out of me! Can't you knock or something?"

"My apologies," Angella replied. "The morning moons have begun to rise. I thought you wanted to be the first to know."

Catra got back on her feet as she leaned against the wall.

"Huh, someone actually listened to me. Would've thought?"

Angella raised an eyebrow but said nothing in response.

A brief silence filled the room before Catra threw her arms in the air.

"If you're done having a staring contest with me I'd like to go prevent Etheria from turning into a wasteland."

Angella nodded. "I understand. I just wished to inform you that your presence is required in the meeting room to form a plan for how you wish to save the world."

Catra wanted to snap back that they were wasting time but there was too much truth in the queen's words to do so.

"But before we commence on that, Castapella wants to go over the Soul Immersion process with you."

Catra's scowl lightened. *"Right gotta remember what to do to get to Adora. Pay attention now."*

Castapella reached into her side pocket and pulled out a small straw bag tied with a golden ribbon.

"This is Macedon Zicary or magical powder put simply," Castapella poured a small amount of the blue powder on her hands. "You

must use this powder and repeat this chant: klaatu barada nikto, in order to begin the Soul Immersion process."

"Pfft," Catra scoffed. "Piece of cake."

Castapella's eye twitched but she continued.

"For the Soul Immersion process to begin, you must spread some of this powder on your face and spread the rest of it on Adora's face. Then you must say the chant out loud. After you've said the chant, you must focus all of your energy onto Adora and imagine yourself becoming one with her mind."

"So how will I know when I'm in Adora's mind?" Catra asked.

"Many of the sorcerers who have performed this ritual successfully have said that they merely found themselves within a different world than their own. But since this process varies from person to person, I'm afraid I can't explain exactly how you'll know when you've performed this ritual successfully. You simply have to trust your soul when it happens."

"Great more cryptic bullshit," Catra replied.

"If you don't feel up to the challenge I could always get my niece to do it," Castapella replied.

Catra shook her head. "No, no I'll do it. I've taken down training robots since I was ten I'm sure I can handle this too. So just let me out of here and I'll go do it."

"Of course," Angella said. "But first…I believe someone wishes to speak with you."

Catra groaned. "Can't you tell them to take a number? In case you haven't noticed I'm under a lot of stress right now! And I barely slept at all last night. And whatever sleep I did get usually consisted of nightmares of what would happen if…"

Catra needn't finish her sentence for Angella to understand what she was getting at. Her face briefly contorted into a look of fear before she regained her composure.

"I understand but Scorpia still wishes to see that you're all right."

Catra's face dropped. "Scorpia? How is she? Is she all right? Shit, shit, shit! She's probably dead because she tried to save me from Adora, who I helped create in the first place and…"

"Catra,"

The queen's voice hadn't been loud or threatening. It was just said with enough force to render Catra quiet.

"Scorpia is in stable condition. Entrapta's quick thinking managed to slow the bleeding somewhat. But our physicians were able to stitch her up back up and she's been allowed to leave the infirmary at any given time."

Catra released a breath that she didn't know she was holding.

"Take me to see Scorpia."

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Scorpia groaned as she slowly regained consciousness.

Her head felt like one of Entrapta's hammers was banging constantly at her brain and her mouth was as dry as the deserts of the Southern Reach plains.

As she slowly opened her eyes, Scorpia found herself in what looked like an infirmary. Several beds, albeit unoccupied, lined the walls. The ceiling, walls and floors were all coated in white and several palace guards were stationed by the door. Some of them even had their spears pointed directly at her.

"Can't say I blame them," Scorpia rationalized to herself.

Scorpia tried to lift herself up but was immediately met with a sharp, stabbing pain across her chest. She let out a loud cry as she flopped back onto the bed.

"Easy now," Scorpia heard one of the palace guards say. "You suffered a major laceration across the chest and almost died of blood loss. You're quite lucky to be alive."

Scorpia furrowed her bow in confusion when the memories of earlier came flashing back in bits and pieces.

"Is Catra ok?" Scorpia asked.

"I fail to see how that's any of your business prisoner," The guard replied.

Scorpia narrowed her eyes. "My wildcat is one of my best friends, possibly the best friend I've ever had. I got this," Scorpia gestured to her chest. "Trying to protect Catra from Adora's wrath. I'd rather die from this than lose Catra. So again…is Catra ok?"

The other palace guard beside her bed sighed. "She's fine. She managed to make it back her with only minor bruises. She's currently being held in the castle dungeons along with Princess Entrapta."

Scorpia's eyes widened. "Entrapta? But I thought she was a princess?"

"She's been convicted of treason and is expected to be tried for her crimes once Adora has been cured."

Scorpia fell silent for a minute.

"I want to see her," She finally said.

"Entrapta?" The guard asked.

"Catra. I know you're already going to shut me down, but something tells me she's just as worried about me as I am about

her. Please grant me just this one request?"

The guard sighed before nodding to the other. The other guard left the room and momentarily later came back with the young Magicat in tow.

Upon noticing Scorpia, Catra rushed forward to the bed.

"Scorpia! Are you alright?"

Scorpia smiled. "I'm much better knowing that you're alright wildcat. Seeing how much you were worried about me doesn't hurt either."

Catra scoffed. "I wasn't worried! It's just…that wound looked pretty deep and…it could've been infected and…I wouldn't wish that on my worst enemy."

Scorpia simply smiled. "Whatever you say wildcat."

An awkward silence fell between the two for a brief time.

"So what's been going on since I've been out?" Scorpia asked.

Catra sighed before she began explaining everything from Entrapta's arrest, Shadow Weaver's main plan involving Adora, the process of Soul Immersion and where the Heart of Etheria was located. All the while Scorpia's eyes grew bigger and bigger.

"Man, the things you miss when you've been out for half a day."

"Can you focus?!" Catra shouted. "This is serious! We all could die or worse become soulless puppets for Shadow Weaver. I…saw something like that in my dreams last night…you and Entrapta… any everyone else was there. They looked exactly like Adora…all of them with their black hair and…black and red eyes. And…you guys told me that I was worthless and that…Adora was only my friend because she felt sorry for me."

"And you believe that?" Scorpia asked.

Catra sighed. "Scorp…when you get told things like this from someone that was basically a mother to you all your life…you start to believe it eventually."

Scorpia frowned and placed a claw around Catra's shoulder.

"Wildcat, I want you to look in the mirror on the wall and tell me what you see."

Catra glanced over. "Uhh…you and me on a bed in the infirmary?"

"And yet you see yourself as a worthless person?" Scorpia asked.

"I…you wouldn't understand," Catra replied as she bowed her head.

"I see a brave, strong and resilient individual who never ceases to amaze me with her leadership," Scorpia continued. "I'm sorry that no one else ever thought that about you but I always did! And Entrapta's always told me how she's connected with you more than anyone else in her life. And you think you're still worthless?"

Catra felt her lips twitch upward. "That's…nice of you to say."

"And I'll keep saying it until you believe it," Scorpia added.

Another brief silence filled the room as the two women struggled to find another conversation.

"So we're off to Dryl huh?" Scorpia asked, trying to change the subject.

"We're?" Catra asked.

"Well duh. I can't let you face certain danger alone wildcat," Scorpia replied.

"But you're still recovering," Catra replied. "Your stitches could just rip open again!"

Scorpia shrugged. "It's a small price to pay to protect the ones I care about in their time of need."

A sense of warmth flowed through Catra's system at Scorpia's words. She hadn't heard such words from anyone else except…

Scorpia's claw around her shoulder prevented Catra from falling into the thinking rabbit hole known as Adora.

"Hey…do you remember what I said back in the Fright Zone?" Scorpia asked.

"Feels like an eternity ago," Catra quietly muttered.

"Positive thinking. When you think something positive will happen, it generally does. Now repeat after me: everything will work out, everything will work out, everything will work out, everything will work out…"

Catra couldn't exactly tell how many times Scorpia repeated these words but within time she felt herself repeating the exact same thing.

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The mine was cold.

The surrounding heat seemed to die off as soon as Catra walked into the entrance. Everything inside the mine was quiet, only the sounds of dripping water could be heard while various chains, used to carte off extremely heavy pieces of rocks, hung motionless from the ceiling.

Catra shivered as she felt the cool air of the mine brush over her as the other princesses, along with Bow and SeaHawk caught up to her.

"There's definitely something big down there," Bow said as he glanced down at the revamped heat seeking tracker pad.

"According to this, the Heart of Etheria, is at least 1000 meters below the surface."

"Well we're not gonna find it just standing out here now are we?" Catra asked.

"Yes," Bow replied. "But we're gonna need an extreme source of illumination if we're gonna navigate our way through there."

Entrapta smiled. "Leave that to me."

Entrapta lowered her welding mask before she walked towards the entrance of the mine. With a turn of the mask's eyes, a blinding red light shot out from the two eye holes, illuminating the mine in a bright red light.

"A little modification I made to my mask, it really helped with those experiments I had to work on during blackouts."

"Entrapta and I will be in the front," Bow instructed. "Everyone else stay behind closely and in a single line. I have a feeling that not all areas of this place are the most secure."

"That is a correct assumption," Entrapta replied. "Several deaths have been attributed to cave ins, sinkholes, various bites from poisonous spiders…"

"Yeah Entrapta," Catra replied. "You're really not helping right now, how about less talking and more guiding."

Entrapta rubbed the back of her head before she motioned for Bow to follow her lead.

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For the first few minutes, the trek into the cave was uneventful.

The group mainly followed the set of tracks, typically used by the mine carts to lure out pieces of rocks, jewels or even First One's tech, as they made their way further underground.

Everything became more and more silent as they ventured further into the mine. The fact that Entrapta's red light caused every stalactite and stalagmite to give off an eerie glow didn't help much either.

But after what felt like an hour, Glimmer suddenly stopped in her tracks.

"Do you hear that?" Glimmer asked.

Everyone stopped and listened. Most of the group simply shrugged and shook their heads. But Catra's enhanced hearing skills made her hear something that turned her blood cold.

"Voices," She replied.

"Like the ones Entrapta talked about?" Bow asked, to which Catra nodded.

"They seem to be coming from down there," Catra said as she made her way off the cart tracks and towards a deep crevice with everyone following suit.

Catra grabbed a medium sized stone off the ground and threw it down the deep hole. A solid minute went by before she heard the unmistakable sound of rock hitting rock.

"Well that's encouraging," Mermista said as she stared down the deep hole.

Bow glanced at his tracker pad. A giant white and red signature was now right below the various blue and green dots that indicated their location.

"I think it's safe to say that the Heart is somewhere down there," Bow said.

"Well I could probably scale down there no problem with my claws," Catra said. "But I'm not sure how you guys can manage."

Bow smirked. "Not to worry. Entrapta a little light?"

Entrapta nodded as she stared down the giant hole. Although her powerful eye lanterns illuminated a great deal of the large fissure, the beams still failed to illuminate the bottom. Bow took out an arrow, with a rope attached, and fired straight down. Again, a solid minute passed before the archer heard his weapon clang against the rocks below.

Grabbing hold of the rope, Bow gave it a light tug. After ensuring that the line was secure he turned back to the others.

"Okay, one by one we're gonna climb down the rope. Entrapta will go first and provide some illumination for the others at the bottom. Once someone reaches the bottom, give the rope a tug so we know you made it."

Everyone nodded before Entrapta stepped forward and allowed her pigtails to wrap around the rope as she climbed deeper and deeper into the crevice. Entrapta's form seemed to slowly disappear from sight with only a red glow indicating her location. Finally, the red glow stopped moving and Bow felt the rope tug in his hand.

"I'll go next," Scorpia volunteered and made her way over before anyone could protest.

Scorpia glanced at the rope and then her sharp pinchers in concern before she felt green foliage coating her claws. Glancing up, Scorpia saw Perfuma with a gentle smile.

"Try that," Perfuma said.

Scorpia smiled before she grabbed hold of the rope and maneuvered down, the foliage providing a surprisingly good deal of friction. Within time, Scorpia saw Entrapta at the bottom of the crevice. The bottom looked just like the rest of the cave; expect that the voices were now much more noticeable. She couldn't make out what they were saying though. It was almost like a chorus of people trying to talk at the same time.

As Bow felt another tug on the rope, Catra stepped forward and began to make her way down before the earth around them shook violently. Catra nearly let go of the rope in shock.

"What was that?" SeaHawk asked.

"An earthquake?" Spinerella asked.

"Cave in?" Netossa asked.

Another violent shake struck through the mine, causing some to be knocked to their feet.

Bow glanced down at his pad and saw several dozen blue and green dots off in the distance.

"Uh guys? I think we have company." Bow stated as his eyes widened.

"Ugh!" Mermista groaned. "Of all the times the Horde tries to attack does it have to be when we're trying to save the world?"

Glimmer grabbed Bow's arm. "What do we do Bow? We can't let the Horde get in here but we also need as much help as we can get if we're gonna find the Heart!"

Bow furrowed his brow before he heard a voice call up at them.

"You guys hold off the Horde and make sure that neither Adora nor Shadow Weaver get through!" Catra yelled up. "I'll find the Heart!"

Catra no!" Bow cried. "You don't have my tracker pad! How are you going to find it?"

"I can hear the voices getting louder down here! Don't worry about me! Just do what you can to fend off the Horde!"

"Catra you can't!" Glimmer cried.

Catra looked down. "Hey Scorpia can you hear me?"

"Yeah but barely wildcat!" Scorpia's voice echoed.

Catra closed her eyes and breathed deeply. "Get ready to catch me."

Everyone let out a loud gasp.

"Catra what are you doing?" Glimmer cried.

Catra glanced up at Bow and Glimmer and gave a ghost of a smile.

"Saving the world."

And with a swipe of her claws, Catra felt weightless as she plummeted down into the hole. The cries of the others grew fainter and fainter as she disappeared into the darkness.

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Bow tried desperately to grab the rope and pull Catra back up but he only managed to pull the severed rope back into his hands.

"Augh! That dumb cat!" Glimmer cried. "If we all went with her she'd have a better chance at finding the Heart!"

Another shockwave rocked through the cave, this one much more violent than before.

"Glimmer," Bow said. "Catra's right. We can't let the Horde anywhere near the Heart! She made her choice and we have to make our own!"

Glimmer sighed before the commander in her took over.

"Bow how many dots do you count outside the mine?"

Bow looked at his pad. "Probably at least 100 of them."

Glimmer gulped but remained steadfast.

"Everyone outside the mine! Fend them off as much as you can! Once we've subdued them enough we'll try and get back down there!"

Everyone nodded as they ran out of the mine. Although walking down the mine felt like an eternity, running back up to the entrance felt like they were there before they knew it.

As Glimmer ran out of the mine's entrance, and saw a dozen Horde skiffs approaching, she only had one thought in her mind.

"I really hope Catra knows what she's doing."

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Catra let out a loud grunt as she felt herself fall into Scorpia's arms. Thankfully there was still plenty of foliage on the princess's claws to prevent them from cutting into her.

"Gotcha!" Scorpia cried as she enveloped Catra into a tight hug. "Do you realize you're nearly giving me a heart attack every time you endanger yourself wildcat?"

Catra squirmed out of Scorpia's tight embrace as she tried not to blind herself by looking into Entrapta's eye beams.

"What's going on up there?" Scorpia asked.

Catra sighed. "The Horde's approaching us and fast."

Entrapta let out a slight gasp as Scorpia's eyes widened.

"But how did they…I didn't tell anyone about…how could they…" Scorpia struggled to find the words.

"Look the how doesn't matter," Catra said. "What matters is finding that First One's thing before they do."

"But how can we do that?" Entrapta asked. "The whole strength in numbers philosophy is significantly diminished based on how few

people we have."

"Plus nobody's seen this thing since the First Ones," Scorpia added. "How do we know what to look for?"

Catra returned to her trademark smirk. "Hey we've done a lot on our own already. And my eyes allow me to see better in the dark. Combine that with Entrapta's light and we should see something sooner or later."

Scorpia and Entrapta looked at each other for a moment before they nodded in agreement.

Catra, meanwhile, turned her head and began walking over various rocks. Entrapta's light at the back managed to light most of the way but Catra still felt fortunate that her eyes could see further into the dark.

For what seemed like forever the trio walked forward, not exactly sure what they were looking for. But eventually, they came across a set of three holes carved into the rock wall in front of them. Each of them were no bigger than the width of a child.

"Well shoot," Scorpia sighed. "Now what?"

"Logically splitting up would allow us to enter all three cavities and increase our possibility ratio of locating the Heart of Etheria by 35.7 percent," Entrapta replied.

"Yeah that's all fine and good expect I don't think I can fit through there," Scorpia added.

"You won't have to," Catra said as she walked towards the center hole. "I can see that the inside of this hole is slightly lighter than the others."

"And we're about 1000 miles from the surface so sunlight is out of the question," Entrapta added as she placed a hair hand under her chin.

Catra smirked as she climbed the wall in front of her before she grabbed the edge of the hole and pulled herself in.

"Wait Catra!" Scorpia called. "I know you have great vision and everything but even those eyes can't see through all that darkness!"

Catra paused for a minute. "Entrapta toss me your welding mask."

Entrapta raised an eyebrow but performed the action anyway. Catching it in her hand, Catra placed the mask over her face, turned the beams on and began to crawl her way through the tight space.

Despite the adrenaline pumping through her system an odd sense of comfort and nostalgia came over Catra. She had often loved to crawl into tight spaces, such as the Horde's air ducts, under bed bunks and even behind the kitchen stoves as she was in the process of stealing sweets. She never felt claustrophobic in these kinds of settings. She never could explain why but figured it was something in her DNA.

As Catra continued to climb through the passage, the hole became brighter and brighter, to a point where she had to turn the beams off because they ceased to serve a purpose.

Finally, Catra saw the end of the tunnel with the light practically blinding by now.

With careful precision, Catra squeezed her way forward until half of her body was sticking out of the end of the hole. Placing both hands on the rocky surface around her, Catra pulled forward and landed on all fours.

Catra stood up and brushed herself off before the sight in front of her took her breath away.

A blue jewel, probably the size of the Black Garnett, was positioned in the center of the room. The jewel glowed brightly; leaving hardly any shadows in the room. But although the outside

of the jewel was blue, the inside was a swirling vortex of various colors with various tones. The top and bottom of the jewel was held in place by several golden vines, each as thick as a tree's roots, which ran into the ground and into the ceiling high above.

Standing next to it, Catra was able to see why some people claimed to have heard voices in the mine. The jewel ran with so much power, it frequently produced a buzzing sound that seemed to be mixed with the voices of various Etherian residents. Every gender, every age and every race of people on the planet seemed to have been flowing through the energy given off by the jewel.

The whole spectacle made Catra's eyes light up in wonderment.

But just before she could even step forward, she heard a voice come from right behind her. It was so close to her ears that it was almost as if the person had bent down and had their mouth mere inches away from her ears.

"Hey Catra." Adora whispered.

Chapter End Notes

Aren't cliffhangers a bitch?

So I'm just gonna call it right now, I probably won't finish this story before Season 3 comes out. Personally I would much rather take my time to craft a story to my liking versus rushing something out and regretting it later.

However, I am definitely planning on getting another chapter out, probably my longest one, before then so look forward to that!

Until then: Peace!

Part 12

Chapter Notes

> Hot damn how about that Season 3 trailer and those two clips that came out? It's like I was pretty excited about season 3 but now I'm on a whole other plane of excitement. But regardless I was happy to get one last chapter out before the third season dropped.
>
> Thanks again for all the likes and follows!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra didn't dare to turn around.

She wished more than anything that the voice she heard was just a figment of her imagination or perhaps made from the jewel itself.

But her gut feeling, along with her instinctive feline curiosity, got the better of her.

Adora, in all her terrifying glory, stood no less than ten feet away. Her smile was one of a predator that had just cornered its prey.

"It's beautiful isn't it?" Adora asked.

Catra's fur bristled.

"How'd you find me Adora?"

Adora pulled out a black claw and took a long, deep sniff.

"With a scent so strong has yours, it was easy to track you down. But I have to thank you for doing all the hard work. It'll make my mission so much easier."

Adora started to walk in the direction of the massive jewel but Catra jumped in front of her, with her claws extracted to their

fullest length.

"Touch that rock…and I'll tear you in two"

Adora paused before she made a laugh so emotionless and cold that it turned Catra's bones to ice.

"Oh Catra, has anyone told you how amusing you are?"

Catra only narrowed her eyes in response.

"We both know there's only way this is going to end and it involves me becoming one with all of Etheria. And who knows… maybe I'll let you become the first of mother's army."

"I'd rather have my head cut off and thrown into the sea than be a puppet for Shadow Weaver again!" Catra sneered.

Adora grinned wickedly as she drew her sword out from behind her.

"If you wanted that all along you should've said so."

And faster than Catra could blink, Adora charged forward as she held her sword up high but Catra managed to duck down and plant a kick into Adora's stomach. Through she didn't fly far; it still took her by surprise enough to move away a few feet.

Catra got back on her feet and looked at the sack of magical powder on her belt. Quickly she reached into the bag and threw some of the powder in her face, being careful that none of it went into her eyes and mouth.

"Gotta find some way to get this stuff onto Adora."

Adora snarled as she stood back up and charged again.

"Might as well do it on my hands, Catra thought in a sarcastic tone.

Catra flipped in the air and landed on Adora's back as she ran her claws over Adora's back. Adora screamed as she charged backwards into a rocky wall.

Catra felt her body crumple as the hard surface slammed against her but she had barely enough time to process the pain before Adora slammed her back into the wall again and again. Catra heard a soft crack before she felt a warm sensation move from her head to her neck. Adora then grabbed her by her neck and landed punch after punch against Catra's face. Catra felt the same liquid pouring out her nose and mouth like a waterfall. But just before Catra could use her claws to fight back, Adora threw her to the ground and she landed with a loud thump. Catra groaned as she placed two fingers at the back of her head before she inspected the damage. Thick blood painted her fingers as she tasted copper in her mouth. Catra wanted to cry out in pain or panic about blood loss but she pushed those thoughts aside as she slowly rose to her feet.

"Enough of this childish nonsense," Adora said. "Why don't you just surrender now and accept the inevitable?"

Catra spat out a wad of blood. "Over my dead body you freak!"

"Right the one with the fur, cat ears and multicolored eyes is calling me a freak," Adora replied as she crossed her arms. "Hypocrisy never looks good on anyone Catra."

"Neither does Shadow Weaver's soulless puppet look," Catra replied as she cracked her neck.

Adora and Catra began to walk around in a circle, their eyes never leaving the others.

"So you're saying you won't join me and mother's quest to rule all of Etheria? Think about it Adora…you and me calling the shots… ruling over Etheria…living as immortals. The Catra I knew would've jumped at the opportunity."

"Guess you don't know me very well," Catra smirked.

"And I guess I never will."

Adora charged again. But Catra, fortunately, had been expecting this and managed to jump onto Adora's back and flip into the air. But what she had not expected was Adora transforming her sword into a whip, catching her by the ankle and falling to the ground.

As Adora began to rope in her prey, Catra clawed the ground in vain but Adora's increased strength made her efforts futile. Looking at her waist, Catra saw that the bag of powder was still intact. Thinking on her feet, Catra rolled herself into a ball and squirmed around. Adora snarled as she threw back her hand and extended the whip to full length. Catra flew through the air before she landed on the ground.

Adora transformed her whip back into a sword and walked towards Catra's body before she aimed the blade at Catra's neck.

"Any last words you filthy animal?"

"Kwaoo, boorta, nwooo," Catra mumbled.

Adora snarled, wrapped her hand around Catra's collar and pulled her up to her face.

"What was that?"

Catra spat out a blue dusty substance into Adora's face. Adora screamed as she rubbed her eyes furiously.

"Klatuu, Barata, Nikto!"

Adora suddenly paused, as if a switch inside her was placed in the OFF position, as she turned and faced Catra. Her face, once of rage, had fallen completely expressionless. Her eyes were wide open, staring at everything and yet seeing nothing.

Despite not wanting to look into her eyes, Catra forced herself to make eye contact with Adora as she remembered Castapella's words from earlier.

"You must focus all of your energy onto Adora and imagine yourself becoming one with her mind."

Despite not being any closer to understanding what the sorceress meant, Catra tried to think of everything related to her former friend.

"Adora, think Adora, naïve, stubborn, kind of dumb, good natured, blonde hair that I would give anything to scrape my claws through, sky blue eyes that I could get lost all day in, the one person who saw me as a friend instead of a pest. The only true friend I've ever had, who now may be gone forever because of me."

The tears were already flowing down Catra's face but she refused to wipe them away.

"Adora…if any part of you is still in there…please let me in… please…please…please…"

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Glimmer smirked as she plunged her father's staff into the horde tank and teleported away before it burst into flames.

A ways over, Spinerella and Mermista managed to create a giant wave in the sky as it swept away the war machines like they were mere bath toys.

The battle between the Princess's and the Horde's army had been going on for a full ten minutes.

Although they were successful in keeping the tanks from entering the cave, an uneasy feeling still came over Glimmer the entire time. Once the initial adrenaline wore off, the sparkly princess started to notice how none of the soldiers within the tanks would ever try to attack on foot. The tanks themselves wouldn't even come within 10 feet of the cave entrance.

As Netossa created another net wall to barricade them from the tank's fire, Glimmer turned to Bow.

"Bow have you noticed anything strange about this whole thing?"

"Uh I haven't really thought about anything besides trying to stay alive Glimmer," Bow replied as he loaded another arrow into his bow.

"Haven't you noticed that there haven't been any soldiers actually exiting their tanks? You think they'd try and rush us all at once so they could overpower us."

Bow had barely a second to process Glimmer's words before the tanks suddenly began driving way in the opposite direction. Glimmer expected them to deploy some sort of super weapon that would catch them by surprise, but the battered machines merely disappeared over the horizon.

For a solid minute, everyone stood there in disbelief.

"So…we won?" Mermista asked.

"Of course we won!" SeaHawk boasted. "Nothing can stop the sense of ADVENTURE!"

While Mermista rolled her eyes, Glimmer began pacing before a certain thought caused her heart to drop into her stomach

"Bow…do you remember Adora talking about battle tactics that the Horde excels in?"

Bow nodded. "Yeah, full frontal assault, sweeping strikes, distractions and…"

The realization hit Bow harder than a stun baton's electric shock. It seemed to hit everyone else at the same time too because they all looked at each other with wide eyes.

"Did…anyone see Shadow Weaver or Adora anywhere in that battalion?" Bow asked.

Everyone fearfully shook their heads no.

Bow and Glimmer took one last look at each other before they raced into the cave faster than their legs could carry them.

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Catra opened her eyes to find herself surrounded in darkness.

Her body felt weightless and yet there was still a strange sort of weight around her limbs. It was similar to being in a swimming pool, albeit from the rare occasions she found herself in water.

As she saw bubbles escape her mouth, Catra's brain instantly went into panic mode as she struggled to hold her breath.

When her lungs became like fire, Catra finally let out a large breath, scattering various bubbles into the darkness.

But instead of feeling fluid enter her lungs, Catra instead felt air enter them as usual.

"I think I'm officially desensitized to weird shit."

Turning her body, Catra found herself facing a giant circle of light. Its yellow and orange tones gave Catra a sort of warm feeling. But the feeling was quickly extinguished when she saw the darkness begin to eat away at the edges of the hole.

Realizing what that meant, Catra swam down faster and faster, not knowing exactly what she was looking for or what she'd expect to find.

As she continued swimming downward, Catra noticed a small yellow and flesh colored dot. Swimming closer, Catra saw the outline of a head come into view.

"ADORA!"

Catra pushed her muscles harder than a day lifting weights. But as she got closer, Catra noticed something that frightened her.

Although Adora's head was visible, the rest of her body was not. It was as if her whole body had simply vanished into the darkness.

When Catra was close enough to Adora, she stopped swimming and allowed her body to float down to Adora's eye level.

Adora's eyes were closed and a pleasant expression crossed her face, as if she were having a pleasant dream that she didn't want to wake up from.

The sight of Adora' seemingly severed head unnerved Catra greatly. But still she gathered all her strength to come closer.

"Adora wake up!"

Adora opened her eyes slowly and glanced at Catra. Her eyes squinted in confusion before she threw her head back and laughed.

"Wow! You…look…fuzzy. Mr. Fuzzypants! That's who you are!"

Catra tilted her head in confusion. "Adora? It's me Catra!"

Adora tilted her head from side to side.

"Cat…ra…can't imagine how you got that name," Adora laughed like someone who had one too many glasses of wine at the Princess Prom.

"Adora…what's happened to you? Where's the rest of your body?"

"I don't know…where's the rest of your body?" Adora laughed again as she threw her head back in laughter.

Catra's face sank as she came closer to Adora and placed both of her hands on the sides of her face.

"Adora this isn't funny! You're in all kinds of horrible trouble and you don't even realize it!"

"Who's danger?" Adora asked.

Catra let out a scream of frustration.

"Adora listen to me! Shadow Weaver's placed a spell on you that's taken over your body and mind! This isn't real! You're trapped in this…place and I'm responsible for getting you out of here."

Adora's eyes looked from side to side but she didn't say anything to regard to Catra's statements. Catra meanwhile looked up at the circle of light. Despite being so far away, Catra could still see the hole becoming increasingly smaller and smaller as the seconds passed by.

"Adora…we gotta swim back up to the hole above us! Or at least… move your head upwards?"

Adora glanced up at the hole and winced.

"Ah, too bright! Don't like it! I'll just stay here."

"Listen to her."

The unexpected third feminine voice caused Catra's neck fur to stand on end.

"Who's there? Show yourself!"

"Who I am is unimportant," The voice continued. "What's important is your foolish attempts at helping Adora. You've been nothing but an annoying pest, always trying to stop Adora from her true fate."

"SHUT UP!" Catra roared. "Adora you have to remember who you are! You have to remember how you got here! It's the only way we can get you…us out of here!"

Adora's face scrunched up into an expression that suggested that she was thinking but it quickly went back to her dopey smile.

"I can't think of…Mora, sorry fluffy."

Catra felt her vision become blurry with tears as she saw the hole above becoming smaller and smaller. She placed both hands on the side of Adora's head and placed her forehead against Adora's. The panic that stared out as a spark had turned into a forest fire.

"This is how it's gonna end," Catra tearfully whispered. "I'm gonna be trapped in here forever while Shadow Weaver and your body destroy everything. I wish back in the woods I could've just said: Hey Adora and…"

The words 'hey' and 'Adora' caused something in Adora's mind to brighten as if a light bulb had suddenly gone off in her head.

Pictures and sounds flew past her eyes. She saw a young blonde girl being called Adora by a tall woman with wavy black hair. She saw the same girl with another girl, which matched this new person's description, coloring under a blanket while one of them held up a flashlight. She saw the same two girls boasting about which one could take out more princesses than the other. She then witnessed the same two girls racing down a hallway as they tried their hand at a friendly competition.

"Catch me if you can slowpoke!"

"Catra slow down!"

More and more words began to flow in and out of Adora's mind, each one becoming louder and clearer than the next.

"The two of us look out for each other."

"You promise?"

"I promise."

"Cover for me Catra no one will even know I'm gone."

"It doesn't matter what they do to us."

"The tiara actually gets stupider the more I look at it."

"Oh Adora…I don't want you to."

"Every hero needs a sidekick."

"I wonder what I could've been if I got rid of you sooner."

"I never meant to make you feel like you were second best!"

"For Etheria!"

"Can't we just talk?"

"What's rule 10 of combat training?"

"FOR THE HONOR OF GREYSKULL!"

"GREYSKULL!"

"GREYSKULL:

"GREYSKULL!"

Catra slowly opened her eyes when she felt sudden warmth against her body. Catra's eyes widened as she saw more and more of Adora's body materialize from the darkness. First her neck appeared, then her chest along with the arms and finally the legs.

Adora slowly opened her eyes, those sky blue eyes that Catra had missed more than she cared to admit, as she gazed at Catra before a gentle smile appeared on her face.

"C-Catra?"

Catra's eyes nearly popped out of her sockets as she threw her arms around Adora.

"Adora! Do you know who I am? Can you remember anything at all?"

Adora's smile never left her face as she rubbed Catra's back. "I'm Adora, you're Catra. I'm also an eight foot tall warrior woman and you like to eat mice."

Catra turned back to look at her. "That was one time you dork!"

Adora looked around in confusion.

"Catra what is this place?"

"There's no time," Catra replied as she grabbed Adora's hand. "We gotta get to that hole above us! It's our only way outta here!"

Adora nodded as she and Catra moved their legs rapidly through the darkness, which seemed to feel thicker and thicker by the second.

"Adora!" The voice cried out.

Adora's eyes widened. "What the hell is that?"

"Don't talk SWIM!"

Adora and Catra kept swimming upwards, both of their legs feeling more like liquid fire than flesh and bone.

"Adora you can't do this to me! We are destined to be together! I won't rest until you've come home!"

By the time Adora and Catra can within 50 feet of the hole, it had decreased to the size of a small playground ball.

"Adora! Give me your hand!"

Adora complied as she placed her hand in Catra's. Catra threw her hand up to the hole with Adora's in tow.

The light felt warmth against their hands as Catra pressed herself and Adora further and further.

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Like waking up from a nightmare, Catra screamed as she opened her eyes and took a deep breath. She found herself still facing Adora as the Heart glowed in the distance.

Adora's eyes began to change from black and red to her traditional blue ones. She glanced down at her transformed state and screamed.

"Catra?! What's happened to me?"

"Dammit Adora there's no time for questions! You gotta let go of the sword! It's the only way the crystal will come off!"

Tears flowed down Adora's cheeks as she tried to open her right hand. But every movement caused violent shocks of electricity to ricochet throughout her system.

"It hurts Catra! It's too much, I can't do it!"

"Yes you can! I know you Adora! You're stronger than any of the shit Shadow Weaver could do to us! You can't let her win!" Catra wrapped her hands around Adora's right. "TRY AGAIN!"

Adora let out a guttural scream as she felt her right hand open fully. As the sword fell to the ground, the data crystal dislodged itself from the jewel as it clattered to the floor.

A bright flash of light turned Adora back into her non She-Ra form, but the black hair and blue skin remained.

Catra unsheathed her claws as she began violently scratching the crystal more than her favorite scratching post. Her lungs produced

several feral screams as she produced more and more scratch marks, despite her claws gradually cracking under the pressure. Finally Catra took to using her fists to punch the crystal again and again, despite the feeling of blood running down her hands. Finally, Catra grabbed the sword and plunged it straight into the gem's center over and over again.

When she felt like her volcano of rage had simmered down, Catra looked down and saw that the crystal was broken into dozens of pieces. She then glanced back at Adora. Adora's black hair slowly morphed back into a golden yellow. Her sharp, black fingernails shrunk back into her pink, well trimmed ones. Her skin slowly faded into her fair complexion and her breathing became more and more steady.

Adora groaned before she forced herself onto her arms. Her bleary eyes opened in confusion.

"Catra? Where am I? What are you…"

The force of Catra's hug knocked Adora back onto the ground as Catra began to cry.

"It's you…it's really you," Catra whispered. "I did it. I saved you."

"Save me?" Adora asked. "From what…" The memories of the past 24 hours slowly seeped into Adora's brain. "Oh."

Catra broke away from the hug. "Yeah…I'm…sorry about what I did. I didn't know this would happen or that Shadow Weaver was involved and then you were nearly lost forever and now you'll never forgive me…"

Adora wrapped her arms around Catra and squeezed with all her might.

"Catra you risked your life to save me…that's more than enough for me."

Catra's brain continued to scream that Adora hated her forever now, but her heart gave into the warmth of the hug she had missed for so long.

Adora's eyes fell upon the Heart of Etheria as she let out a quiet gasp.

"What is that?"

Catra looked over. "The Heart of Etheria. The center of the whole planet."

"It's beautiful."

"Probably the most beautiful thing you're ever seen," Catra commented.

Adora looked back at Catra. Though she often saw the best qualities of her friend in close proximity, the glow of the jewel seemed to enhance these even more. How her eyes would glow brighter than any of the moons in the sky, how her freckles made her face even cuter and how her lips seemed even more soft and kissable.

Adora stepped closer to Catra and glance at her lips. "I can think of one thing."

Whatever Catra had intended to say was interrupted by a wall of rock behind them exploding into pieces. Adora and Catra dove to the ground as Adora wrapped an arm around her in protection. When the dust settled, Adora and Catra looked up and felt their hearts drop as Shadow Weaver floated into the room, with Scorpia and Entrapta held in her red electric field.

"You…failed me Adora." Shadow Weaver said each syllable with pure venom.

"Shadow Weaver!" Adora grabbed the sword with both hands and aimed it at her former mother figure.

"I gave you the chance to rule by my side and instead that insufferable furball has to ruin everything!"

"That insufferable furball has a name you know," Adora replied.

"Just like yours happens to be fuckface," Catra replied as she unsheathed her claws. "Let Scorpia and Entrapta go. They have nothing to do with this."

"I feel it appropriate to punish all traitors to the Horde, least of all someone who stands in the way of my goals." Shadow Weaver approached closer as Entrapta and Scorpia screamed out in agony as another shock rocked their systems.

"It's over Shadow Weaver," Adora proclaimed as she stepped closer.

"Over?" Shadow Weaver laughed. "Oh Adora you should know that it's never over until the deed is done."

Catra picked up several pieces of the data crystal and allowed them to drop in front of her.

"It's over fuckface," Catra said.

"And we're not going to let you hurt anyone ever again," Adora replied.

"Oh Adora, I thought I taught you well but it still seems like you fail to see how powerful I truly am."

And with a flick of wrist, Shadow Weaver caused the pieces of the data crystal to float into the air before they formed together again into a symmetrical shape.

When the crystal was formed again, Shadow Weaver moved the crystal into her hand.

"Now then Adora," Shadow Weaver whispered in a slow voice. "Let's try this again."

"NO!" Catra screamed as she ran forward and rammed her fist into Shadow Weaver's mask. Her knuckles cried out in agony as she connected with the solid steel but her adrenaline made her fail to notice it. Catra swiped her hands across every square inch of Shadow Weaver's body. Shadow Weaver cried out in agony as the force field around Scorpia and Entrapta vanished causing both of them to fall to the ground.

Shadow Weaver caught one of Catra's hands in her own as she sent an electric shock throughout Catra's system. Catra screamed as Scorpia wrapped both claws around the sorceress and tried to subdue her. But Shadow Weaver surrounded herself in a shadow force field causing Scorpia to fly into a wall before she collapsed onto the ground, unmoving. Catra meanwhile felt herself being thrown through the air until her back made contact with the Heart of Etheria. Catra felt all the air in her lungs disappear as she lay on the ground in pain. Shadow Weaver then sent another shadow to float around Entrapta as it began to slowly suck all the air out of the genius's lungs.

Adora raced forward with her sword but Shadow Weaver caught her in another shadow and threw her against the wall. Adora had barely enough time to groan before she felt herself being slammed against the wall.

Shadow Weaver began flowing over to Adora as she summoned the data crystal to her hand.

"That'll be quite enough of that Adora. I'm honestly surprised that Castapella even remembered the Soul Immersion process. I always thought I was the only one who could master it. But regardless your friend just used up the last of her magical powder. This means that as soon as you fall back into my grasp there won't be anyone who can save you."

Shadow Weaver hoisted Adora into the air so her face was only inches away from Adora's.

"Any last words Adora?"

Adora opened her eyes, glanced down and smiled. "What's rule 10 of combat training?"

Shadow Weaver nearly threw Adora into the rocks out of rage. "Insolent child! I taught you well enough to know that you should always keep an eye on every aspect of your opponent. Because you…can…"

Shadow Weaver suddenly felt an empty weight in her hand. Glancing down, she saw that the data crystal was nowhere in sight. Turning around, she saw Scorpia and Entrapta still on the ground but Catra was nowhere in sight. Shadow Weaver let out a feral scream as she dropped Adora and began stalking forward menacingly.

"You are making a grave mistake Catra. Give me that crystal and I promise I'll make your death swift and somewhat painful."

"You want the crystal?" Catra's voice called out.

Shadow Weaver moved her head around rapidly, trying to find the source of the voice.

"Then…TAKE IT!"

Shadow Weaver moved her head up just in time to see Catra leaping off the Heart of Etheria with the data crystal raised in the air. Before the old witch could even gasp, Catra stabbed the crystal into the red crystal on Shadow Weaver's mask. Instantly, fleshy red tentacles invaded the sorceress's jewel as her veins became bigger and redder. Shadow Weaver screamed in agony as she threw Catra off of her and began to stumble around in agony. By this point, Scorpia, Entrapta and Adora had begun to regain consciousness as the scene unfolded before them.

Shadow Weaver's hair stopped moving in a wavy form as it draped over her face before it began to fall out in clumps until she was completely bald. She then glanced down at her hands and saw the flesh begin to bubble rapidly, like water in a boiling pot. The skin then took on a more liquid state as it fell onto the ground

leaving nothing but stark white bones behind. More of Shadow Weaver's flesh began to ooze out of the bottom of her mask and her cloak as the blue colored liquid made a small pool on the ground. Shadow Weaver continued to scream as her body became noticeably thinner and thinner. Then without warning, Shadow Weaver's entire body exploded in a cloud of dust. Pieces of her long garment lay scattered on the floor while her mask and the data crystal lay on the floor, perfectly intact.

It had all happened so fast that the three women had to let a full minute go by before they could regain their bearings.

"Uhh…what just happened?" Scorpia asked.

"That witch went back to whatever hell she came from," Catra replied as she took a ragged breath.

Catra slowly helped Scorpia to her feet. "You going to be okay there big girl?"

Scorpia let out a small laugh. "Yeah I'll be fine. Shadow Weaver's a pretty hard hitter but I'm stronger than she thought."

Catra placed an arm around Entrapta. "You okay Entrapta?"

Entrapta wheezed a little as she sucked more air into her lungs. "I think so. Although I've never seen a runestone quite like that one before! Do you think I can study it?"

Catra laughed. "Sorry trap but I think this hunk of rock is exactly where it needs to be."

A low groan snapped Catra's attention towards Adora, who had slowly gotten to her feet, albeit with a slight stumble in her step. Catra ran over to Adora and enveloped her in a hug.

"Nice shot Catra," Adora laughed, albeit weakly. "How'd you even know that'd work?"

Catra rubbed the back of her head. "To be honest…I was just hoping to stab that crystal into her brain but…this works too."

Adora glanced at Shadow Weaver's mask on the ground. "She's… really gone. It's finally over."

"Yeah…and you're…you again." Catra prayed Adora couldn't see the blush on her cheeks.

"Thanks for saving me again Catra. I don't even know how I can even repay you for everything you've done for me."

Catra glanced at Adora's lips. "I can think of one way."

Catra and Adora began to lean their faces closer and closer when they were suddenly interrupted by the sounds of various voices and footsteps approaching their location. Glancing at the now destroyed wall, Catra saw the other princesses along with Bow and SeaHawk approaching.

"Catra!" Glimmer cried. "We're sorry we couldn't get here sooner but we think Shadow Weaver and Adora are…"

Upon seeing Adora in her normal state, everyone rushed over and wrapped their arms around Adora.

"ADORA!" Everyone cried out.

"You're okay," Glimmer whispered as tears of joy poured down her cheek. "You're…really okay."

Adora smiled. "Thanks to Catra."

Everyone turned towards Catra who had a slight blush on her cheeks. "Yeah…it was nothing really."

Glimmer removed herself from the group hug and approached Catra with a neutral look on her face before she threw her arms around her.

"Thank you," Glimmer whispered.

One by one, everyone began to envelop Catra in a hug as they each said their thanks. Catra, unfamiliar with such displays of affection, tried to blink back the tears.

"I…I…I can't handle all this mushiness."

Adora laughed, god how Catra had missed that laugh. "Afraid that's how it is with us Catra."

As the group broke off from the hug, Perfuma noticed the pile of blue goo on the floor, along with Shadow Weaver's mask.

"What happened in here?" Perfuma asked.

Catra glanced at her former mentor's remains before she went into detail about the Soul Immersion, Shadow Weaver and what happened when she stabbed the witch's crystal.

"It's possible that the combined magic of her powers along with the magic in the crystal caused the two super nomadic forms to overload until all energy was spent." Entrapta theorized.

"You mean like how one major fire cancels out another when they come into contact?" Perfuma asked.

Surprised to hear someone being able to decipher her words, Entrapta turned towards the flower princess and smiled. "Yeah… that's one way of putting it."

Catra was just about to say something to break the tension, when a loud rumbling echoed throughout the chamber.

"CAVE IN!" Bow cried. "We gotta get out of here now!"

"Entrapta grab the crystal!" Glimmer cried.

Entrapta raced over and picked up the shard before she placed it in her overall pocket. Everyone began to run out of the chamber

with Catra the last in tow. But before Catra left, she grabbed Shadow Weaver's mask off the floor.

As everyone raced up the mine tracks towards the daylight, several rocks began to tumble around them. Netossa managed to generate a protective shield so that none of the rocks could knock them out cold.

When they finally ran out into the daylight, everyone turned to see the tunnel fill up with more and more rocks until the entrance became nothing but a wall of stone.

"The Heart of Etheria buried again," Bow said.

"Thank the First Ones," Netossa added as she swung an arm around Spinerella.

Suddenly, Adora groaned as she stumbled and held her head.

Glimmer and Bow rushed over and nearly screamed at the blood that had caked into the back of Adora's skull.

"Adora's hurt! We gotta get her back to BrightMoon right away!"

No sooner had she spoken, Swift Wind came flying out of the clouds and landed in front of the group.

"Did someone say Swift Wind?!"

"Uhh…no but we're sure glad you're here," Bow replied as he hoisted Adora onto the steed's back. "How'd you manage to find us?"

"I was just keeping watch at the castle when I felt Adora's presence again," Swift Wind replied. "I can't tell you how great it is to feel that again!"

"Huh a talking horse? Okay," Catra said.

"Yeah I know pretty crazy but usually it gets a bigger reaction from people," Swift Wind replied.

"Well my best friend turned into Shadow Weaver Jr., I entered a weird vortex, found a giant, glowing rock and saw my tormentor collapse into a pile of goo. I think you're kinda low of the weird totem pole," Catra replied.

"Touché," Swift Wind replied as Glimmer and Bow hopped on. "Anyone else coming?"

"We'll be at the castle shortly," Entrapta replied as she pulled the crystal out of her pocket. "There's something I have to do first."

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Entrapta gazed down the volcano.

Orange magma bubbled gently as the fumes rose to the surface. The heat was so intense that the genius had to stand back a few feet just so her face wouldn't burn up.

Entrapta glanced down at the crystal in her hands.

"To think…so many secrets could've been on this crystal. Secrets we may never see again on any First One's artifact."

Entrapta felt a hand on her shoulder. Glancing up, she saw Perfuma giving her a gentle smile. Over her shoulder, Entrapta saw the rest of the group (Mermista, SeaHawk, Netossa, Spinerella, Catra and Scorpia) nodding slowly.

Entrapta flicked the data crystal into the volcano. Everyone walked closer to the edge and saw the green object sizzle and pop before it disappeared beneath the magma.

Everyone felt as if their shoulders became infinitely lighter as they each breathed a sigh of relief.

Perfuma wrapped her arms around Entrapta. "Thanks Entrapta. I know how hard this must be for you."

Entrapta shrugged. "There are always more things I could study… If I get a chance."

Perfuma placed a finger under Entrapta's chin and raised it so that the two women were looking into each other's eyes.

"We will deal with that later. But I have a feeling the universe will work out in your favor."

Catra rolled her eyes at the flower princess's obsession with the universe solving her problems but said nothing. As everyone began making their way down the volcano, Catra heard Scorpia call out.

"Hey Catra! Aren't you coming?"

"Yeah…I'll catch up," Catra replied, her eyes never leaving the volcano.

Once she was sure that everyone was gone, Catra pulled out Shadow Weaver's mask and stared down at the object with morbid fascination.

The very face she feared to look at every day, the face that had been emotionless the entire moment she made her life a living hell was right in her hands. Throughout her childhood, she used to think that nothing could've taken the old witch down. She always thought that when she and Adora would rule the Fright Zone, they'd just imprison the witch in a cell or banish her to Beast Island. But although the hands of fate led her on a far different path, Catra began to realize how it had ultimately landed in her favor and that she ultimately wouldn't have it any other way.

Catra hissed before she flung the mask straight into the volcano.

The mask bounced off the volcano's walls before it landed in the magma with a loud splash. Catra glanced down and watched as the mask was slowly swallowed by the magma. The soulless white eyes seemed to stare back at Catra for the longest time before they eventually were melted away by the hot liquid.

Catra released a breath she didn't realize she was holding as she glanced up at the sky. Her entire chest seemed lighter, her very heart felt more free and alive than it had been in a long time.

Shadow Weaver, her lifelong tormentor, her childhood boogeyman was finally gone. No longer did she feel like she was being watched, no longer did she feel like she had to look behind her back every few seconds for fear of being caught by the very witch.

She was free.

Catra turned and eventually caught up to Scorpia who the later could've sworn that the young Magicat had a bit of a skip in her step.

Chapter End Notes

Ding dong the witch is dead

This was a really fun chapter to write and I'm glad to see how many of you are enjoying it!

I can't say for sure when I'll get the next (and final) chapter out as Season 3's coming out this weekend and I want to binge watch that like there's no tomorrow (and also recover from the inevitable angst it's going to provide). But I will definitely continue to work out and it will come out soon.

Until then: Peace!

Part 13

Chapter Notes

I'm back, rested, recovered from the angst of Season 3 and am ready to give you the Catra/Adora content you deserve!

So, hope you enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The voices came and went.

Adora never understood what they were saying, but their tones always indicated a sense of worry. Sometimes her body would feel weightless; other times it felt like the entire gravitational force of the planet were situated on her. But either way, Adora just laid there and allowed everything to happen, not fighting or figuring out clues like she usually would.

Until the day her body decided to move forward.

Adora opened her eyes slowly to find a sea of white and pink on the ceiling above her. Adora tried to sit up but found her muscles still too weak to perform the action.

"Adora!" A female voice cried out.

Adora tilted her head and saw Angella rush to her side.

"Adora! How are you feeling? Are you alright?"

Adora tried to speak but only managed a quiet mumble. She glanced to the night table next to her and pointed at the pitcher and glass sitting on top.

"Oh right of course!"

Angella grabbed the pitcher off the nightstand and poured the water into the glass.

Angella placed her hand behind Adora's head as she poured the contents of the glass into her mouth. Adora slowly swallowed the water before the glass was empty.

"How…long…have I been out?" Adora asked, her voice starting to gain back its strength.

"About three days," Angella replied as she set the glass and pitcher back on the table. "I can't tell you how much I've worried about your well being."

"Quite a lot huh?" Adora asked.

Angella sighed. "I haven't left your side since you've been here."

Adora groaned as she placed a hand against her forehead.

"God what even happened?" Adora asked.

Angella smiled softly as she placed her hand gently against Adora's face. "A bad dream Adora, but it's over now. Thanks to Catra."

Adora's eyes bulged so much that Angella thought they would pop out of their sockets.

"Catra?! Did she make it out of the cave? Is she safe? Did she say anything about me? Or…"

Angella placed her hand on Adora's shoulder. "Catra's fine. She managed to escape the caverns along with the others. She's currently still in the prison down below, along with Scorpia and Entrapta."

Adora sighed as she laid her head against the pillow. She allowed her eyes to close as she tried to slow her rapid heartbeat.

"You love her don't you?"

Adora's heart nearly went into cardiac arrest.

"WHAT?! Who told you that? I mean…that's not true. We've known each other…but…I don't…well I mean…she's…"

Adora stopped herself as Angella placed her hand against Adora's cheek. Adora slowly looked back into Angella's eyes and was surprised to find understanding instead of loathing.

"How…how did you find out?" Adora asked.

Angella chuckled. "I mean you no offence Adora, but your skills at acting like Catra isn't the world to you are severely lacking."

Adora glanced down at the floor but was surprised to find her face being lifted by Angella's other hand to meet her eyes yet again.

"Adora…when I first began dating Micah, everyone thought of me as crazy for even considering the idea. They'd bring up such trivial matters such as the fact that I was far taller than him or that immortal beings should leave marriage to mortal beings."

Adora's face dropped. "But…you're the queen…taking behind your back is like…illegal."

Angella smiled. "No position of power is immune to criticism, Adora."

Adora felt a smile slowly creep onto her face.

"Adora," Angella continued. "Love's not about what makes other people happy, it's about what makes a single person happy. I and Micah had different personalities. We sometimes clashed in the war room over battle strategies or whether Glimmer should learn magic at an early age, but at the end of the day, we always looked at each other and thanked the First One's that we came together like we did. We didn't hide from our flaws or past mistakes; we embraced them and moved forward. We didn't care about what other people said of our relationship, we were simply happy being together. And if you give yourself the chance Adora… I'm sure you and Catra would feel the same way too."

Adora sighed before she felt her shoulders become lighter. "So this means that Catra can stay in BrightMoon?"

The smile vanished off the queen's face. "I still must converse with the council…"

"Your majesty," Adora felt her heart race again. "Catra helped save me and Etheria from a terrible fate! She's seen the error of her ways, just like I did. You could've just seen me as a Horde soldier even after I became She-Ra but you didn't! You saw me for who I really was! Can't you just see that with Catra?" Adora bit her lip. "I…I love her."

Adora felt her shoulders become light as air as she finally admitted her love for the damaged Magicat. She shut her eyes and prepared herself for the inevitable lecture about why she was wrong or why she should never love an enemy. But instead, Adora was surprised to find herself surrounded by the queen's wings.

"Oh child," Angella whispered. "I know how much Catra means to you. But I still have a role to fulfill as the queen. And that includes discussing whether someone is truly willing to swear allegiance to the rebellion."

Adora would have protested further but she was stopped by Angella's hand on her face.

"Adora, you've had an undeniably terrifying ordeal. I want the practitioners to keep an eye on you for observance overnight. Our decision won't be announced until tomorrow evening."

"But I feel fine now!" Adora argued as she tried to lift herself up before she collapsed on the bed. "Ok, maybe the muscles are a little soft right now."

Angella smiled before she kissed Adora's forehead. "Get some rest. I'll be back to check on you in a while, along with Glimmer and Bow."

Adora sighed as she lay back on the bed, hoping that sleep would overcome her before her anxiety did.

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Adora still couldn't understand how everyone in the meeting room couldn't hear her heart beating faster and faster.

Currently, Adora was standing next to Bow, Glimmer, the other princesses, SeaHawk, Swift Wind, several guards and council members from across Etheria.

Catra, Scorpia and Entrapta stood in the center of the room, their heads cast down towards the floor.

"Force Captain Catra, Scorpia and Princess Entrapta," Angella began. "You are here to face judgment from the council based on your actions both past and present."

Catra and Entrapta simply nodded. Scorpia managed to choke out a quiet: "Yes, Ma'am."

"Your crimes include: treason, destruction of the Whispering Woods, full frontal assault on BrightMoon castle, numerous attempts at conquering Etheria and infecting Adora with Shadow Weaver's data crystal which nearly caused her to corrupt the entire planet."

Catra turned her attention from the floor towards Adora.

"Anytime you want to jump in here Adora." The look in her eyes said.

"However, because of your heroic efforts to save Etheria, eradicating the crystal and a high recommendation from Adora, Glimmer, Bow and surprisingly enough Perfuma…the council has decided…to welcome you into the rebellion."

Adora nearly fell over in shock. The other princesses gave out startled gasps as Angella stood up, walked down the stairs from

her throne and approached the former Horde trio.

"Princess Entrapta, do you promise to swear allegiance to the rebellion once again? To ensure that your talents are not spent on the wrong side?

Entrapta glanced up and saw Perfuma slowly nodding her head.

"I do…I see what's more important now." Entrapta replied.

"Scorpia," Angella continued. "Do you promise to swear allegiance for the rebellion? To stand with us against the ones you once served?"

Scorpia nodded. "Wherever Catra goes, I go."

Angella turned towards Catra. "Force Captain Catra?"

Catra winced when she heard her former title.

"Do you swear allegiance to the rebellion? To right the wrongs you have committed and to ensure that the rest of Etheria does not fall to anymore of the Horde's insidious plans?"

Catra paused for a moment. This was it, a chance to change who she was, how she appeared to the world. But that voice in the back of her head, which sounded eerily similar to Shadow Weaver, whispered: "They'll still hate you. No matter what you do for them, they'll still see you as the remorseless Horde soldier that tried to destroy everything. You might as well turn back now and strike them while they're guard is down."

Catra looked back at Adora. The latter gave the former a gentle smile and nodded, her eyes radiating nothing but pure admiration.

At that point, nothing else seemed to matter.

"Yes," Catra replied, the words coming easier than she thought they would. "I swear allegiance to BrightMoon and for a chance to fight alongside Adora."

"Then rise."

The three women did as told.

"I hereby accept you as honorary members of the Rebellion!"

The other princesses cheered, with Adora and Perfuma in competition over who could scream the loudest.

Entrapta had barely enough time to face the crowd before she felt several arms wrap around her.

"Welcome back Entrapta!" Perfuma cried.

"Try and not to befriend anymore robots kay?" Mermista asked with a smile.

"NO PROMISES!" Entrapta cried as she wrapped her arms around Perfuma.

Entrapta stopped and blushed as she realized what she had done.

"Oh Perfuma I'm sorry I got in your personal space! Oh I'll never get the fundamentals of how to act in social situations or what to say or…"

Perfuma's finger on her lips stopped Entrapta cold.

"Entrapta," Perfuma smiled. "Stop talking."

And before Entrapta could even blink, she felt Perfuma's warm lips press against her own. Perfuma's pigtails shot straight into the air as she closed her eyes and leaned deeper into the kiss. For once, Entrapta listened to her gut instinct and decided to just enjoy the moment.

Once they pulled away, Entrapta let out a small giggle. "Wow… that was…"

"Fascinating?" Perfuma slyly replied.

Entrapta smiled widely. "Or of the many positive adjectives I could've thought of. It's giving me this warm, fuzzy sort of feeling."

Perfuma laughed. "It's called love Entrapta."

Entrapta smiled before her cheeks became a deep crimson. "Can I…have more of this…"

"Love?" Perfuma replied as she took the inventors arm. "I thought you'd never ask."

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Scorpia smiled as she saw Entrapta walking away with Perfuma, looking happier than she could remember the genius ever being.

Scorpia felt someone tug at her claws. Looking down, she saw Frosta looking up at her in wonderment.

"Are those actual claws? Can you crush rocks with them? How do you do your hair?" Frosta's questions came out faster than a Horde tank's laser blasts.

Scorpia laughed however. "You…you're not afraid of me?"

"Are you kidding?" Frosta asked. "You're so tall and strong and awesome the way you just climbed into that cavern. I wish I could be as cool as you! Can you crush something in your claws for me?"

Scorpia laughed again as she scooped the child into her arms.

"You know snow queen; I think this is the start of a beautiful friendship.

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Adora allowed for various people to come up to her and say how thankful they were to have her back on their side. But while her

mind was preoccupied with the people around her, her eyes were scanning the crowd for one person in particular.

Adora finally caught sight of Catra. She was at the far back of the room, her hand on one of the giant doors. As if she could sense when she was being watched, Catra turned and looked into Adora's eyes.

Though her smile was one of content, her eyes seemed to hide something else…almost like a mix of guilt and sadness.

Before Adora could even step forward, Catra pushed open the door and ran from the room. Adora excused herself from the others as she raced out of the room, ignoring the several shouts of protest from behind her.

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Adora grunted as she scaled down another rock.

Despite her best efforts to catch up with Catra, the feline humanoid had proven too fast.

"Some things never change," Adora thought as she tried to pinpoint where Catra could've gone.

"Catra always went to the highest point in the Fright Zone when she wanted to be alone…so maybe…"

Adora spotted a high cliff in the distance with a lone figure on top. Adora turned her sword into a grappling hook gun and shot it into the air. Once the hook had reached the top, and she gave it a quick tug to ensure it was secure, Adora started the long climb up. She almost expected to see Catra come to the edge to see what was going on, or to taunt her like she used to do back in the Fright Zone. But the young Magicat made no appearance.

Once Adora reached the top, she changed her sword back to normal and turned her head.

Catra sat on the edge of the cliff. Her knees were brought up to her chest and her tail was curled around her body like a security blanket.

"Well," Adora began, trying to break the tension. "Seems like you're settling into BrightMoon just fine. You've already found a place to mope."

Catra didn't answer.

"Hey…uh…I just wanted to talk," Adora said.

"Well…talk away because I got nothing to say," Catra replied.

Adora snorted. "Oh yeah, saving the world from a horrible fate, destroying Shadow Weaver and becoming a part of the rebellion is not worth talking about."

Adora laughed but Catra didn't return the gesture.

"Catra…are you okay?"

"Stop it Adora."

Adora froze. "Stop what?"

Catra finally turned her head to face Adora, with fire in her eyes. "THIS! Trying to be nice to me after all I've done."

Adora took a few steps forward. "Catra I was just…"

"Adora, I've tried to kill you several times, left you to die in that temple, nearly destroyed all of BrightMoon and infected you with a virus that nearly caused the whole world to end. I don't deserve sympathy from anyone! And…and…" Catra looked down at her hands. "It's all my fault."

Catra flopped back down on the ground and turned her back on Adora as she stared at the waterfall coursing down the nearby rocks.

"Catra?" Adora asked as she sat down next to Catra and placed a hand on her shoulder.

"I should've gone with you back at Thymore…I should've never blamed you for everything bad that happened to me. I should've been blaming Shadow Weaver for making me so unhappy…for making me into this…this…"

Adora slowly rubbed Catra's shoulder. "She's gone now Catra. She won't ever hurt us again. Don't you feel happy?"

Catra sighed. "I do…it's just…"

Catra hissed as she shut her eyes.

"Catra what is it?"

"Adora…I…I…"

"Catra it's okay just take your time to get out what you need…"

"CHANGE! I'M AFRAID OF CHANGE ALRIGHT?!"

The silence between the two women was deeper than the ocean.

"Change?" Adora asked, raising an eyebrow.

Catra felt her eyes become misty. "I always planned our lives out. You and me…we were going to rule over the Fright Zone…call the shots and maybe…maybe…"

"Get together?" Adora asked as a sly smile crossed her smile.

Catra tried to remain stoic but the blush on her cheeks told Adora otherwise.

"Grow closer as friends. Anyway…" Catra sighed. "Then you became a giant sword lady, left for your princess friends and suddenly I was thrown into a situation I never expected. It was too much change for me and…it scared me. And…I was angry at

you for changing the plan instead of just staying with me and making me happy."

Adora wrapped her arm around Catra. "Catra…even if I did stay with you…you would have never been truly happy."

Catra snapped her head towards Adora. "Don't you dare say that Adora! You were my whole world, no universe! And you're saying that waking up next to you wouldn't have brightened my whole outlook on life?"

"Shadow Weaver and Hordak would've still been around us in one way or another. And I know…how horribly Shadow Weaver treated you and how Hordak ultimately saw you as nothing more than a pawn. But now…Shadow Weaver's gone for good and you're no longer under Hordak's thumb. And you're still going to be with me! How can that not make you happy?"

Catra was just about to reply when she stopped herself and actually took the time to gather her thoughts. Her heartbeat wasn't as fast anymore, her breathing was deeper and more even and she and Adora were actually having a conversation that didn't involve threats or violence.

"Yeah," Catra felt herself smile for the first time in an eternity. "I… I am happier here." The smile soon vanished. "But I get the feeling that no one's gonna trust me after what I've done."

"Some people still don't trust me after what I've done for the rebellion," Adora replied.

Catra's eyes widened. "You? But…you're She-Ra! You've saved everyone in BrightMoon from the horde and you do good deeds all the time."

Adora gave a small smile. "And yet I still hear whispers from the guards and certain townspeople who say that I'm just a spy for the Horde, waiting for the perfect moment to strike."

"Man, people in BrightMoon make Kyle look like Entrapta," Catra replied before she began to giggle. It didn't take long for her giggle to evolve into full blown laughter.

Before long, Adora found herself laughing loudly too. Whether it was because of what Catra said that was making her laugh, or the fact that seeing Catra laugh made her laugh, Adora allowed herself to simply enjoy the moment. When Adora settled down, she wiped one of her eyes before she took Catra's hands into her own.

"Catra…not everyone will like you."

"Has anyone ever told you that you suck at giving advice?" Catra replied.

"Can I finish?" Adora asked before Catra shrugged.

"But it doesn't matter what others think! The important thing is… you're still in my life! You've recognized all the terrible things you've done and are willing to make amends for them! You still will have people that care for you, respect you and will be willing to do anything to make you happy! Just like…me."

Adora wiped away the tear that Catra didn't know she had.

"I…I love you Catra. And that is definitely one thing that's never going to change."

She wasn't sure which one made the move first, but all Catra knew was the sensation of Adora's lips on her own. Catra's mind went into cloud nine as they felt their tongues move around in a kind of erotic dance. Her arms found their way onto Adora's back before she felt Adora's arms on her back as well.

At that moment, nothing else mattered to Catra. Every worry and every thought faded out of existence. She just felt like: yes this is where she needed to be. The whole planet could've blown up and she wouldn't give a damn

Cursing the need to breathe again, Catra pulled away and opened her eyes to find Adora with the deepest blush she had ever seen on the blonde.

"That was…wow," Adora breathed.

"Yeah…didn't know you had it in you," Catra replied with a smirk. "Going all out with the tongue on the first date."

Adora playfully smacked Catra's arm as Catra burst out laughing.

"You are the worst!" Adora tried to sound anger but couldn't hide the playfulness in her voice.

Catra collapsed into Adora's arms with a huge smile. "Gotta love me."

Adora gave a happy sigh as she wrapped her arms around Catra. "Yeah…I guess I'll just have to learn to live with it."

"Just like how I'm gonna have to deal with your dumb jock energy."

"Do you want me to throw you off this cliff?"

"Meh, cats always land on their feet anyway."

"I really hope your mouth doesn't get you in trouble with the locals around here Cat."

"I thought you said it didn't matter who liked me and who didn't?"

"Yes but I'd appreciate it if you could come home every night without getting into a fight."

"Yeah I'd hate to meet the person that took a look at my claws and teeth and said: Oh wow that looks like someone I want to mess with!"

Adora could've continued with the playful argument but decided to simply allow a moment of peace between the two of them.

A comfortable silence fell between the two as they gazed out over the ocean as the afternoon moons began to set, turning the ocean into a sea of diamonds.

Adora moved her hand behind Catra's left ear and began to scratch the area. Almost immediately Catra began to purr, a sound that Adora thanked the First Ones she could hear again now and forever more.

"Love you forever Catra."

"Love you beyond forever Adora."

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Unbeknownst to them, the other princesses, along with Bow and SeaHawk, watched the scene from a distance.

"About damn time," Glimmer remarked.

"It's so beautiful," Bow cried.

"She…and Catra…huh?" Frosta struggled to find the words.

"Guess we rubbed off on them," Perfuma said as she held Entrapta close.

"Yeah, I called it from like day one," Mermista replied as she outstretched her hand. "SeaHawk you owe me a pearl necklace."

Chapter End Notes

And that's a wrap!

Gotta say this story's been one hell of a ride! I'm honestly blown away by how many people have looked at it, commented on it and even left favs on it! I thank each and every one of you for giving me the courage and encouragement I needed to keep going on! It means everything to me!

And I hope to continue writing more She-Ra stories in the future! Hopefully the new seasons can provide me with some inspiration! But hopefully this little bit of Catra/Adora fluff is enough to get you through the hiatus madness of waiting for Season 4.

Peace!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!